

NUMBERS

PREFACE.

This fourth Book of Moses is called Numbers, because it begins with the numbering of the people. The Hebrews, from its first words, call it Vaydedabber. It contains the transactions of the Israelites, from the second month of the second year after their going out of Egypt, until the beginning of the eleventh month of the 40th year; that is, a history almost of thirty-nine years.

Ch. --- In the nine first chapters various orders of people are described, and several laws are given or repeated. From the 10th to the 33d, the marches and history of God's people are related; (H.) from the 20th of the second month, in the second year after their departure out of Egypt, till the eleventh month of the 40th year, and the last of Moses: so that this Book contains the transactions of almost thirty-nine years; (T.) whereas, the Book of Leviticus specified only some of the laws and occurrences of one month. Here we behold what opposition Moses experienced from Aaron and his sister, from Core, and from all the people; and yet God protected him, in the midst of all dangers, and confounded, not only their attempts, but those also of Balaam, and of all his external foes. H. --- Moses conquers the Madianites, and divides the conquered country between the tribes of Ruben, Gad, and half of the tribe of Manasses. In the three last chapters, he describes the land of Chanaan, orders all the inhabitants to be exterminated, assigns cities for the Levites, and for refuge; and forbids such marriages, as might cause any confusion in the distribution of the lands belonging to each tribe. Moses composed this part of the Pentateuch, as well as that of Deuteronomy, a little while before his death, out of the memoirs which he had carefully preserved. C. --- According to Usher, the people were numbered this second time, A.M. 2514, C.

i.; after which they leave the desert of Sinai, (C. x. 11.) go to Cadesbarne, and return thither again 2552. Soon after this, Mary and Aaron die; Moses lifts up the brazen serpent; and the Hebrews take possession of part of the promised land (2553) on the eastern banks of the Jordan.

That on the western side, flowing with milk and honey, was conquered by Josue in the following years. H.

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CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. First day of the second month, called after the captivity, Jiar, which party corresponds with our April. These injunctions were given from the tabernacle, (C.) in the desert, the 12th station, (H.) at the foot of Mount Sinai.

Ver. 2. Houses. The families consisted of the immediate descendants of the 12

patriarchs; the houses were from the subdivisions of these. The same plan of numbering the people was adopted on other occasions. Jos. viii. 16. 1 K. x. 20.

--- Sex, between 20 and 60 years of age. All the subjects of the Eastern kings may be called upon, if they be able to bear arms; and hence we find such immense armies in the Scripture, and in profane history. Moses numbered the people once before, (Ex. xxx. 2,) and found exactly the same number of warriors, the dead being replaced by others, during the space of seven months. Perhaps the odd numbers might not be specified, as all the totals consist of so many exact hundreds, except that of the tribe of Gad, v. 25. On the former occasion, the people were not perhaps ranged according to their tribes, which was now deemed necessary, as they army was going to begin its march under its respective leaders. C.

Ver. 3. Arms, (fortium). "Strong or brave." The psalmist (civ. 37,) says, there was not one feeble. M. --- Troops. Heb. "army." Sept. "force." Their officers shall be at their head, and shall assist you in the work. Some might command 1000, others 100, and some only 50. See Ex. xiii.

18. xviii. 21. --- Princes; the first-born, or most ancient, (Lyran.) the lineal descendants of the patriarchs; (Jansen) or, in fine, such as were chosen for their merit, as all were equally noble; and hence Nahasson, prince of Juda, is mentioned, though he was not a descendant of the eldest son of Juda, but of Phares; and those who were at the head of

those who were numbered a little before the death of Moses, were not the descendants of these. C. xxvi. 64. In effect, we find that Moses chose for his council, able men out of all Israel. Ex.

xviii. 25. Bonfrere. C.

Ver. 14. Duel. Hebrew Dehuel. But (C. ii. 14,) we find the word begins R, as the Septuagint have read, Ragouel. H.

Ver. 16. Army. Heb. "of a thousand." The Vulg. commonly styles them tribunes.

They were

"people of name in the assembly," as the Heb. indicates. C.

Ver. 26. Juda. This tribe was the most numerous. But it is not here placed first, because the order of birth in Lia's children is observed. Then come those of Rachel; and last of all, the children of the two handmaids, Bala and Zelpha. H.

Ver. 47. Levites. As they attended the tabernacle, like God's peculiar servants, and were not obliged to go forth to battle, it was not necessary to number them with the rest. C. --- They might, however, fight if they thought proper, as the Machabees did. See Josep. Ant. iii. 11. iv. 4. T.

Ver. 51. Stranger, even of any other tribe. S. Aug. q. 3. W.

Ver. 52. Army. Heb. "they shall have law was already in force, and probably all such precepts were observed as were not incompatible with the wandering state of the Hebrews. C.

Ver. 20. Curiosity. Sept. "suddenly." Let them not rush in before all the vessels be properly covered. The priests folded them up with all haste, that they might see them as little as possible themselves. C.

Ver. 23. Thirty. Sept. "25," as v. 3. C. --- They began to be taught how to act, at 25; but did not officiate till 30. D.

Ver. 26. All things. Heb. "veils round the altar" of holocausts in the court. C.

Ver. 27. Assigned. Heb. "you shall count over to them what they have to carry."

Sept. "you shall call (the Levites) by name, and all that shall be intrusted to them," v. 32. C. --- From the different offices of the priests

and Levites in the old law, Innocent III. takes occasion to shew the distinction of the orders in the Christian Church. De S. Altar. 2. ad 7.

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CHAPTER V.

Ver. 2. Camp; in the midst of which God had fixed his tabernacle. See Lev. xvi.

16. Some pretend that these unclean persons were only excluded from the camp of the Lord, and from that of the Levites, which occupied 2000 cubits round the tabernacle. But God will not permit any of the camp to be defiled by such people. They were to absent themselves for seven days, and then wash themselves, &c. C. xix. 11. If lepers be excluded from the camp, how much more do heretics deserve to be cast out of the Church! Theod. q. 8. W.

Ver. 3. It. Heb. "their camps, in the midst of which I dwell." C.

Ver. 6. To commit, against one another, v. 7. S. Aug. q. 9. When the thing is secret, so that the judges cannot take cognizance of it, the offender must nevertheless abide by the decision of the priest. Moses condemns him who had stolen an ox to restore it with another, or even to give five oxen, if he have not the one stolen in his possession. Ex. xxii. 1. 4. H. --- Here to reward the sincerity of the man, who confesses his private fault, he only requires the thing itself to be restored, with a fifth part besides. C. --- Negligence, not with contempt; (M.) though he knows that he is transgressing the divine and natural law. T.

Ver. 7. Shall confess. This confession and satisfaction, ordained in the old law, was a figure of the sacrament of penance. Ch. --- A special confession of their sin, with satisfaction, and a sacrifice, are required. So Christ orders us to lay open our consciences to his priests. S. John.

xx., &c. W.

Ver. 8. But if. Moses does not mention this case. Lev. vi. 2, 5. Here he determines that the heirs, if known, must be entitled to the restitution. A Hebrew could not die without an heir; but a proselyte might, and then restitution was to be made to God. The Rabbins say, that when the

person injured was already dead, the offender took 10 persons with him to the grave of the deceased, and said, "I have sinned against the Lord and against N.; I have injured him thus. "

After which he gave what was due to his heirs; or, if none could be found, to the house of judgment or the judges, who might restore it, if any claimant appeared afterwards.

Ver. 9. First-fruits; (*teruman*,) a term which comprises also voluntary oblations of all sorts, and the parts of the victims which belong to the priests; unless the person offering expressed a different intention. C.

Ver. 14. The spirit of jealousy, &c. This ordinance was designed to clear the innocent, and to prevent jealous husbands from doing mischief to their wives: as likewise to give all a horror of adultery, by punishing it in so remarkable a manner. Ch. --- The spirit of jealousy, of fear, &c.

denotes those passions of the soul. This very remarkable law of Moses suited the genius of his people, (C.) and tended greatly to restrain the infidelity of the married couple, and the fury of suspicious husbands. Theod. q. 10. God was pleased, by a continual miracle, to manifest the truth, on this occasion, provided the husband were not also guilty: for in that case, the Rabbins assert, the waters had no effect. They relate many particularities, which seem contrary to Philo and Josephus, who inform us that the trial was still made in their time, though the former writers pretend that it was disused, on account of the many adulteries which were committed, in the age preceding the destruction of the temple by Titus. They say that the person who had committed the crime with the woman, died at the same time that the bitter waters put an end to her existence.

When the suspected person was brought before the Sanhedrim, they tried, by all means, to extort a confession from her. But if she persisted in maintaining her innocence, they made her stand in black, before the eastern gate of the court, denouncing to her what she had to expect. If she answered Amen, the priest wrote the imprecations (ver. 19-22,) on vellum, with ink, which had no mixture of vitriol in it; and taking water from the laver, and dust from the court, with something bitter, like

wormwood, effaced the writing in a new earthen vessel; while another priest tore her garments as far as the breast, and tied them up with an Egyptian cord, to remind her of the miracles wrought by God.

If she confessed the crime before the writing was effaced, she was to be repudiated, without any dowry; or, if she kept company with a suspected person, contrary to her husband's admonition, after she had come off victorious from drinking the bitter waters, she was subjected to the same punishment, and could not demand to be admitted any more to make the miraculous experiment. See Selden, Uxor. iii. 13.

Ver. 15. Measure, (sati). Heb. and Sept. "epha," of which the measure was only one-third. C. ---

Oil, &c. These were rejected in sacrifices for sin. Lev. v. 11. Jealous husbands have no sentiments of commiseration, or of sweetness; (H.) nor can any experience the emotions of joy, while they are in such a situation. T.

Ver. 17---18. Holy water, destined for sacred uses, which is called most bitter, v.

18, (M.) and cursed, (v. 22,) on account of the imprecations used to detect the guilty. W. --- Earth, to shew the woman, that if she had been unfaithful, she deserved to be trodden upon as dung. Ecclus. ix. 10.

--- Head, that she may remember all is naked before the Lord. M. --- Heb. may signify, "he shall cut the hair of her head," (see Lev. x. 6. C.) or take off her veil.

Joseph. iii. 10. H. ---

Remembrance, by which God was requested to manifest the truth, either by punishing or by rewarding the woman, v. 15, 28. M. --- Bitter, either on account of the wormwood, or because of their effects on the guilty. C.

Ver. 19. Adjure. The woman was put to her oath. Josephus. H.

Ver. 21. Curse. Heb. "an object of execration, and an oath," &c. so that people can wish no greater misfortune to befall any one, than what thou shalt endure.

H.

Ver. 22. Amen. Our Saviour often uses this form, to confirm what he says, verily, truly. The woman gives her assent to what had been proposed, "so be it." C.

Ver. 23. Book. Heb. sepher, may also denote a board covered with wax, which was used as one of the most ancient modes of writing. C. --- Josephus says, the priest wrote the name of God on parchment, and washed it out in the bitter waters.

Ver. 24. Up. Heb. "and the water, which causeth the malediction, shall enter into her, bitter."

According to Josephus, the jealous husband threw first a handful of the gomer of barley flour, upon the altar, and gave the rest to the priest; and after the other ceremonies were finished, the woman drunk the water, and either had a son within ten months, or died with the marks of infamy.

B. iii. 11. Edit. Bern. Some Rabbins say she became livid and rotten, though she might linger on part of the year. Sotæ iii. But if she proved innocent, she acquired fresh beauty and health, and was delivered with ease of a son.

Maimon. H.

Ver. 27. Through her. Heb. "into her," exerting all their efficacy.

Ver. 28. Children, that her husband may love her the more, and she may receive some compensation, for the stain thrown upon her character. M. --- We do not read in Scripture that any was ever subjected to this trial. The method of giving a bill of divorce was more easy. C.

Ver. 31. Blameless. To act in conformity with God's injunctions could not be reprehensible. But it would have been certainly criminal to tempt God in this manner, in order to discover a secret offence, if he had not authorized it expressly. If the husband wished to avoid the displeasure of God, he was bound to banish from his heart all malice, rash judgments, &c. The permission here granted, was owing to the hardness of heart of this stiff-necked people, as well as the laws regarding divorces and retaliation. Women, being of a more fickle and suspicious temper, are not indulged with the privilege of divorcing their husbands, or of making them drink the waters of jealousy. But if a man were taken in the act of adultery, he was put to death, Leviticus xx. 10.

The crime is equal in both parties. "The husband, says Lactantius, (de V. Cultu.

xxiii.) ought, by the regularity of his conduct, to shew his wife what she owes him. For it is very unjust to exact from another, what you do not practise yourself. This injustice is the cause of the disorders, into which married women sometimes fall. They are vexed at being obliged to continue faithful to those, who will not be so to them." The Romans would not allow wives to bring an action against their husbands. "You would kill, with impunity, your wife taken in adultery, without any trial, said Cato, and she would not dare to touch you with her finger, if you fell into the same crime."

Gell. x. 23. The authority which was given to husbands over their wives, was deemed a sufficient restraint; and men being obliged to be often from home, and in company, would have been exposed to continual alarms, from the suspicious temper of their wives, if they had been subjected to the like trials.

C. --- In latter ages, however, the Jewish ladies began to assume the right of divorcing their husbands, in imitation of Salome, sister of Herod the great, and of Herodias, his grand-daughter. Matt. xiv. 3. Josep. Ant. xv. 11. xviii. 7. Grotius supposes that the Samaritan woman had divorced her five husbands. Jo. iv.

18. But this being contrary to the law, her first marriage alone subsisted. H. ---

Her iniquity, in giving her husband any grounds of suspicion.

The Rabbins observe, that he was bound first to admonish her, before witnesses, not to keep company with people of bad character; and if he could bring witnesses that she had been found afterwards with them for ever so short a time, he might have the remedy of the law. The pagans maintained, that several of their fountains and rivers had the power of disclosing and punishing perjury. Polemon mentions a fountain of this nature in Sicily; and Solinus (C.

xi.) says, that one in Sardinia caused the perjured to go blind. The waters of the Styx were greatly feared on this account. Hesiod, Theog. 783. Tatitus (vii.

20,) mentions some other fountains, which had the same effects as the bitter waters. C. --- The various ordeal trials which were formerly in use, were probably established in imitation of this law of Moses; but not having the same authority or sanction, they were in danger of being looked upon as superstitious. H.

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CHAPTER VI.

Ver. 2. Sanctified, and separated from the common sort of people, and obliged to observe abstinence like the Nazarites, as the Heb. intimates in one word, nazir. All this was done to acquire greater sanctity and perfection. Sept.

"whoever has made a great vow to be very pure to the Lord," and intends thus to signalize his zeal for God's glory. The original term means also to distinguish oneself by a wonderful thing. There were Nazarites for life, like Samson and S. John the Baptist; and others for a limited time, like S. Paul.

Their abstinence from wine, &c. lasted generally for a month, and was to be performed at Jerusalem. Those of the female sex could not bind themselves by vow till they were ten years and a day old, nor boys before they were full 13.

C. --- The custom of cutting the hair, in honour of some god, was very common among the pagans; and S. Cyril (de ador. 16,) seems to think that the Hebrews had seen it practised in Egypt, and that Moses judged it expedient to let them do so for the sake of the true God, in order to divert their minds from giving way to superstition. C. --- The Hebrews made vows to abstain from wine for 30

days, and then to offer sacrifices, and to cut their hair, when they were attacked by any dangerous illness. Josep. Bel. ii. 15. S. Paul perhaps made a vow of this nature, in the perils of the sea. Acts xviii. 11. Spencer, Rit. iii. 6.

Juvenal alludes to this custom, when he observes, that sailors with their heads shaved, delight in safety to recount the dangers to which they have been exposed:

Gaudent ubi vertice raso,

Garrula securi narrare pericula Nautæ. (Sat. ii.)

Ver. 3. Drunk. Heb. shecar, may signify old or palm wine. Lev. x. 9. --- Drink.

Heb. "of shecar," which was a clear wine, with perhaps a mixture of sugar. ---

Vinegar was a common beverage among the ancients. Plin. xiv. 16. Ruth ii. 14.

The soldiers gave our Saviour some of theirs to drink. The Turks, who are not allowed to drink wine of the grape, make use of various other sorts of made wine. --- Grape, or the liquor procured from grapes, with a mixture of water, after they have served already to make wine. This liquor is called secondary wine by the Greeks, (M.) being designed for labourers in winter. Varro 54, and Columella xii. 40. Grapes of every description are forbidden to the Nazarites, as they either tend to inebriate, or at least are too luxurious. H. --- God deigns to give those a rule who voluntarily consecrate themselves to his service.

"What do the Nazarites designate, but the life of those who abstain, and are continent."

S. Greg. Mor. xxxii. 23. W.

Ver. 4. Kernel, or stone. Neither the inside nor the outside must be eaten.

Ver. 5. Grow. At the commencement, and at the end of the Nazariteship, the hair was cut; though perhaps a sort of crown was left at the top of the head, as the 7th verse may be rendered, "the crown of his God," &c. C. --- The Nazarite is under the same regulations with the high priest, with respect to any corpse, v. 6. Maimon. More, p. 3. Lev. xxi. 11. Both were consecrated to God in the most perfect manner. M. --- When the hair of Samson was cut off, he immediately lost his supernatural strength. Jud. xvi.

Ver. 6. Dead. To teach us that those who are consecrated to God, ought to abstain from the works of death. H.

Ver. 9. Day. That none might escape; (Theod. q. 11) though the Heb. may imply that the hair was only shaved on the ninth day, when he was to be purified. C.

xix. 12. Then the Nazarite had to begin again, as if he had done nothing, (C.) if his vow were only for a time. Those who had taken a vow for life never shaved.

Ver. 11. Sinned. Contracting a legal uncleanness. --- That day, and commence his vow. M.

Ver. 13. He. The priest.

Ver. 18. Fire, on the altar, where the ram has been sacrificed. Abulensis.

Lyranus thinks it was burnt on the fire, with which the meat was boiled. M.

Chaldee. T. --- The Sept., Philo. &c.

understand it in the former sense; and Theodoret says the consecrated hair was placed upon the victim on the fire. C.

Ver. 20. Priest, contrary to what was required in other sacrifices. Josep. iv. 4.

Both the priest and the Nazarite waved the sacrifice towards the four quarters of the world.

Ver. 21. Mind. If he have vowed any thing more, he must perform it. H.

Ver. 23. Sons. The three forms of benediction for the high priests, have all the same meaning, and they might choose which they pleased. Grotius observes, that they pronounced them aloud standing, with their hands lifted up. The books of Moses are the ritual of the priests.

Ver. 25. Show. Heb. "make his face shine," joyful and serene, (C.) like a light to direct thy steps.

Ps. lxvi. 2.

Ver. 26. Turn. With loving mercy, may he comfort and protect thee. M.

Ver. 27. Invoke. Heb. "they shall name my name (Yehovah, in pronouncing blessings) upon the sons of Israel," which I will ratify. H. - -- "They shall place the blessing of my name," &c. Chal.

They shall praise my name. C. --- God authorizes us to use a determinate form of blessing, and grants the effect, when his minister pronounces it, (W.) if no obstacle be put by the party. H.

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CHAPTER VII.

Ver. 1. The day. The second of the second month, the year after the Hebrews left Egypt. We might read this chapter immediately after the 10th of Leviticus.

Ver. 3. Covered. Destined to carry some parts of the tabernacle. C. --- The Sept.

use a term which, according to Hesychius, denotes the chariots in which people of quality travelled, Lampenes. M.

Ver. 8. Four. The sons of Merari were not very numerous, (C. iv. 44,) and they had the heaviest parts of the tabernacle to carry. The metal alone would weigh 274,875 Roman pounds, of 12

ounces each; not to mention the pillars, &c. If 100 waggons carried each 3000

pounds, and every man 50, they would not carry one half; so that the people must have furnished them with many more waggons besides these four of the princes. Jansen. C. --- Abulensis thinks the Merarites carried all that was not laid on the four waggons. M.

Ver. 9. Serve in removing the most sacred vessels of the sanctuary. C. iv. 4. ---

Shoulders, out of respect. Yet the ark itself was placed on a cart, (2 K. vi. 3. H.) improperly. D.

Ver. 10. That day. About that time; the ceremony lasted at least twelve days, v.

84. T.

Ver. 11. Altar of holocausts, the dedication of which continued seven days. Ex.

xxix. 36. M.

Ver. 13. Dish, (acetabulum.) Heb. kaharath. See Ex. xxv. 29. This present of the prince of Juda weighed five Roman pounds. It was of silver, and consequently could not be used in the sanctuary, but in the court, (C.) at the altar of holocausts. T.

Ver. 14. Mortar. Heb. caph, which the Vulgate commonly renders phiala, "a cup," (M.) may signify a spoon for incense, as it generally accompanies the censer. 3 K. vii. 20. It means literally "the palm of the hand." The high priest took his hands full of incense on the day of expiation. Lev. xvi. 12. But on other occasions, a spoon was probably used to throw incense on the altar, or on the coals which were burning in the censers. C.

Ver. 23. Buck-goats, (hircos). The same as the he-goats given by Nahasson.

The presents of all the 12 princes are equal; and Moses mentions them in detail with equal honour. They give them according to the order in which they encamped. Juda, with his two tribes, first; then Ruben, &c.

Ver. 89. Oracle of God, whose majesty appeared, in the form of a bright cloud, upon the propitiatory, or mercy-seat. H. --- Moses is allowed to enter in quality of God's messenger, to announce his will to the people; or perhaps he heard the mandates of God, standing without the veil. D.

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CHAPTER VIII.

Ver. 2. Looketh. This candlestick stood on the south side, with one branch extending towards the altar of incense, on the east; and the other to the west, so as to give light to the loaves of proposition, on the north. Ex. xxv. 31. C. --- It was intended to illumine the holy of holies, where a sort of feast was prepared for God, and where no windows were found. M. --- Heb. simply,

"When thou lightest the lamps, the seven lamps shall give light over against,"

upon, or near to

"the candlestick." H. --- The lamps might be separated from the branches and stem of the candlestick. D.

Ver. 7. Let them be sprinkled with the water of purification. This was the holy water, mixed with the ashes of the red cow, (Num. xix.) appointed for purifying all that were unclean. It was a figure of the blood of Christ, applied to our souls by his holy sacraments. Ch. --- Purification, (lustrationis) or "expiation." The water, mixed with ashes, was taken and sprinkled round about the houses, and upon those persons who wished either to be cleansed from some defilement, or to advance in virtue and purity. We use salt instead of ashes. Theocritus (Idyl. xxiv. 100,) puts these words in the mouth of Tiresias, "then mixt with salt, according to the law, with a green branch sprinkle the honoured and pure water, and sacrifice to the supreme Jupiter a hog, if you wish to gain the victory over your adversaries." --- Flesh, to remind them that they must cut off all superfluous thoughts, the roots of which they will however never be able to destroy entirely, as S.

Greg. (Mor. v. 23,) says, "The flesh always produces superfluities, which the spirit must always cut away with the sword of solicitude." See Lev. xiv. 8. xxi.

5. 10. H. --- The priests serving in the temple were obliged to cut their hair every month; and the Levites probably observed the same regulation, to acknowledge, that they who approach God must be pure and detached from earthly cares, (C.) and particularly from the works of sin; to remind them of which, they were to be sprinkled with water, their garments washed, and they were to offer two oxen by the hands of Aaron, and to be lifted up or offered to God, to serve in his court. T.

Ver. 10. Upon them. Some of the princes performed this ceremony, to testify that they gave up the Levites to serve God, (v. 15,) and would not be answerable, if they were guilty of any irreverence or neglect. C. --- They offered them as a sort of sacrifice for the people, (M.) and gave their approbation to them, setting them at liberty. D. v. 14. 20.

Ver. 11. A gift. Heb. "he shall heave them as a heave-offering before the Lord."

Some assert, that Aaron lifted each of them towards the four quarters of the world; (v. 21,) or he made them go up towards the altar, and on each side. This ceremony was performed whenever a Levite was taken into the ministry. 2 Par.

xxix. 34.

Ver. 12. Thou, Moses, though the Heb. here seems to refer it to Aaron, "he shall." But the Sept.

and Arab. agree with the Vulg. and the context shews that Moses is the person (C.) who had chiefly to officiate. Aaron also performed his part, v. 11. H.

Ver. 14. Mine. Free from the burdens of the state, and employed in singing and keeping the doors of the sanctuary. M.

Ver. 15. Into, or "towards, about;" for the priests alone could enter in. Heb. "the Levites shall go in (or be admitted) to do the service of the tabernacle," and to remove it, &c. H. v. 19.

Ver. 21. Lifted. Hebrew tenupha, Ex. xxix. 24. Perhaps only a few were received at once. M. ---

Prayed. Hebr. means also "to expiate, or redeem," as v. 19.

Ver. 25. Serve, in any laborious functions, as the original imports.

Ver. 26. Ministers. Heb. "to watch over," (C.) direct, and "train up their brethren." Sam.

Grotius.

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CHAPTER IX.

Ver. 1. The Lord. The 15 first verses might be placed at the head of this book.

God gave orders to celebrate the first passover in the desert, about the 14th of the first month, in the second year of liberty, soon after the consecration of the tabernacle. C. --- This is the only passover which the Jews are recorded to have celebrated during the 40 years' sojournment; as they were not allowed to celebrate it, without having circumcised all the males of their family, (Ex. xii.

43,) which they could not do in the wilderness (His cuni, &c.) being uncertain how soon they would have to remove by the direction of God. H. --- First month. Hence, Moses does not always observe the order of time, as he spoke (C. i.) of what happened in the second month. D.

Ver. 3. In the. Heb. "between the two evenings." Ex. xii. 6. Sept. "towards the evening, in its season, according to its law, and determination," sugkrisin, (v.

14,) suntaxin, "arrangement;" in both places we have justifications. H. --- God's law is so called, because nothing can be done right without it. M. --- The merit of human actions depends on their conformity with the will of God; (D.) and when he gives directions, we must comply exactly. H.

Ver. 5. In Mount. Heb. "desert (or mountainous country) of Sinai" Ex. xiv. 3. C.

Ver. 6. Some. Heb. "and there was men," a solecism, rejected by the Sam. and Arab. copies.

Houbigant. --- Man. That is, by having touched, or come near, a dead body, out of which the soul was departed. Ch. --- Such were forbidden

to offer any sacrifice. Lev. xxii. 4. Yet they could not refrain from burying the dead. Philo.

de vita Mos. 3. As, therefore, the action was far from being criminal, and they had partaken of the paschal lamb without restriction in Egypt, and heard that God required all to offer this sacrifice, under pain of excision, (v. 13,) they reasonably wished to know how they were to act, particularly as the 14th of Nisan alone was appointed for this sacrifice, and they could not be purified in less than seven days. If the law, by which they were excluded from the camp, (C. v. 2,) were already published, they consulted Moses by some friend. The Rabbins suppose, that those who buried Nadab and Abiu, are meant. C. --- The common people did not properly offer a sacrifice, though they might kill the victim. D.

Ver. 10. Unclean, in what manner soever. Philo. --- Nation; or at a great distance, whether in the country or out of it. The Rabbins say 15 miles, or leagues, (C.) which make 45 miles. H. ---

Sept. all such were bound to observe the passover in the second month, as the whole people did under Ezechias; (2 Par. xxx.) though the Rabbins falsely pretend, that when the greater part of the people were under this predicament, the law did not oblige, and they might eat the paschal lamb in the month of Nisan. Women were not bound to make the second Phase. Ex. xii. 19. C. ---

This festival was never transferred beyond the second month. M.

Ver. 14. Stranger. Both the Jews who lived at a distance from the promised land, and those of other nations who had embraced their religion, were obliged to observe this law; while the uncircumcised were absolutely excluded. C.

Ver. 15. A cloud, and fire, alternately covered the tabernacle of the covenant, which was 30

cubits long and 15 broad. The pagans, perhaps, hence took occasion to accuse the Jews of adoring the clouds. Nil præter nubis & cœli Numen

adorant. Juv. Sat. xiv. C.

Ver. 16. By day. These words are omitted in the Heb.; but the context shews that they must necessarily be supplied; as they are in the Sept. The same cloud assumed different appearances.

C.

Ver. 20. For, &c. Heb. "and so it was when the cloud was days of number upon the tabernacle; by the mouth of the Lord they staid in their tents," &c. Days of number, yamim mispar, most probably means a few days; (see Deut. iv. 27,) though Louis de Dieu would translate "a full year;"

as yamim, according to him, signifies, v. 22. It is understood, however, by others, to denote a week, a month, a year, or an indeterminate number of days.

Gen. xxiv. 55.

Ver. 23. Watches, like sentinels, observing the signal of the cloud; and regulating the time and course of their marches by its direction. H.

NUMBERS 10

CHAPTER X.

Ver. 2. Two trumpets. These were probably deemed sufficient at first, though in the days of Josue there were seven, (C.) and in those of Solomon 20,000.

Josep. viii. 2. T. --- They were used for all public assemblies. Josephus (iii. 11,) says, one was sounded to call the princes together, and the other to collect the people, which is not quite conformable to the Scriptures. C.

Ver. 4. Once. Heb. "with one trumpet." If both sounded together uniformly, the people assembled, v. 7.

Ver. 5. Longer, and with interruptions. Heb. teruha, "a signal," an alarm. Sept.

"a loud cry of victory." Chal. "the taratantara," as Montanus translates, in allusion to the sound of the Hebrew word, (C.) or of the trumpets. When they were sounded with a variety of notes, or at different intervals, all knew that the camp was to break up, even though they had not been attentive to the motions of the cloud. Then Juda led the van. C. ii. 9. H.

Ver. 6. And, &c. Heb. "they shall blow an alarm for their marches." This must be referred to the camps on the west, which proceeded forward at the third sounding, as those on the north did at the fourth, according to the Sept. H.

Ver. 7. Sound. High mysteries must be reserved for the more learned. Theod. q.

15. W.

Ver. 8. Priests. God's officers and heralds. Curtius (3) observes, that among the Persians at day-break, the signal was given from the king's tent by sound of trumpet.

Ver. 9. Your God, who will reward your obedience with victory.

Ver. 10. And on. This serves to explain what kind of banquet was meant. On the festivals of religion, peace-offerings were made, of which those who were pure, might partake. H. --- On solemn and extraordinary occasions, holocausts were also presented to God by the whole nation; and the trumpets announced those public rejoicings. 2 Par. v. 12. xxix. 26. C. --- Months. The day when the moon first appeared, was a festival day among the Jews, (M.) or the first day of the month, while they observed the solar year.

Ver. 11. The second. The Samar. copy here places what we read, Deut. i. 7, 8; and it is certain that those words were addressed to Moses on this occasion, though it be not so certain that they were written by him in this place. C. --- Of the month Jiar. The Hebrews had continued near Sinai a year and 20 days.

Thence they went to the desert of Pharan, encamping first at the sepulchres of concupiscence, and at Haseroth, which were probably in that desert. Moses only specifies those encampments, where something memorable took place.

He mentions none between Asiongaber and Cades, thought the length of the journey required many. Num. xi. 34.

xiii. 1. C. --- Perhaps he only reckons those among the stations where the people continued a considerable time.

Ver. 17. It. Hence it would appear, that part of the Levites followed Juda's division, which was preceded by the priests bearing the ark, (v.

33,) while the Caathites bore the sacred vessels after Ruben, (v. 21,) and were followed by Ephraim and Gad. But Calmet observes, that the Levites, and the whole camp of the Lord, came in the middle of the four great divisions, immediately after Ruben. C. ii. 9. 17. Salien thinks, that the ark and cloud led the way, and returned to the middle at the end of the journey, v. 36. H. T.

Ver. 21. Sanctuary, or holy vessels. They never set them down, till they arrived at the place where the tabernacle was to be fixed. Hebrew may be, "the sons of Caath set forward, bearing the vessels of the sanctuary, (C.) and they (the other Levites, v. 17,) set up the boards and curtains of the tabernacle till they arrived;" that so both the vessels and the ark might be placed in proper order.

If the ark had to return into the middle of the camp from leading the way, as Salien insinuates; while it passed between the ranks of Juda, the Levites would have time to arrange every thing. H.

Ver. 29. Hobab; probably the brother of Sephora, and son of Raguel or Jethro, who had departed, leaving this son for a guide to Moses. Though God directed the marches of the Hebrews, he would not have them to neglect human means.

--- Kinsman. The Heb clothen, and Greek gambros, are not more determinate, as they signify either father, son, or brother-in-law (see Ex. ii.

18. C.); or in general a relation. S. Jerom. D.

Ver. 31. Guide, being well acquainted with the country, and consequently able to point out the best places for pasturage and for water, and to inform us what sort of people we are near. Heb.

"thou shalt serve us for eyes." Sept. "as a senator." The Persians had officers who had the title of eyes and ears of the king. Brisson 1. Some suppose that Moses stood in no need of Hobab, having lived himself in that country 40

years, with Jethro; and that he only wished to keep his kinsman with him, that he might observe the true religion. He supposed at that time that they would presently obtain possession of Chanaan. But the sins of the people caused almost all to perish in the desert. Hobab probably accepted of the proposal, as we find the Cineans, descendants of Jethro, holding a portion of the land. C.

Judg. i. 16. His posterity, the Rechabites, were noted for more than usual piety; and were the same with the Essenes, according to Serarius, and the first authors of a monastic life. Jerem. xxxv. T.

Ver. 33. Journey. During this time, we know not where they encamped. The first place that is specified is Tabera, or "the burning," (C. xi. 3. C.) which S. Jerom believes is the same place which was also called the sepulchres of concupiscence, (v. 34,) the 13th station, (H.) which is described above as the desert of Pharan. M. --- Before them. See v. 17. H. --- The Rabbins assert that there were two arks; one containing the writings of Moses going before, with the lawgiver, at the head of the army; and the other, carried by the Levites, in the centre. Drusius. ---

Calmet would rather translate "went in their presence;" that is, in the midst.

The kings of Persia always marched in the centre, for greater safety, and that they might communicate their orders with more expedition, as well as to keep all in order, and observe what was doing. Xenophon.

Cyrop. iv. and viii. Arian ii. and iii. C. --- But the ark of God would probably go before the people, with the cloud, which hung over it.

Ver. 36. Host. Sept. "Bring, or turn back, (H.) O Lord, the thousands, the myriads in Israel."

Some give the same sense to the Hebrew. C. --- Prayers are composed, not only for the obtaining of good in general, but also for particular purposes. W.

NUMBERS 11

CHAPTER XI.

Ver. 1. Fatigue. Heb. simply, "and the people were like those who complain of evil, or who seek pretexts, inwardly, in the ears of the Lord." S. Jerom explains this evil to mean the fatigue of the journey, which lasted for three days together. C. --- Hence, some who were ready to lay hold of every pretext, took occasion to murmur, and to contrast their present wearisome life with the false pleasures of Egypt. The people of that country were now desirous of returning, and prevailed upon many of the Hebrews to join with them, v. 4. H. --- They were chiefly those who were farthest from the ark, the dregs of the people; though some pretend that the uttermost part means the principal men of the camp. See Gen. xlviii. 2. "The fire devoured one part of the camp."

Sept..

Ver. 2. Up, as rain is by the earth. Amos ix. 5.

Ver. 3. The burning. Heb. tabherah. Ch. --- Calmet uses no reason for confounding this station with that mentioned, v. 34.

Ver. 4. For, seems, however, to connect the burning of some with the destruction of many more, who had eaten the quails, as if both judgments took place at the same encampment. Sept. render the Heb. "and a mixt rabble among them, desired greatly; and sitting, cried, as well as the Israelites, and said," &c. H. --- A mixt multitude. These were people that came with them out of Egypt, who were not of the race of Israel: who, by their murmuring, drew also the children of Israel to murmur: this should teach us the danger of associating ourselves with the children of Egypt; that is, with the lovers and admirers of this wicked world. Ch. --- This verse may relate a different history from the preceding ones, as the punishment was of another kind. D. --- The murmurers were burnt to death. H.

Ver. 5. Fish. The Nile abounds in fish, which they might catch freely. The fish of the lake Mœris, brought a considerable revenue to the king of Egypt. Herod. ii.

149. The Hebrews had dwelt also near the Mediterranean Sea. Fish was formerly in greater esteem than it is at present.

The priests of Egypt abstained from it, (Herod. ii. 37,) and the people from such as had scales, and from eels, because they believed they were sacred. (ib. C.

lxxii.). Porphyrius and Ovid even maintain that they refrained from all fish, as well as the Syrians. But they had not probably carried their superstition so far, in the days of Moses. --- Garlic. These things are much more delicious and wholesome in hot countries. The Greeks fed much on cucumbers and garlic.

Aristophanes. --- The Turks still delight in them, eating the former raw with sour milk, (which would be very dangerous in our climate), and onions, which are as good as our pears. Spon.

Bellon. iii. 18, &c. The wounded Machaon feasts upon onions, &c. Iliad ix. The Egyptians afterwards scrupled to eat leeks and onions. C. --- Porrum & cepe nefas violare...O sanctas gentes! quibus hæc nascuntur in hortis---Numina.

Juven. Sat. xv. But in the earlier ages Moses represents them as accustomed to such food. H.

Ver. 6. Dry, like people quite worn out for want of food. Ps. ci. 5. 12. Lamen. iv.

8. --- Nothing.

An exaggeration. We are disgusted with this light food. C. --- They wished not only for the taste, but also for the colour, of other meats. M. --- How often do we imitate their folly, when we are disgusted with the bread of life! H.

Ver. 7. Bdelium. Bdelium, according to Pliny, (l. xxi. c. 9,) was of the colour of a man's nail, white and bright; (Ch.) or like wax, (B. xii. 9,) between white and yellow. It might resemble a tarnished pearl or ivory in colour, and coriander-seed in shape.

Ver. 8. Oil; or, when unprepared, like flour and honey. Ex. xvi. 31. C.

Ver. 10. By. Heb. "for." Jonathan and others endeavour to excuse their ancestors, by saying that they wept because they were forbidden to marry their near relations. --- His tent. Some explain the Heb. of the tent of Moses.

But the Israelites more probably staid at home.

Ver. 12. Nurse. We often read of men nursing or watching over others. 4 K. x. 5.

Est. ii. 11.

Thus kings shall nurse the Church. Isai. xlix. 23. C. --- All who have authority should treat their subjects with love. M.

Ver. 14. For me. Had he not the judges, whom Jethro advised him to appoint?

But all matters of consequence were still brought to Moses. He was made answerable for all things.

Ver. 15. Evils. Heb. "my misfortune." The Rabbins say their, or thy, was formerly written, but corrected by the scribes. C. --- Moses fears the anger of God falling upon the people. H. --- It is very wonderful that the Heb. text here retains the feminine pronoun att, instead of atta; thy, thee; as if Moses were addressing himself to some woman; and this absurd peculiarity is more absurdly accounted for, by saying that Moses was "so exasperated during this his address to the divine Being, as to be incapable of pronouncing both syllables!" The same mistake occurs, 1 K. xxiv.

19. Kennicott i. 412. God does not reprehend Moses as guilty of any disrespect or pusillanimity.

H. --- The holy man prays with due submission to the will of the most High. W.

Ver. 16. Seventy men. This was the first institution of the council or senate, called the Sanhedrim, consisting of seventy, or seventy-two senators or counselors. Ch. --- Calmet calls this in question. Dissert. on the Police, &c.

Moses chose these senators from among the officers, whom he had before set over the people, (Ex. xviii.) or from those who had superintended their affairs in Egypt, according to the Rabbins, (Ex. iii. 14,) who say that the traditions explaining the law were entrusted to

them. Jarchi, &c. --- Ancients; a title of authority in the East. See Gen. 1.

7. It was not so necessary that they should be far advanced in year, as that they should be men of prudence and of consummate virtue. These qualifications received a great increase, when they were filled with the spirit of God. C. --- They were thus authorized to decide controversies peremptorily, and to consult God, like Moses, being endued also with a prophetic spirit. M.

Ver. 17. Thy spirit. S. Augustine (q. 18) reads "of the spirit which is on thee;"

(Sept.) referring it to the indivisible spirit of God, so that these ancients received what was sufficient for them, while Moses suffered no diminution.

Thus one lamp communicates light to another, without being impaired. Orig.

hom. 6. Theodoret (q. 18,) also adds, that a person confers baptism on thousands, and yet loses no part of the grace himself. Selden (Syn. ii. 4,) shews that the Jews explain this spirit of a certain emanation of divine light, or inspiration, which causes the prophets to speak. They have not in general, a distinct belief of the blessed Trinity. "I will make an increase of the spirit, which is upon thee, and will place it upon them." Chal. v. 25.

Ver. 18. Sanctified. Prepare yourselves to receive flesh. The word is often used in this sense.

Jer. vi. 4, &c. Onkelos. --- Cease to murmur, and bewail your sin. C.

Ver. 20. Of days complete. So two years of days, means two full years. 1 Mac. i.

30. ---

Loathsome to you. "Indigestible" Sym. "Bilious." Sept. "Till it become loathsome to you, and a source of scandal, (Chal.) or of dispersion, as some translate the Heb.

Ver. 21. People, able to bear arms. H. --- In all there were above two millions. C.

Ver. 22. Fishes. Moses does not distinguish them from flesh, no more than S.

Paul does 1 Cor.

xv. 39. Fish was not formerly allowed on fasting days. C.

Ver. 23. Unable: Heb. "shortened." Sept. "insufficient." Moses had expressed his astonishment, not his doubts; though the words might convey the latter idea to us more than his behaviour in C.

xx. 10. But God sees the heart. --- To pass. Hebrew may be also, "hath called thee;" (C.) Sept.

"shall come upon thee," and execute the thing, as soon as thou shalt promise it. H.

Ver. 25. Afterwards. Some give a contrary meaning to the Heb., with the Sept., Syr., &c.: "They prophesied, (on that occasion) but they did not continue" to do so; except when they were favoured with the influence of the spirit. When it was requisite, they were enabled to declare God's will and his praise to the people. C. --- Saul is said to have prophesied when he praised God, 1 K. x. 5.

10. M.

Ver. 26. Forth, being lawfully hindered, (C.) or out of humility. S. Jer. ep. 127.

Ver. 27. Man. The Rabbins say, without proof, that he was Gersom, the son of Moses, and that the two prophets were half-brothers of the lawgiver, and foretold his death and the persecutions of Gog, &c. C. --- Hermas (11. 2.) refers to some of their predictions: "The Lord is nigh to those who are converts." See Ps. xxxiii. 19. H. --- But they prophesied probably, by announcing only, as men inspired, the praises of God and sentiments of piety, without diving into futurity. C. ---

Theodoret (q. 21) thinks they were not of the 70 judges, but equal in dignity to them. Cotelier.

Ver. 28. Chosen among the seventy, and designed, from his youth, to be the general, and successor of Moses; the Heb. may be understood in all these senses. See Ex. xvii. 10. C. ---

Josue was afraid lest they had assumed this air of authority in opposition to Moses. S. John addressed our Saviour, under the same impressions of zeal, Luc. ix. 49.

Ver. 30. Camp of the people, from the tabernacle, which was in the midst of it.

H.

Ver. 31. Sea; the Mediterranean and the Red Sea. The wind blew from the south-west to the west with respect to Moses, or from the south with respect to Jerusalem. Ps. lxxvii. 26. Many quails are found about Rinocorura, and some have imagined that these had continued during winter at the bottom of the waters, as they say swallows do. Bochart i. 15. God had sent the Hebrews a similar provision for one day, about the same season of the year. Ex. xvi. 13.

--- Flew.

The Hebrew says simply, "as it were two cubits upon the earth;" whether they were heaped one upon the other to that height, or, as it is more probable, (C).

they flew only so much above the ground, an might easily be killed. H. -
-- The Sept. call them ortygometa, the leader, or the largest sort of quails. Suppose twenty of them filled a bushel, or the thirtieth part of a corus, each person would have at least 6,000 quails; and if there were three million people, they must have had 18,000 million such birds. M. -
-- Philo takes notice, that the Jews were very fond of this food; and Aristotle (Anim. viii. 12,) says, their flesh is as good as that of woodcocks. T.

Ver. 32. Cores. Heb. "Chomarim," each of contained 100 gomers. One gomer was the daily allowance of manna for each person, and of course their must have been sufficient quails for one hundred days. But Moses tells us that each one collected at least ten times that quantity, or as much as he could eat for 1,000 days. Bochart therefore supposes, that only each family, of ten people, gathered so much: or the Heb. should be rendered heaps, as the core, or chomer, is not a proper measure for birds, but for corn and liquors. The Sept.

Syr. &c. have "heaps." We need not have recourse to a new creation of these birds, as their numbers are very surprising. Plin. x. 23.

In Italy above 100,000 have been caught in one day, within the space of 5,000

paces. Blond. The Psalmist compares the number brought on this occasion, to the dust, or to the sand of the seashore. Ps. lxxvii. 27. --- Dried them in the sun, having first salted them, as the Egyptians did. C.

Athenæus. --- Many quails are found in Egypt, and around the Arabian Gulf.

Josep. iii. D.

Ver. 33. Plague of fire, v. 3, Ps. lxxvii. 21. C. a Lapide. --- Failed, after the month was expired.

M. --- They had been accustomed to live upon manna, which was a light food, during the space of a year; and now eating greedily of this flesh, their stomachs were overcharged, and they died of an indigestion. C. --- The Rabbins say, God punished their gluttony by death, and obliged the rest of the Hebrews to abstain from all flesh, except from that of the peace-offerings, till they entered the promised land. Seld. Syn. ii. 4.

Ver. 34. The graves of lust; or the sepulchres of concupiscence: so called from their irregular desire of flesh. In Heb. Kibroth Hattaavah. Ch. --- Hence S.

Augustine observes that, "it is not a matter of so much moment to be heard by God. For some he hears in his wrath, granting their requests, while he refuses to comply with some petitions of his friends." D.

NUMBERS 12

CHAPTER XII.

Ver. 1. Ethiopian. Sephora, the wife of Moses, was of Madian, which bordered upon the land of Chus, or Ethiopia; and therefore she is called an Ethiopian: where note, that the Ethiopia here spoken of, is not that of Africa, but that of Arabia, (Ch.) on the east side of the Red Sea.
Ex. ii.

15. Jealousy instigated Aaron and his sister on this occasion. C. --- Perhaps Sephora had claimed some pre-eminence on account of her husband's glory, in being a mediator between God and his people, and therefore they pretend to the same honour, v. 2. **H. ---** The Heb. insinuates, that they laid hold on the pretext of Moses having married, or received again, a woman of a different nation contrary to the law which he had promulgated, "for it adds, he had married or retaken an Ethiopian woman." Others believe that he had put her away, and that Aaron and Mary stood up in her defence. "Mary and Aaron murmured against Moses, on account of the wife whom he had taken, who was a perfect beauty, because he had separated himself from his beautiful wife."

Onkelos. --- Some are of opinion, that this woman was Tarbis, the daughter of the king of Ethiopia, whom Moses espoused after he had terminated the wars between him and the Egyptians, before he retired to Madian. But this account of Josephus, (Ant. ii. 5,) and the explication of Onkelos, and of the Rabbins, seem to be destitute of any solid foundation. **C.**

Ver. 3. Exceeding meek. Moses being the meekest of men, would not contend for himself; therefore God inspired him to write here in his own defence: and the Holy Spirit, whose dictate he wrote, obliged him to declare the truth, though it was so much to his own praise. **Ch. ---** So he mentions his defects without reserve. **C. ---** There are occasions when a person may be not only authorized, but in a manner forced to declare what may be to his own praise.

Moses was in such a situation. The peace of the whole nation was in danger, when false insinuations were thrown out against the lawgiver and king, by his own nearest relations, and by them who were next in authority to himself.

Aaron, the high priest, countenanced at least the remarks of his sister, who seems to have been the most to blame, as she alone is punished with the leprosy. H. --- Some have suspected that this verse has been inserted by a later inspired writer. A. Lapide. --- But whether it was or not, there is no reason to infer with T. Paine, that Moses was either "a vain and arrogant coxcomb, and unworthy of credit, or that the books (attributed to him) are without authority."

For if he did not write this verse, it does not follow that he wrote none of the Pentateuch; and if Paine scruples not to write of himself: "the man does not exist, that can say...I have in any case returned evil for evil:" and is not praising himself as a very meek man, when at the same time he is writing to cause all the mischief he can both in church and state, and thus during the heat of revolutionary madness, to involve thousands in ruin? Watson. H.

Ver. 5. Come to the door of the tabernacle, where Moses also was standing.

Ver. 6. Vision. Other prophets were inspired in a more mysterious manner: Moses, though he saw not the majesty of God in any corporeal figure, was instructed by him in the most secret things with the utmost perspicuity, (C.) as if a man were explaining his sentiments to his most intimate friend. Ex. xxxiii.

19. H.

Ver. 7. Faithful: Hebrew Neeman, steward or master of the palace. Such was Samuel, 1 K. iii.

20; David, (C.) 1 K. xxii. 14; Naaman, the general of Syria, 2 K. v.; and Bacchides, 1 Mac. vii.

H. --- Ambassadors had this title, (Prov. xiii. 17,) and fidelity often denotes an office. 1 Par. ix.

22. Job (xii. 20,) speaks of the Namonim. C. --- But none among the Israelites was more justly entitled to this honour than Moses. He announced the word of God without any mixture of falsehood, and did not arrogate to himself more than his due, as Aaron seems to have done, v. 2.

H.

Ver. 10. Departed from the door to its former place, (C.) as if in abhorrence of Mary's leprosy, (Hiscuni) and still more of the sin, which had brought upon her that punishment. C. --- Perhaps the cloud was raised higher in the air than usual, but did not proceed forward; (M.) otherwise the Israelites would have decamped. They remained at Haseroth till Mary was returned into the camp, v.

15. H. --- Leprosy, of an incurable kind, like that of Gieze, 4 K. v. 27. It covers the whole skin with a white scurf. Lev. xiii. 10. Aaron is spared, either because he had sided with his sister only out of complaisance, without any formal malice against his brother; or because God, in consideration for his priestly character, would not render him contemptible in the eyes of the all people, intending to punish him in a more secret manner: for was are not always to judge of the grievousness of a fault, by its present punishment. Perhaps Aaron obtained pardon by his speedy repentance, v. 11. C.

Ver. 12. Dead; consumed by leprosy, or incapable of performing the duties of life. M. --- Heb.

" an abortive, whose flesh is half consumed before he comes forth from his mother's womb."

Sept. "he eateth half her flesh." "Permit not her to be separated from us, I beseech you, for she is our sister: pray, I beg, that her flesh may be healed."

Chaldee.

Ver. 14. Answered him. The force of this reply must be very obvious. If a father had been so irritated by his daughter, as to shew his indignation in the strongest manner, (see Job xxx. 10.

Mar. xiv. 65,) she would surely keep out of sight for a time: and can she complain, if I, who have been more injured in the person of my minister, exclude her from society seven days, after having covered her with the leprosy as with spittle. C. --- The excommunication, in the Christian Church, bears some resemblance with this exclusion. Mary did not undergo all the legal purifications, (Lev. xxxiv.) as the miraculous cure dispensed her from them. M.

--- Origen (hom.

vi. 7,) and other Fathers, explain the mystery of this historical event. Moses, taking to wife the Ethiopian, represents Christ calling the Gentiles, which excites the murmurs of the synagogue.

Mary shews the deformity of the latter religion at the present day, without head or sacrifice. The encomiums bestowed upon the Jewish legislator, belong in a still stricter sense to Jesus Christ, the mildest of men, fully acquainted with all the secrets of God, and the most faithful in all his house.

S. Jer. ep. ad Fab. mansion xiv.

NUMBERS 13

CHAPTER XIII.

Ver. 1. Pharan, at Rethma, C. xxxiii. 48.; though Barradius confounds that station with that at Cades-barne. The Samaritan copy inserts here a long passage, taken probably from Deut. i. 20.

21. and 22, which shews that the Hebrews first proposed the sending spies, out of timidity; which God severely punished in the sequel, though in his anger he here consents to their proposal, which seemed to originate in motives of prudence, v. 3.

Ver. 3. Rulers of a hundred men, according to Hiscuni, inferior to those mentioned, C. x. 14. C.

Ver. 6. Huri: Sept. "Souri." None of the tribe of Levi, the third son of Jacob, are sent; but two represent the different branches of the tribe of Joseph, v. 9. 12.

The tribe of Ephraim comes out of its natural order, and has been overlooked by Calmet. H.

Ver. 12. Sceptre. Heb. matte, means also "a tribe."

Ver. 17. Josue. His former name Osee, or Hoseah, means "one saved, or salvation:" but the addition of the i, taken from the name of the Lord, intimates,

"he shall save, or the Saviour of God." Some think that Moses had given him this name after the defeat of the Amalecites; but the Book of Exodus, where the name is found, might have been written after he received this commission.

C. --- The Sept. have, "Ause, the son of Nave, Jesus," as he was a striking figure of our blessed Saviour, and their names are written with the same letters, Yehoshuah. This Moses foresaw, and also that he should be the happy instrument, in the hand of God, of saving the

Israelites, by introducing them to the land of promise, and establishing them in peace therein. M.

--- The changing of his name imported, likewise, that he should be the chief leader. Theod. q. 25.

W.

Ver. 18. South side, which is to the north of where you now dwell. Moses enters into several details for the satisfaction of the people, though they had probably a general idea of the country and of its fruitfulness already, having lived not far off. They might not know, however, but that some part of the inhabitants might dwell in tents, instead of towns, as many of the Arabians did.

Ver. 21. First ripe (*præcoquæ*;) Heb. lit. "the first-born." Sept. "the days of spring, forerunners of the grape." In Madeira, grapes ripen in March. Some suppose the messengers departed in June, others in July. In Palestine, they have fresh grapes from the end of June till Martinmas, and three vintages, in August, and in each of the two following months.

Ver. 22. Sin. The desert of Pharan was contiguous to that of Sin. They departed from Cadesbarne, and went along the Jordan to Rohob, at the foot of Mount Libanus, and on the road to Emath; then they returned by the confines of the Sidonians and Philistines, through Hebron, to the camp at Cades.

Ver. 23. And came. The printed Heb. has, "and he came:" but the Sam. and all the versions, as well as some MSS. properly retain the plural, which the Massorets allow is right. Kenn. Diss. 1.

--- Enac, the founder of Hebron, and father of the giants of Chanaan. Jos. xv.

13. The Greek word anax, "king," was perhaps derived from him, as also the famous Inachides, who settled in Greece, after they were driven out by Josue.

Grot. --- Tanis, where the tyrants of the Hebrews resided; a city, which the Egyptians represented as the most ancient in the world. Moses represses their vain boasting, by informing them that Hebron was of

greater antiquity. It was afterwards assigned to the priests, and for a city of refuge, in the tribe of Juda.

Jos. xx. 7.

Ver. 24. Torrent. Sept. "vale." --- Its. Heb. "one cluster." --- Two men, Josue and Caleb; (S.

Maximus) though the Rabbins say they carried nothing. --- Lever, or staff, suspending it thus, in order that it might not be crushed. In that valley, Doubdan (i. 21,) was assured by the religious, that clusters, weighing twelve pounds, might still be found. Pliny (xiv. 1,) says, there are some in Africa, larger than a male infant. Strabo (xi.) describes some in Carmania, two cubits high.

Forster saw a religious man at Nurenberg, who had lived eight years in Palestine, and assured him that two men could hardly carry a bunch of grapes, such as grew in the vale of Hebron: (C.) but this may seem to be an hyperbole.

H. --- Lucas (T. i. p. 310,) assures us, that he had seen a bunch at Damascus, weighing above forty pounds. The Fathers here contemplate Jesus Christ, suspended between the two testaments, the synagogue and the Church: the juice, or blood of the grape, (Gen. xlix. 2. Deut. xxii. 14,) denotes his passion.

S. Jer. ep. ad Fab. S. Bern. in Cant.

ser. 44. C.

Ver. 27. Cades. The desert of Pharan, or of Cades, is the same. H. --- The town is sometimes called Cades-barne, or Recem, (Chald.) which is Petra, the capital of the stony Arabia, and lies rather nearer to the Dead Sea than to the Mediterranean. It was on the high road from the Red Sea to Hebron. In one part of the desert of Cades, the people murmured for want of water. C. xx.

1. But there was plenty near the city. Moses continued here a long time after the return of the spies. Deut. i. 19. 46. C.

Ver. 30. South. They had already routed the Amalecites; but the spies insidiously recall to their remembrance, that they would be again in arms to obstruct their passage. --- Hethites, dwelt nearest the Philistines, in the country which fell to the shares of Simeon and of Dan. The Jebusites occupied Jerusalem; and the Amorrrhites, the most powerful of all those nations, held possession of most of the territory which was allotted to Juda. Nearer the Dead Sea, on the same mountains, dwelt the Cinezeans and the Cineans.

Bonfrere places the Chanaanites on the banks of the Jordan, from the lake of Sodom as far as the sea of Tiberias. But they dwelt also near the Mediterranean; and the Phœnicians maintained themselves at Tyre and Sidon, against the most powerful kings of the Jews, and extended their commerce over the old world, to many parts of which they sent out colonies. C.

Ver. 31. Caleb, to whom Josue alone joined himself, to bear witness of the truth against the other ten; whom the people were, however, more inclined to believe, (C. xiv. 6. Eccli. xlvi. 9,) paying more attention to numbers than to authority, when it suited their humour. H.

Ver. 33. Spoke ill, &c. These men, who, by their misrepresentations of the land of promise, discouraged the Israelites from attempting the conquest of it, were a figure of worldlings, who, by decrying or

misrepresenting true devotion, discourage Christians from seeking in earnest and acquiring so great a good, and thereby securing to themselves a happy eternity. Ch. ---

Devoureth, by being exposed to continual wars from the Arabs, Idumeans, and from its own inhabitants, the monsters of the race of Enac. With this God had threatened the Hebrews, if they proved rebellious. Lev. xxvi. 38. See Ezech.

xxxvi. 13. C.

Ver. 34. Monsters. Heb. "giants." --- Locusts, or grasshoppers. So much inferior in size were we to them. Heb. insinuates that the spies entertained these sentiments when they beheld the giants, and the latter seemed to look down upon them with contempt; "and so we were in their sight."

These wicked men scrupled not to exaggerate in order to fill the people with dismay. H. --- Their suggestions tended to make them distrust the goodness or the power of God; and therefore he would not suffer them to enjoy the sweets of the land. C. xiv. 23. 29. W. See Deut. i. 28. Isai.

xl. 21.

NUMBERS 14

CHAPTER XIV.

Ver. 3. We may. The Latin MSS. and Bibles before Sixtus V. read "in Egypt, and not in this," &c.

But the present translation agrees with the Heb. Sept. and Chaldee. C. - -- They obtained what they said they wished for, v. 28 C. xiv. 29. xxvi. 64. W. --- And that. Heb. &c. "and wherefore hath God brought us into this land, that we may fall," &c. In a rage they attribute a malicious design to God. C. --- Better. And who would have given them food in the wilderness? M.

Ver. 4. Captain, instead of Moses, whom they could not bring over to their criminal design, no more than Aaron, Josue, Caleb, &c. H. --- Some imagine the rebels wanted to choose themselves a king, (C.) or even another god. Drusius.

--- Every community acknowledges the necessity of having one at the head. W.

Ver. 5. Israel; begging that God would not destroy them, as he had done their brethren. C. xi.

M.

Ver. 6. Garments, in testimony of their disapprobation and zeal; to make these insolent people reflect upon the evils into which they are throwing themselves.

C.

Ver. 9. To eat, or consume them, as easily as we devour a piece of bread. The expression is proverbial. Ps. xiii. 4. --- All aid. Heb. "their shadow," which is taken in the same sense. Sept.

"their time or opportunity is gone." The Rabbins refer this to holy Job, who, they say, died at this time. A. Lapide. --- He dwelt near the Jordan. Pineda in Job. C. i. 1. and 27.

Ver. 10. Cried out, &c. Heb. "said stone them."

Ver. 11. Detract. Heb. "despise, irritate, or blaspheme." God is incapable of anger, says Origen; he only foretells what will come to pass.

Ver. 13. That the. The sentence is left imperfect, to signify the agitation and distress with which Moses was oppressed, as if he had said, Thou wilt thus afford a pretext, that the Egyptians and Chanaanites may say to one another, that thou couldst not perform what thou hadst promised; and therefore, that in vexation thou hadst destroyed thy people. H. --- Heb. "Then the Egyptians shall hear it...and will tell it to the inhabitants of this land...because the Lord could not," &c. v. 16. C.

--- Thus they will blaspheme thy holy name. M.

Ver. 15. One man. All at once, (C.) entirely, without sparing so much as one.

Vatable.

Ver. 16. Sworn. God swore to give this land to the Hebrews, but not to this particular generation.

His oath would be equally fulfilled by raising posterity to Moses, v. 13. But, at his entreaty, he spared the descendants of this people, and gave the land to their children under Josue. H.

Ver. 17. Lord, in overcoming all difficulties, raised either by the enemy, or by thy rebellious people.

Ver. 18. Mercy. Sept. "merciful and true," as Exod. xxxiv. 6. 7. On that occasion, it is not written that God swore. H. --- But equal credit is to be given to his word, as to an oath. M. ---

Clear, or, as S. Jerom expresses it in Exodus, and no man of himself is innocent before thee. C.

--- By these titles God will be addressed; and therefore Moses mentions them all, though some of them might seem to obstruct his petition of pardon. M. ---

He knew that none of God's perfections were contrary to one another, or to his nature of consummate goodness; and he sued for the pardon of his people, with all due submission to the dictates of his justice. H.

Ver. 20. Forgiven the sins to those who repent; but the punishment due to them must be undergone, though not so soon as I had threatened, v. 12. 19.

How happy is that nation, which has one like Moses to intercede for them! H.

Ver. 21. Lord. I will surely punish the guilty; and all the earth shall know that their own crimes, and not my imbecility, prevented their

taking possession of Chanaan. My glory shall shine both in my long-suffering, and in the effects of my justice. Let me pass for a dead god, like the idols, if I do not perform what I say.

Ver. 22. The men, above twenty years of age, v. 29. --- Majesty, manifested by the signs, &c. H.

--- Ten times; very often. It is not necessary to specify the number of the rebellions, as some have done, placing the first on the other side of the Red Sea, (Ex. xiv. 11,) and the tenth here. The expression is often used to express a great but indefinite number. Eccles. vii. 20. C.

Ver. 23. It. None of those who murmured ever entered the land of promise.

Origen (hom. 27,) believes that the Levites behaved with fidelity, and were not comprised in the punishment. In effect, Eleazar certainly entered Chanaan.

Jos. xiv. 1. Salmon also, who espoused Rahab, had seen the wonders of God, but had not joined with the rest; so that, when it is said (v. 2,) that all murmured, we must explain it by S. Jerom's rule, of the greatest part; as, no doubt, many would abhor the conduct of the seditious. C. -- - Omnia non ad totum referenda esse sed ad partem maximam. S. Jer. ep. 146. ad Dam.) Ver. 24. Spirit. The spirit of obedience and of courage. M. --- Followed me, as a guide, and hath fulfilled all my desires. Vatab. --- This he was enabled to do by God's free grace. But his co-operation merited a reward. See S. Aug. de Grat.

&. Lib. iv. W.

Ver. 25. For. Heb. "Now," &c. The enemy is ready to attack you in the defiles, and I will not expose you at present to their fury, as you shall not enter the land for many years. Wherefore to-morrow, &c. H. --- It seems they complied reluctantly, for they probably encamped in that neighbourhood about a year. C.

Ver. 30. Hand, the posture of one taking an oath. Gen. xv. 18.

Ver. 33. Years. Within five days from the departure out of Egypt, (M.) and above 38 from this time. Heb. "they shall be shepherds," without any fixed dwelling, like the shepherds of that country. --- Consumed. They had complained that Chanaan consumed and devoured its inhabitants. C. --- Their children underwent a temporal, but salutary, punishment for their sin. S.

Aug. ep. 75. W.

Ver. 34. Revenge. Heb. "my breach of promise, or if my threats be vain," &c.

Sept. "you shall know the fury of my anger." C. --- I will convince you by the severity with which I shall execute this sentence, that you had no reason to distrust my former promises. S. Jerom (in Ezech. xx.) entertains hopes of the eternal salvation of many of these Hebrews, who had time to do penance for their sins.

Ver. 37. Lord, by pestilence, (ver. 12; Philo) or by the exterminating angel, 1

Cor. x. 10. They were burnt to death before the tabernacle, or at least died suddenly. Jans. The Jews have appointed a fast on the 7th of the 6th month, to bewail this event. C. v. 39.

Ver. 41. Which conduct shall not, &c. They had been ordered to return: now they will advance, and, though admonished that the Lord will not assist them, they depend upon their own efforts, being ever full of themselves, and distrustful of God, the two sources of all spiritual misfortunes.

H.

Ver. 44. Blinded, with presumption, as the Heb. yahpilu, insinuates. "Their heart was puffed up with pride, and they ascended." Deut. i. 43. C. --- The enemy was ready to receive them, and easily routed this rabble, abandoned by God, and by Moses, Aaron and his sons, Josue, and other men of virtue and sense. They who before lay lurking in the valleys, (v. 25,) assume fresh courage, when they become the executioners of God's vengeance, and come pouring down from their mountains, with irresistible fury; nor do they stop till they had made a dreadful carnage of the Hebrews. The same place was again deluged with blood, (C. xxi. 3,) and was called Horma, or "the Curse." The Sam.

and Sept. add, and they returned into the camp, Thus, by their own woeful experience, they began to feel that God would keep his word in punishing the common people, as well as the leaders, v. 37. H.

NUMBERS 15

CHAPTER XV.

Ver. 2. Speak. This law was probably given towards the end of the 40 years, v.

23.

Ver. 3. Victim "of peace," as some Latin copies read, including all the different sorts, v. 28. C.

Ver. 4. Ephr. Heb. "a tenth of flour," or one gomer. D.

Ver. 6. Oil. Greater libations are required for a ram, as it is larger than the former victim, which was accompanied with only half the quantity of fine flour.

H. --- Part of the wine and oil was poured on the flour, and burnt on the altar; the rest was given to the priests.

Ver. 11---15. Thus, &c. --- Land. In this last verse, the Sam. copy observes a more correct manner of punctuation than the Heb. which is commonly rendered "O congregation." Houbig. ---

The author of the Vulgate has preserved the sense, but not all the words of the original. The strangers here spoken of are the proselytes of justice, who kept all the law. Those of the gate, who lived in the land, uncircumcised, could only present holocausts, without libations. Lev. xxii.

25. C. --- "The many sacrifices (of the old law) prefigured this one sacrifice" of the new. S. Aug.

de C. x. 20. Christ, represented by the oil, offers himself the victim, under the forms of bread and wine. D.

Ver. 20. Eat. Heb. and Sept. "of your dough." They elevated a part towards heaven, and gave it to the priest or Levite, who lived nearest them; and, in case none could be found, as at the present day, they were to burn it in honour of God. Tradition determines the quantity to be between a 40th and a 60th part.

S. Jer. in Ezec. xlv. This they do every time they bake, according to Philo, and Leo of Modena, (2. 9,) though the law be not clear, and some might think it sufficient to give a part, the first time they baked with new flour.

Ver. 22. Ignorance. Other victims are prescribed; (Lev. iv. 13,) so that the ignorance here mentioned must be of a different nature. The former was perhaps a sin of commission, and this a sin of omission; such as if the whole people should neglect to eat the paschal lamb. The Rabbins think that the law alludes here to idolatry, committed for want of knowledge. But that is next to impossible in a whole nation. Outram believes, that the Book of Leviticus speaks of those who transgress the negative precepts, without abandoning the true religion; but the present law alludes to those who forget the laws of their fathers, and embrace a false worship. Thus Ezechias offered the victims here prescribed, though more in number, to expiate the idolatry of the people under Achaz, 1 Par. xxix. 21. See also 1 Esdr. viii. 35. Some think Moses has supplied in this place what was left deficient before. But it is more probable, that he supposes here only some of the tribes have sinned ignorantly, while in Leviticus he speaks of the whole nation. C. --
- No one sins for the sake of the offence, but for some advantage which we falsely persuade ourselves we shall derive from doing so. S. Aug. q. 24.

Ver. 25. And for. Heb. "and their sin (offering) in the presence of the Lord, for their ignorance."

C.

Ver. 30. Pride. Heb. and Sept. "with hand, or with head (Chald.) uplifted,"

without shame or control. The Rabbins say, he must deny that God is the author of the law, and sin deliberately, after being admonished, &c. before he will incur this penalty. But why all these restrictions? ---

Rebellious. Heb. "he hath blasphemed, or irritated the Lord." Such crimes imply a contempt of the law. --- Cut off by God, if the judges neglect to do it.

The Hebrews maintain, that each individual has a right to kill such scandalous offenders, as Phinees did Zambri. C. xxv. 7. 1 Mac.

ii. 23. It is not clear whether all strangers, living in the country, were subjected to this law. Seld.

Jur. ii. 11. Though such crimes were not pardoned by the law, true repentance will free us from them. S. Aug. q. 25. W.

Ver. 32. Wilderness of Pharan, if this crime were committed soon after the murmuring of the people, or in some other part of the desert. This example tends to show the severity and extent of the former precept. The law had condemned the breaker of the sabbath to be put to death. But Moses consulted the Lord, to know in what manner; or perhaps there were some circumstances attending the offender, which extenuated or enhanced his crime. Some of the Rabbins have unjustly aspersed the character of Salphaad, as if he were the person, because it is said that he died in the desert in his own sin. C. xxii. 3. C. --- Those who transgress with full knowledge, deserve to be severely chastised; (Lu. xii. 47,) and this is the more necessary, when the law has been lately promulgated, to restrain the insolent. H. --- God generally makes an example of those who first transgress his laws, as he did our first parents, Cain, the Sodomites, the worshippers of the golden calf, &c.

He punished thus the sacrilege of Nadab, the disobedience of Saul, the lie of Ananias and Saphira. Cajetan. D.

Ver. 38. Fringes. The Pharisees enlarged these fringes through hypocrisy, (Matt. xxiii. 5,) to appear more zealous than other men for the law of God. Ch.

--- Our Saviour conformed to this law. Luke viii. 44. Moses shews that these fringes were to be made for the cloak, which was square, and not for the tunic.

Deut. xxii. 12. The colour, in S. Justin's time, was purple. Dial. It seems that the Phœnicians were accustomed to wear such fringes. Sidoniam picto chlamidem circumdata limbo. Æneid, iv. C. --- God ordained that his people should be thus distinguished from other nations. T.

Ver. 39. Astray, (fornicantes). The eyes being left without restraint, easily fix upon dangerous objects, which captivate the heart, and lead to idolatry and the contempt of God's law. C. --- We are also admonished to meditate on the law, and not follow our own thoughts or interpretations, so as to render it of no effect, in the regulation of our morals. H.

NUMBERS 16

CHAPTER XVI.

Ver. 1. Isaar was brother of Amram; and, consequently, his son was the cousin of Moses. ---

Core engaged the rest in his revolt. Heb. "took or replied," interrupting Moses at the very time when he was speaking, in the name of God, and requiring that he should shew by what right he arrogated to himself alone that authority.

"Core separated himself." Chal. "He retired." Syr.

"Core spoke...and Dathan...and they rose up." Sept. The Caathites encamped near the tribe of Ruben; and hence Core had an opportunity to engage some of them in his revolt, by insinuating that Moses occupied the post in the state which ought to belong to them, as Ruben was the first-born; while Aaron had obtained the high priesthood, and the rest of the Levites, though of equal nobility, were to be treated as his servants. It is not known when this revolt happened. Some place it at the camp of Sinai; others at that of Jetebata. Deut.

x. 8.

Ver. 2. Rose up. The crime of these men, which was punished in so remarkable a manner, was that of schism, and of rebellion against the authority established by God in the Church; and their pretending to the priesthood without being lawfully called and sent: the same is the case of all modern sectaries. Ch. --- Let them dread a similar punishment; not only the authors of such wicked pretensions, but those also who consent to them. Rom. i. 32. For we find that Core and all his adherents were buried in hell; (v. 33,) and those likewise who complained that their punishment was too severe, fell victims to the raging fire, v. 49. With what earnestness ought we not therefore, to contend for the faith once delivered to the saints! Jude 3. For if those be so severely punished who rise up in opposition to lawful superiors, either in church or state, what swift destruction do they not bring upon their own heads who deny God, who bought them, and make him a liar, by calling in question his most sacred truths? 2 Pet. ii. 1. H. --- Core and his companions impugned not the law directly, but resisted Moses and Aaron. S. Ignat. ep. ad Magnes. They believed in the same God; yet, because they took upon themselves to sacrifice, they were forthwith punished by God, and their unlawful sacrifices could do them no service. S.

Cyp. ep. i. 6. Thus we are warned to keep in the true Church, and to obey those who are set over us; and never, for any temporal consideration whatever, to encourage, by our presence, the sermons or meetings of heretics, or of schismatics, lest we perish with them, v. 26. W. ---

Assembly. Heb. "famous in the assembly, men of name," and distinction, senators. It seems Hom left the rest of the conspirators, as he is mentioned no more. The princes of Ruben were desirous of obtaining the temporal power only. But the Levites aspired at that sacred pre-eminence, which had been given by God to Aaron and his sons. C.

Ver. 3. Let it be enough. Heb. rab, "too much you take upon you;" or "suffice it for you." Sept.

--- Holy ones, as deserving of the priesthood as yourselves, v. 10. Why then would you treat them as your inferiors? We will throw off the yoke, and assert our just rights. C. --- On the same plea, Luther (de abrog. Missa,) rejects all ecclesiastical hierarchy, and will have no distinct priesthood, because all Christians are called priests, (Apoc. i.) and a holy priesthood, 1 Pet. ii. 5. W. ---

But they do not take notice that the apostle immediately explains himself, by saying, to offer up spiritual sacrifices, and to declare the virtues of Christ; in which sense they are also styled a kingly priesthood. ib. v. 9. H.

Ver. 5. The holy ones, whom he has chosen for the high priesthood. The psalmist, speaking of this sedition, says, they provoked...Aaron, the holy one of the Lord. Ps. cv. 16. C. See 1 Tim. ii.

19. --- Only those who are chosen by God, can lawfully perform this sacred office, as the Almighty declares by a miracle. H.

Ver. 6. Censers. It was not lawful for the Levites to offer incense: but they had prepared for themselves the ensigns of the priestly power, and Moses permits them to try their success. H. ---

They might have brought the censers, or broad plates, bowls, or vials, (Apoc.

v. 8,) out of Egypt, where every family offers incense to their domestic gods and sacred animals. In Sicily and Greece they were also very common, as well as at Babylon; where married people always purified themselves with the smoke of incense. Herod. i. 197.

Ver. 7. Lord, in his sanctuary, where the priests alone offered incense twice a day upon the altar.

C. --- Too much. Moses retorts upon them their own words, v. 3.

Ver. 9. To him: Heb. and Sept. "to them," or instead of the people. God had chosen them for that post of honour, to the exclusion of all the rest, so that they ought, the least of all, to have complained. But it often happens, that those who are the most exalted, take occasion to esteem themselves deserving of still higher honours; and thus, like Lucifer, fall into the bottomless pit!

H. --- Core was perhaps the more irritated, because he was not at the head of the Caathites, though a descendant of the second son of Caath, while Elisaphan, sprung from a fourth son, was preferred to him. C. iii. T.

Ver. 11. Him. The injury is offered to God, who made choice of Aaron freely.

Ver. 14. Eyes. These princes of Ruben were not desirous of the priesthood, as Core was; they repined, that Moses had got possession of the sovereign authority, and therefore they endeavour to represent him as an imposter, who had promised great things, but in reality had deprived the people of all the happiness which they formerly enjoyed in Egypt, and was now disposed to exercise his tyranny upon their very persons. H. --- "Do you wish that we should not see through your impostures?" Heb. "wilt thou put out the eyes of these men," who have informed us what sort of a country Chanaan is? Sept.

"thou hast blinded these men," who are so stupid as to obey thee. C. ---

Chaldee, "though thou pull out our eyes, we will not come."

Ver. 15. Very angry. This anger was a zeal against sin; and an indignation at the affront offered to God; like that which the same holy prophet conceived upon the sight of the golden calf, Ex.

xxxii. 19. Ch. --- Respect not. Heb. "thou wilt not have regard for their sacrifices, " as long as they continue in these sentiments of pride and of rebellion. H. --- Thou knowest. Heb. "I have not," &c. --- Ass. This expression is proverbial, 1 K. xii. 3. The Samar. and Sept. read, chamod,

"any thing desirable," instead of chamor "an ass." C.

Ver. 22. God, who givest life to all, and searchest the inmost recesses of the heart. M.

Ver. 26. Depart. If we give any encouragement to schismatics, or go to their meetings, we must expect to be involved in their sins. S. Cyp. de Lapsis 5. W.

Ver. 27. People, (frequentiâ). The Sept. generally translate tappam by aposkene, "family and effects," of every denomination. C. --- Here was a full assembly waiting for the event, between fear and hope. As these rebels would not come, when Moses sent for them, he condescended to go to them, and denounced the impending ruin, v. 14, 25. He commits his whole cause to God, and is willing to be rejected as a vile impostor, if God do not shew, by a miraculous and exemplary punishment of his opponents, that what he had hitherto done, as the head of the people, and particularly in the consecration of Aaron, was by his direction. H. - -- He had before proved his mission by miracles. Ex. iv. W.

Ver. 30. Hell. See Ps. liv. 16. Prov. i. 12. "They were consigned to the tomb before they were dead," (S. Optatus, B. i.,) while their impenitent souls were buried in hell. The souls of their infant children, which had no share in the rebellion, might be exempted from the latter part of their punishment. C. --- If some have the rashness to blame the severity of this judgment of God, let them shew the disparity between it and the various other accidents occasioned by earthquakes,

&c. which involve millions of such "smiling infants" in destruction; or, if they do not infer from these misfortunes, that the laws of nature are unjust; neither ought they to conclude that the religion, delivered by God to Moses, was an imposture, or that the Jewish legislator was cruel.

He continued a silent spectator of this transaction, which he was informed by the Spirit would surely take place, and could not be averted by his intercession, which had before rescued the less guilty multitude, v. 22. H. ---

"They descend into hell alive; that is, feeling their own perdition, who, imitating Core,...separate from the Church, and presently fall into heresy." S.

Aug. ep. 93.

Ver. 32. Tents. Heb. adds, "all those who belonged to (or sided with) Core, and all their riches."

Moses informs us, (C. xxvi. 10,) how some of Core's children were miraculously preserved.

Their descendants were appointed by David to sing and to guard the doors of the temple, 1 Par.

ix. 19. C. --- Samuel was of the same family. 1 Par. vi. 33. T.

Ver. 33. Hell. Heb. adds, "they, and whatsoever belonged to them, descended into hell, or the pit." Sale. --- The souls of the impenitent into the former, the bodies of the cattle, &c. into the bowels of the earth. H.

Ver. 35. Incense. Core had left them, and was busy in stirring up the people to rebellion, when a fire proceeding from the cloud, or from the altar, or perhaps a thunderbolt, (C.) came to arraign them before God's tribunal, there to meet their chief, and to hear the eternal sentence of separation from all good, which was instantly pronounced upon all who died impenitent. H. ---

Perhaps Core might have been offering incense with his 250 men, when the fire seized him, v. 40.

D.

Ver. 38. Sinners. These censers were sanctified or set apart for God's altar: 1.

By the intention of those who used them, though contrary to his will; 2. by the exemplary vengeance which he exercised upon the rash pretenders to the priesthood; 3. by being a monument of their folly, and therefore placed, by God's order, upon the altar, to deter all others from imitating their conduct.

Eleazar was commanded to take them up, and scatter the strange fire; that Aaron might not be defiled with touching the carcasses or ashes of the deceased, nor seem to exult in their death. C.

--- God was thus also pleased to manifest that the children of Aaron, and not of the other Levites, should succeed him. S. Aug. q. 30. W.

Ver. 39. Altar of holocausts, which was already covered with plates of brass. C.

Ver. 40. Stranger, though he be even of royal dignity. Thus Osias was afflicted with a perpetual leprosy, which rendered him incapable of exercising even the office of king, because he had attempted to offer incense, 2 K. xv. 5. 2 Par.

xxvi. 17. H.

Ver. 45. Get ye out. Moses and Aaron complied with the spirit, though not with the letter of this injunction. They lay prostrate on their faces, with all humility and earnestness, begging that the Lord would preserve them, and at the same time take pity on the frailty of the multitude, who had been deluded, and had, in words at least, approved the conduct of the rebels. H. --- God encourages them inwardly to persevere in prayer, in the same manner as when he said to Moses, (Ex. xxxii. 20,) Let me alone, that my wrath may be enkindled, &c.

Ver. 46. Take. Moses was inspired by God, on this extraordinary occasion, to pass over the common rules, which forbade the high priest to offer incense any where but in the tabernacle, and never to appear among the dead. C.

Ver. 49. Core. We cannot reckon less than 15,000, who perished in consequence of their adherence to this innovator. Behold the first-fruits of ambition and of rebellion. H.

NUMBERS 17

CHAPTER XVII.

Ver. 2. Speak. The cause of the different families of the Levites now being fully decided, that one of the other tribes might pretend to the honour of the priesthood, God orders Moses to propose another miracle to them, of a less terrible nature than the preceding one. --- Man, or prince of the tribe. H. --- The name of Aaron was written upon his staff, which was taken from an almond tree; those of the princes of the other tribes appeared upon their respective rods, and represented their different families, v. 3. C.

Ver. 5. They murmur. Hence it seems this miracle was not unnecessary, as the people were still inclined to murmur at the pre-eminence given to Aaron. H.

Ver. 6. Besides, &c. Heb. and the other versions, "the rod of Aaron was in the midst of their rods." Whence some infer, that there were only 12 rods. But Origen, (hom. 9,) and most others, allow 13, as the tribe of Joseph was divided into those of Ephraim and Manasses; (C.) each of whom had a proper representative or prince. See C. ii. 18. 20. x. 22. xiii. 9. 12. The tribe of Levi is generally placed by itself. If there were only 12 rods, whether would the name of Elisama, or that of Gamaliel, designate the tribe of Joseph? Who was properly the prince of that undivided tribe? H.

Ver. 8. The rod of Aaron for the house of Levi, was budded, &c. This rod of Aaron, which thus miraculously brought forth fruit, was a figure of the blessed Virgin conceiving and bringing forth her Son, without any prejudice to her virginity. Ch. --- Almonds. Buds, blossoms, leaves, and fruit just formed, (Is.

xviii. 5,) appeared upon the rod, which before was dry. Tostat believes, that it continued in the same state during the whole time that it was preserved in the ark. "The grace of the priesthood never fades." S. Amb. ep. 63. or 58. The almond tree is the first which blossoms, and

therefore it is styled a watching rod. Jer. i. 11. The Fathers observe in this of Aaron, a figure of Christ's passion and glorious resurrection; and Origen (hom. 9,) remarks, that from his cross proceed the sweet odours of virtue, and the fruits of converted nations. C. ---

For Christ made peace through the blood of his cross. Colos. i. 20. The blessed Virgin, whom the blooming rod also represents, might as easily become a mother without losing her virginal integrity, as this dry rod might produce fruit, without receiving any moisture from the earth. S.

Aug. S. Greg. Nys. S. Bern. &c. W.

Ver. 10. Testimony. S. Paul (Heb. ix. 4,) says it was in the ark. See Deut. xxxi.

26. C. --- It was not the rod with which so many miracles had been wrought. T.

Ver. 12. All perish. Many had been already destroyed. Those who remained, and were conscious of their seditious practices, feared a similar treatment. H.

Ver. 13. Destroyed. They betray the sentiments of their hearts; though some believe that they were now entering into themselves, and desirous to know what they must do to escape the fate of their brethren. God gives them an answer in the following chapter, teaching them that they must refrain from approaching to the tabernacle, unless they be authorized; and provide such things as are requisite for the maintenance of those, whom he has chosen for his ministers. C. ---

Afterwards, he passes over the transactions of about 35 years, in profound silence, that the memory of those who had so often murmured, might perish.

Salien. A.C. 1505.

NUMBERS 18

CHAPTER XVIII.

Ver. 1. Priesthood. If you transgress, or if you neglect to instruct and watch over those who are employed about the sanctuary, you shall be responsible for it. C. --- You must resist those strangers who would intrude themselves into the office, which I have confirmed to you by miracles. M.

Ver. 2. Sceptre. Heb. shebet, denotes also "tribe, family," &c. The princes of families probably bore a sceptre, as we find all magistrates did in the days of Homer. Iliad i. Æneid xii. C. --- All the other children of Aaron's father, were to be in the order of the Levites, among whom even Moses left his own family, though he was himself an extraordinary priest. H.

Ver. 4. Stranger; even born of a woman of the tribe of Levi. Maimonides.

Ver. 7. Priests. Heb. "you shall serve in the ministry of priests which I have given you." The office was not due to them on account of any superior merit.

H.

Ver. 8. Charge, as stewards or dispensers (C.) of what is offered to me; part of which I abandon to your use, as long as your republic shall subsist. M. ---

First-fruits, or "heave-offerings," which comprised also the victims, first-born,

&c. over which the high priest had a general inspection. ---

Office. Heb. "unction." Sept. "as a reward," or salary for your labour, in performing the duty of priest. C.

Ver. 9. And are. Heb. "This shall be thine, of the most holy things, from the fire." Some parts of the victims for sin and of the libations were to be consumed, while the rest was given to the priests. These libations were not properly styled holy of holies, (which were to be eaten only in the holy place, by those who were in actual service) no more than the peace-offerings were, of which even women might partake, v. 11. 12. Lev. x. 14.

Ver. 11. House, perpetually. Hired servants were not admitted to eat of them.

Lev. xxii. 10. C.

Ver. 12. The best, (medullam.) Lit. "the marrow." H. --- The fattest and most delicious. M.

Ver. 13. First-ripe, (initia.) "The beginnings" (H.) of the fruit of trees, in the fourth year. Lev.

xix. 24. It may also comprise all the fruits of the earth. C. --- First-fruits must be distinguished from tithes, which were only the tenth part. The former were offered immediately to the Lord, but the latter to the priests, &c. for their support. Besides the first-fruits of ears of corn at the Passover, and of bread at Pentecost, and at every weekly baking, first-fruits were to be given in the 7th month of the harvest and of the vintage, according to each person's generosity, provided he gave between the 40th and the 60th part of his revenue; and these last are commonly the first-fruits meant in Scripture. ---

Lord, in sacrifice. If they were given to the priest, the unclean might partake of them. M.

Ver. 14. Vow. Heb. cherem, "anathema:" man, beast, or land might be thus consecrated to God, either for sacrifice, or for the benefit of his priests. Lev.

xxvii. 28. H.

Ver. 15. Beast. The Rabbins restrain this to the ass alone, which they pretend was deemed the only unclean animal by the Israelites, in Egypt, when this law was established; and Moses indeed specifies it alone. Ex. xiii. 13. Abenezra. ---

But we cannot doubt but that camels, and all other unclean animals, were to be included, if the Hebrews kept them; (C.) and those which were rendered impure by some defect, were also to be redeemed. M.

Ver. 16. Of it; the first-born of man. The child might be redeemed sooner, and sometimes they waited till after the purification of the mother, or 40 days, as our blessed Lady did. Lu. ii. 22. C.

--- Five sicles of silver, or about 11 s. 6 d. Eng. were then to be paid, unless poverty obliged them to give only two turtles or pigeons. H. --- Beasts might be redeemed after they were eight days old. Ex. xiii. 12. Leo of Modena, (p. 1. c. 9,) informs us, that when a child is to be redeemed, at present, the father sends for a descendant of Aaron, who, after enquiring of the mother, if she have had no child before; and of the father, if he wish to redeem the infant, says aloud,

"This child, being the first-born, belongs to me; as it is said, (Num. xviii. 16,) Thou shalt redeem the child of a month old for five sicles. But I take this (about two crowns of gold) instead." C. ---

But how can these priests prove their genealogy, since the distinction of the tribes has been so long lost? --- Of silver. Heb. "according to thy estimation, for the money of five sicles, by the sicle of the sanctuary, which hath 20

geras." H.

Ver. 18. Thine. So that thy wife and children, if clean, may eat the flesh. C.

Ver. 19. A covenant of salt. It is a proverbial expression, signifying a covenant not to be altered or corrupted; as salt is used to keep things from corruption; a covenant perpetual, like that by which it was appointed that salt should be used in every sacrifice. Levit. ii. 3. Ch. --- Thus God gave the kingdom to David for ever, by a covenant of salt, 2 Par. xiii. 5. Salt is an emblem of eternity.

Oleaster believes, that salt was used in the ratification of all solemn covenants, to denote their stability. C.

Ver. 20. Nothing. No portion of land, like the other tribes; but only some towns and suburbs, allotted to thy children in the midst of the Israelites. They might purchase land as well as others, and might obtain a property by the vows of their brethren. Lev. xxvii. 14. Jeremias (xxxii. 7) and S. Barnaby had land. Acts.

iv. 37. God had provided for his ministers abundantly, without exposing them to much trouble. The Levites enjoyed the tithes of all the produce of the country, besides the first-fruits of corn, dough, &c. and some parts of each beast that was killed in the town. Deut. xviii. 3. The priests, who were still fewer in number, enjoyed the 100th part of the revenue of all Israel, receiving tithes from the Levites, and innumerable accidental offerings of wine, &c. which made Philo say (de præm. Sacerd.) that "the law of Moses gave the priests all the splendour of kings." They might, therefore, be zealous to preserve religion for their own temporal advantages. --- I am, &c. God promises to reward those who serve him with fidelity.

Deut. xviii. 1. Jos. xiii. 14. The priests of the new law ought more particularly to serve him with disinterestedness, for his own sake. C. --- Of this they are reminded, when they take the first step towards holy orders. The bishop cuts off some of their hair in the form of a cross, while they recite, The Lord is the portion of my inheritance, and of my cup: it is Thou that will restore my inheritance to me. Ps. xv. 5. Pontif. Rom. H. --- "Some possess riches, while they serve Christ, who appeared in the garb of poverty." S. Jerom ad Nepot.

Ver. 22. Deadly sin. That is, sin which will bring death after it. Ch. --- Heb. "lest they bear sin unto death," and fall like their brethren. C. xvii. 13. H.

Ver. 23. People; or the Heb. may be also "they shall bear their own iniquity." If they prove negligent in performing their duty they shall be punished; and if they do not restrain the people from approaching the tabernacle, they shall be answerable for their offence, and both shall incur death. C. --- They shall, however, save their own souls, if they have not been deficient in instructing the people, and in doing their utmost to prevent any profanation. H.

Ver. 27. As an. Thus you will perform your duty, as well as if you gave corn and wine of your own growth. M. --- Presses. Heb. yakeb, means also the tub where wine was kept. Jonathan translates, "as the ripe (old) wine of the tub of your wine-press;" insinuating that the wine must be fit for use. C. v. 29. 30.

Ver. 32. By, &c. Heb. "when you have made a heave-offering of the best of it; nor shall you profane the holy things of," &c. H. --- This they would do, if they gave the worst only to the priests. D. --- There were only three at this time; yet they received the 100th part of the produce of so many thousands. Well therefore might God say, I will fill the souls of the priests with fatness: and my people shall be filled with good things. Jer. xxxi. 14. T.

NUMBERS 19

CHAPTER XIX.

Ver. 2. Observance. Heb. "ceremony." Sept. "distinction, (diastole, S. Aug. q.

33,) or ordinance." C. --- Victim. Heb. "the ordinance of the law." D. --- A red cow, &c. This red cow, offered in sacrifice for sin, and consumed with fire without the camp, with the ashes of which, mingled with water, the unclean were to be expiated and purified; was a figure of the passion of Christ, by whose precious blood, applied to our souls in the holy sacraments, we are cleansed from our sins. Ch. --- Age, three years old. Some translate, "entirely red." They suppose, that these regulations are in opposition to the customs of the Egyptians, who never sacrificed the cow, esteeming it sacred to Isis, or to the moon. Spencer (Rit. ii. 15) adds, that the red colour was formerly in the highest estimation; and this victim represented the death of Christ, who expiated our defilements. The Egyptians immolated bulls of a red colour, in hatred of Typhon, and to appease that dangerous god, whom they depicted perfectly red. Plut. (Isis) observes, that they hate all animals of that colour; and the Copths precipitated a red ass down a precipice. The ancient kings of Egypt sacrificed red men on the tomb of Osiris or Dyphon; (Diod. Bib. 1,) and Manetho assures us, that they scattered their ashes in the wind. If this custom prevailed in the days of Moses, we need not wonder that he teaches the Hebrews to have so little dread of Typhon, as even to chose a red cow in preference, to purify themselves. --- Yoke. Such victims were generally chosen by the Romans, Greeks, and Egyptians, as more delicate and respectful.

Intacta totidem cervice juvenicus. Georg. iv. Bochart, anim. 2. 33. S. Jerom (ep.

27,) says, that a red cow was sacrificed every year, as in reality one would be requisite for all the people, though the Rabbins pretend that only seven, or ten at most, were treated in this manner, from Moses till the destruction of the temple by Titus. Drusius.

Ver. 3. Of all. Heb. "before his face." Sept. "they shall bring her out, slay and burn her before him," which must be referred to some other priests, who accompanied Eleazar on this occasion, v.

8. C. --- Aaron did not perform this office, as the sacrifice was not solemn, but sorrowful, and designed for purification. M. --- The Rabbins say, however, that the high priest performed this ceremony ever after; and, since the building of the temple, they did it upon Mount Olivet. This is also marked by S. Jerom, ep.

27. It was thus a more lively figure of Jesus Christ sweating blood on that same ground; as the smoke might represent his ascension. Acts i. 10. Lu. xxii.

44. C. ---

He died out of Jerusalem, in full age, (v. 2,) or 33 years old, being wounded in every part for our transgressions, (v. 5,) setting us an example how to suffer, (v. 6,) and by his blood communicating virtue to the sacraments, v. 5. His body, derived from Adam, (or red earth, v. 2,) was buried in a most clean place, (v. 9,) and those who crucified him became more unclean; (v. 8) while even those who were employed in burying him (v. 9,) required to be cleansed by the grace of his passion, which must be communicated to them by baptism, in the name of the blessed Trinity, without which they cannot partake of any of the sacraments. C. xii. The old law could bring nothing to perfection. Those who lived under that dispensation, were forced to wait till the evening, (v. 7,) when in the last ages the new law commenced, that by faith in Christ they might obtain the remission of their sins. Thus we perceive the meaning of many things which to the Jews were veiled in shadows. Heb. x. S. Aug. q. 33. Theod.

q. 36. W. --- The Fathers observe also, that the infirmity of our Saviour's flesh, and his liberty in giving and resuming his life, (Jo.

x. 18,) were denoted by the cow, which had never been yoked. C.

Ver. 4. And. Heb. "And Eleazar, the priest, shall take part of her blood with his finger." He looked from the pile of wood, where he was standing, towards the west, and sprinkled the blood, and wiping his fingers upon the skin of the cow, waiting till the fire was kindled, before he opened her belly; he then threw into the fire the cedar-wood, &c. Drusius. --- Others believe that this last ceremony was performed by some one else, (v. 7,) as it is not clear that Eleazar became unclean. His being substituted instead of Aaron, might shew that Christ would institute a new priesthood.

Ver. 6. Dyed. With which the cedar and hyssop were tied together, as being deemed most proper instruments of purifications. Lev. xiv. 4. 49. S. Paul informs us (Heb. ix. 19,) that Moses thus sprinkled the people and the book: and branches of this description were probably used when the people took this holy water, v. 18. The ashes intimate that those who have sinned, may be purified by the sacrament of penance, v. 9. C.

Ver. 10. Strangers. Even those who had not embraced the Jewish religion.

Grotius. --- Thus, the baptism of Christ brings salvation both to the Jews and to the Gentiles. S. Aug.

Ver. 12. Seventh. If he neglect to be sprinkled on the third day, his purification will be protracted till the 10th. As this was the only means of removing the legal uncleanness contracted by touching a dead body, some of the ashes must have been reserved in various parts of the country, after the Israelites were dispersed. C.

Ver. 13. Upon him, unless he be excused by ignorance, (Lev. v. 3. 6,) he shall be slain.

Ver. 14. Days. Almost all nations seem to have considered themselves defiled by the presence of a corpse. Virgil (*Æn. vi. 149,*) writes, *Præterea jacet exanimus tibi corpus amici*---*Heu nescis! totamque incestat funere classem.*

Ver. 15. Cover. Sam. "neither chains nor bands." Formerly boxes were tied down. Hom. Odys.

viii. If the covering of any hollow vessel was off, when a corpse was present, it became unclean.

C.

Ver. 16. Grave. The Hebrews buried it at a distance from towns, and set up some mark to apprise all people, that they might not be defiled for seven days.

C.

Ver. 17. Burning of the red cow, which was also a sin-offering, v. 9. H. --
- Upon the ashes they poured some running or spring water. The pagans generally preferred the water of the sea; or if they could not procure any, they mixed salt with common water. Ovid (Fast iv,) mentions a lustration made with the ashes of a calf, mixed with horse blood; and another, which was used in honour of Pales, the goddess of harvests, by the oldest virgins present, who sprinkled the ashes of calves, populos purget ut ille cinis. Athenæus (ix. 18,) observes that a stick was taken from the fire of the altar, was extinguished in water for the purification of the unclean; and the ancient Romans, who had been at a funeral, sprinkled themselves with water, and jumped over fire for the same purpose; as the Greeks were accustomed to place a vessel full of water, at the doors where a corpse was lying, that all might purify themselves when they came out. C.

Ver. 20. Church, or assembly of the people. H. --- He shall be put to death by the judges, or by God. M.

Ver. 21. Evening. The victims which were appointed for the expiation of sin, communicated a legal uncleanness to those who were employed about them.

They were looked upon as so holy, that the most pure were guilty of a sort of irreverence by touching them. C.

Ver. 22. Is unclean, by touching the dead, must remain defiled seven days. But those whom he touches, as well as all who may have communication with them in infinitum, may be purified in the evening. C.

NUMBERS 20

CHAPTER XX.

Ver. 1. Sin, Zin, or Tsin, nearer to Judea than the desert, where the Hebrews encamped before.

Ex. xvi. 1. H. --- Moses informs us of very little from the time when the people murmured at Cades-barne, in the second year, till the beginning of the 40th year of their sojournment. --- In Cades. The Rabbins assert, they remained there the first time twenty-nine years, (C. xiv. 45,) and the second, ten.

Genebrard, A.M. 2670. But we do not believe they continued there above a year the first time. --- Mary. S. Gregory of Nyssa, and S. Ambrose, suppose she was always a virgin, in which respect she was a figure of our blessed Lady, as well as in her name. She was probably 130 years old, as she was very discreet at the time of the birth of Moses, and employed by Providence in preserving his life, as the blessed Virgin screened our Saviour from the fury of Herod. She had the superintendence over the Hebrew women; (Ex. xv. 20. Theod. in Mic.

vi. 4,) and hence many apply to her and her brothers those words of Zacharias, (xi. 8,) I cut off three shepherds in one month. Mary died without being permitted to enter the promised land, on account of her murmuring, C. xii.

Thus the synagogue, though proud of her prerogatives, cannot enter the land of rest. C. --- There. Some place this Cades not far from the Red Sea, (v. 20,) south of Idumea, while the other was to the north, and nearer Chanaan, being generally called Cades-barne. Bonfrere and C. a Lapide. C. xx. 16. --- In this place Mary died, four months before Aaron. M.

Ver. 3. Brethren, Core, &c. (C. xvi. 32,) or with them he died (C. xi.) at the graves of lust. C.

Ver. 6. And cried...to murmur. These words are not found in the Heb., Sept., &c.

nor in the new edition of S. Jerom, though they occur in most of the Latin MSS.

C. --- If it be an addition, it must be very ancient. Mariana.

Ver. 8. The rod, with which Moses had wrought so many miracles, and which was placed in the tabernacle, v. 9. It is called his rod, in the Heb. v. 11. We do not find that the rod of Aaron, which budded, was used to work miracles. ---

Thou. Sept. "you." Both Moses and Aaron concurred in the action, (v. 12,) but Moses was the chief agent. C.

Ver. 10. Rock. Your frequent murmurs will stop the course of God's bounty. If God had not condemned the conduct of his ministers on this occasion, we could hardly find any reason to blame them. But the Fathers observe, that they betrayed a want of resolution, and intended to throw the blame upon the incredulity of the people, in case they failed of success. Because they exasperated his spirit, and he distinguished with his lips. Ps. cv. 33. See S.

Chrys. and S. Aug.

on this psalm. They were not commanded to strike the rock at all; and when the water did not come at first, they struck again, (C.) being afraid lest they should now be taken for impostors. H.

--- They speak as if the work was their own. --- Can we, &c. They exasperate the people, instead of promoting their conversion. In a word, they did not glorify God, (C.) by representing him as the sovereign holiness and mercy; and the God of unbounded power. H.

Ver. 11. The rock. This rock was a figure of Christ, and the water that issued out from the rock, of his precious blood, the source of all our good; (Ch.) while the striking twice with the rod, denoted the cross, composed of two pieces of wood. S. Aug. q. 35. W.

Ver. 12. You have not believed, &c. The fault of Moses and Aaron, on this occasion, was a certain diffidence and weakness of faith: not doubting of God's power or veracity; but apprehending the unworthiness of that rebellious and incredulous people, and therefore speaking with some ambiguity. Ch. --- S.

Augustine (c. Faust. xvi. 16,) does not think them guilty of any grievous crime.

M. --- But this must be left undetermined. C. --- Land, beyond the Jordan, which is described (C. xxxiv. 2,) as the land of promise, though the east side of the Jordan was so too.

H.

Ver. 13. The water of contradiction or strife. Heb. Meribah. Ch. --- Sanctified: he shewed the effects of his power and clemency towards the people, and he treated his ministers with a just severity. The Samaritan copy here inserts what we read in Deuteronomy, only it places the speech of Moses in an historical form. "The Moses said, Lord, &c. (C. iii. 24-28.) Moreover, the Lord said to Moses, you shall pass by, " &c. C. ii. 4-6.

Ver. 14. Cades, not far from Mount Hor, on the confines of Idumea, v. 22. and Jud. xi. 16. C.

Ver. 16. Angel, who had performed so many wonders in favour of the Hebrews.

He is generally supposed to have been S. Michael in the cloud.

Ver. 18. Edom, the people who dwelt near Mount Hor. Those of Seir, lying more to the west, (D.) granted them leave to pass, and to buy food. Deut. ii. 28. 29.

Grotius maintains, that the Hebrews might justly have forced a passage upon this refusal; as S. Augustine (q. 44,) says, that they might lawfully have waged war upon the Amorrhites, on the like occasion; and the holy wars have been defended on the same plea, because the Saracens would not suffer the Christians to go in pilgrimage to the holy land. See Mare, lib. i. 1. But Selden (Mare. claus. 20) asserts, that princes have a right to hinder others from passing through their territories; and S. Augustine only excepts one case, when they are sure the strangers can or will do no harm. But how can they obtain this assurance? Calmet answers, the long continuance of the Hebrews near the confines of Seir, without offering any molestation, and their being conducted by so holy a general, might give the people of Hor sufficient security. But at any rate the Israelites could not wage war upon them for refusing a

passage, since they were expressly forbidden by God: Stir not against them, (Deut.

ii. 5,) the people of Seir, nor against any of the Idumeans, the children of Esau, who had taken possession of the country of Horrites. Gen. xiv. 6. The Hebrews seem to have been convinced of this, otherwise they would not have feared their multitudes, nor taken such a circuitous road.

The angel in the cloud directed them to proceed, without molesting their territory. They went, therefore, towards the south, round the land of the Idumeans, who dwelt near the Dead Sea. H.

Ver. 19. Price. Heb. "I will only do one thing, walk through." Sept. "the matter is of no consequence, we go by the mountain." Louis de Dieu translates, "It is not indeed a word, (or idle pretence) I will pass through on foot."

Ver. 22. Hor, in the territory of Cades, or Rekem, which is the same town as Petra. Onkelos.

Josep. Ant. iv. 4. Hor was part of a range of mountains, like Libanus. The Hebrews encamped at a place called Mosera. Deut. x. 6. C.

Ver. 24. People, in the bosom of Abraham, while his body is consigned to the grave. ---

Incredulous. Heb. "you rebelled against," &c. the words were addressed to both. Sept. "you irritated me." H.

Ver. 26. Vesture, or pontifical attire. Eleazar had been anointed already, so that perhaps he stood in need of no other ceremony to be acknowledged high priest. He was dispensed with on this occasion to attend his dying father. The spirit of God gives great encomiums to Aaron. Malac. ii.

4-7. Eccli. xlv. 7. 27. He, at the same time, prefigured Christ, the gospel, and the old law. He spoke plainly, and was allowed to enter the holy of

holies; while Moses was excluded, spoke with difficulty, and had a veil on his face. See S.

Jer. ep. ad Fab. man. 33. But on the other hand, he represented the law with all its defects. He falls into several great faults, and dies despoiled of his glorious vestments, to shew the abrogation of his priesthood. The pagans have, perhaps, introduced some parts of his history into that of Mercury, the god of thieves and of travellers, the messenger of the other gods, whom they adorn with a wand, &c. in imitation of the rod of Aaron, who was the interpreter of Moses, and the head of that people, which wandered for 40 years, after plundering Egypt. C.

Ver. 29. Dead, in the 123d year of his age. M. --- Neither Moses, Aaron, nor Mary, representing the Law, the priests, and the prophets of the Old Testament, could introduce the people into the promised land. This honour was reserved for Josue, the illustrious figure of Jesus Christ, and of his Church. C.

NUMBERS 21

CHAPTER XXI.

Ver. 1. Arad. This was either the name of the king, or of his city, which was situated in the southern parts of Chanaan, and which fell to the share of Hobab, in the tribe of Juda. H. --- When this king heard, by means of his spies, or was informed that Israel intended to make an irruption into his country like spies, without declaring war, or by the way which their spies had marked out either just before, or in the second year after their exit; or in fine, by the road, which the Sept.

leave untranslated, Athrim, and which means "of the spies," he resolved to be beforehand with them; and, coming suddenly upon them, took some spoils, or, according to the Heb. Sept. &c.

"captives." These, by the ancient laws of war, he might either sell or put to death. Vendere cum possis captivum, occidere noli. Horace. Grot. Jur. iii. 7. The Rabbins pretend that this king took fresh courage on account of the death of Aaron, and the consequent disappearance of the cloud, and that he drove the Israelites seven encampments back, as far as Mosera, which they confound with Haseroth.

Ver. 2. Cities. Heb. "I will subject their cities to anathema, or utter destruction."

This vow they probably made at the place called Horma, or "Anathema," which was anciently called Saphaad.

Judg. i. 17. They fully executed their threat under Josue, who defeated the king of Hered, (Jo. xii.

14,) though they destroyed, at present, whatever they could. Arad was afterwards rebuilt by Hobab.

Ver. 3. Anathema. That is, a thing devoted to utter destruction. Ch. --- The explanation of Horma is inserted by S. Jerom. H.

Ver. 4. Edom, one of the princes, had refused them a passage; upon which they went by Salmona to Phunon, (C. xxxiii. 37. 42,) where they probably murmured, (C. v.) and were bitten by the serpents, as we read in this chapter.

C.

Ver. 5. God. They had before often directed their complaints against the two brothers. Now, Aaron being no more, they attack God himself, who had always resented the injury done to his ministers. --- Food. So they call the heavenly manna: thus worldlings loathe the things of heaven, for which they have no relish. Ch. --- Sept. "our soul is indignant at this most empty bread,"

which has no solidity in it, nor support. Many translate the Heb. "most vile bread." Thus, in the blessed eucharist, the substance of bread is removed, and the accidents only appear; so that to the worldly receiver, it seems very empty and light, though in reality it be supersubstantial; containing Christ himself, who fills the worthy communicant with grace and comfort, and enables him to go forward on the road to heaven, without fainting. H.

Ver. 6. Fiery serpents. They are so called, because they that were bitten by them were burnt with a violent heat. Ch. --- Hence they are called seraphim, by which name an order of angels are known. The Egyptians adored a serpent which they called serapis, at Rome; and they represented their god serapis, with a serpent entwining a monstrous figure, composed of a lion, a dog, and a wolf. Macrob. Saturn i. 20. The seraph was a winged serpent. Isai. xiv. 29. and xxx. 6. Such often infested Egypt, in spring, coming from Arabia, unless they were intercepted by the ibis.

Their wings resembled those of bats. Herod. ii. 76. Mela, &c. God probably sent some of this description into the camp of the Israelites. C. --- Some call them præster, (Plin. xxiv. 13,) from their burning; others the hydra, or, when out of water, the chershydra, the venom of which is most dangerous. The Sept. style them simply, "the destroying, or deadly serpents." See Bochart. T. ii.

B. iii. 13. Deut. viii. 15. Wisd. xvi. 5. 10. H.

Ver. 8. Brazen. Heb. "fiery." But, in the following verse, it is said to have been

"of brass." We might translate, "make a seraph, and fix it upon a standard,"

(C.) in which form it would resemble one suspended on a cross. It was placed at the entrance of the tabernacle. S. Just. apol. Ezechias afterwards destroyed it, because it was treated with superstitious honours. 4 K. xviii. 4. Thus the best things are often abused. H. --- God commands this image to be erected, while he forbids all images of idols. W. --- By comparing the different passages of Scripture we may discern the true import of them. Pictures may often prove very useful and instructive. They serve the ignorant instead of books. But then the ignorant must be carefully instructed not to treat them with improper respect, as S. Gregory admonishes. And is not the same caution requisite for those who read even the word of God, lest they wrest it to their own destruction, as both the unlearned and the unstable frequently do. 2 Pet. iii. 16.

If every thing must be rejected which is liable to abuse, what part of the creation will be spared? The Bible, the sacraments, all creatures must be laid aside. For we read, (Rom. viii. 20. 22,) the creature was made subject to vanity

--- every creature groaneth. H. --- It is probable that Moses represented on the standard such a serpent, as had been the instrument of death. This was not intended for a charm or talisman, as Marsham would impiously pretend.

Chron. x. p. 148. Such inventions proceed from the devil; and the Marsi were famous for curing the bites of serpents, by giving certain plates of brass.

Arnob. ii. See Psal.

lviii. 5. But this image was set up by God's express command; and the Book of Wisdom (xvi. 5.

7,) assures us, that the effect was entirely to be attributed to him, the figure of a brazen serpent being rather calculated to increase than to remove the danger. Kimchi. Muis. Hence Jonathan well observes, that only those were healed who raised their hearts to God. C.

Ver. 9. A brazen serpent. This was a figure of Christ crucified, and of the efficacy of a lively faith in him, against the bites of the hellish serpent. John iii.

14. (Ch.) S. Amb. Apol. i. 3. As the old serpent infected the whole human race, Jesus Christ gives life to those that look at him with entire confidence. Theod.

q. 38. The brazen serpent was destitute of poison, though it resembled a most noxious animal; so Jesus Christ assumed our nature, yet without sin. C.

Ver. 10. Oboth, where Obodas, an ancient king of the Nabatheans, was adored.

Hither they came from Phunon, celebrated for its copper-mines, where Bochart believes the Hebrews were bitten by the serpents, though others say that judgment was inflicted upon them at Salmona; which may be derived from tselem enu, "our image."

Ver. 11. Jeabarim, means "the ford, (of Zared, v. 12,) or the straits of passages, passengers, or Hebrews; or the hills Abarim," which extended over the eastern parts of Moab. It was the 38th station, (C.) at the southern extremity of Mount Abarim. H. --- After which Moses specifies those of Zared, (v. 12,) Mathana, Nahaliel, Bamoth, Arnon, (v. 19,) Dibon-gad, and Helmon-dablataim, (C.) all on the sides of that

mountain, before they came to the summit, which was also called Phasga and Nabo. C. xxxiii. 45, &c. But Pococke reckons only the two last among the stations, and makes those of Abarim and Shittim the 41st and 42d. The Sept. read, "they encamped in Achelgai, on the other side, in the desert." H. --- Eusebius and S. Jerom call this station of Jee, Gai or Hai, which they place near Petra. Jer. xlix. 4. --- East. The Sam. here inserts, (Deut. ii. 9,)

"And the Lord said to Moses, Fight not, " &c.

Ver. 12. Zared. The Israelites passed over this torrent, 38 years after the murmur at Cades-barne, (Deut. ii. 14,) when God ordered Moses not to attack the Moabites.

Ver. 13. Against. Heb. "on the other, or on this side of (the river, v. 14) Arnon,"

which runs from the east, almost in the same direction as the torrent of Zared, but empties itself into the Dead Sea higher up, near the mouth of the Jordan.

C. --- It divides the Moabites from their brethren, the children of Ammon, who lay to the north-east. The Hebrews encamped on the south side of this river, in the desert of Cademoth, (Deut. ii. 26,) whence they sent to ask leave of Sehon to pass through his dominions; but, on his refusal, God ordered them to cross the Arnon by force. C.

Ver. 14. The book of the wars, &c. An ancient book, which, like several others quoted in Scripture, has been lost. Ch. --- S. Augustine (q. 42) thinks this book was written by one of that country. Others believe that Moses wrote a more detailed account of the wars which he had to wage with the Amalecites, (Ex.

xvii. 14,) and these other nations, out of which he has only inserted some of the heads in the Pentateuch. But whether these two verses were taken from another work of Moses, or from the history of some other person, they are now of divine authority. Saul says to David, (1 K. xviii. 17,) fight the battles of the Lord,...and the children of God and of

Ruben pass all armed for war before the Lord, (C. xxxii. 29. C.) whence it appears, that the wars of the Hebrews were attributed to God. Tostat is of opinion, that the Book of the Just, is the same with that to which Moses here refers. See Jos. x. 13. 2 K. i. 18. But Theodoret thinks rather, that the former was a more extensive account of the transactions of Josue, out of which the book which bears his name was compiled. Such records certainly existed, to which the sacred historians frequently refer: and it is very probable, that a work of this nature was compiled in the days of Moses, or perhaps before his time. S. Aug. C. D. xviii. As it contained a prediction, respecting the future wars, in which the Hebrews were about to engage, it could not but make a suitable impression upon them. It might already be in every one's mouth, and the Heb. may insinuate, that it would be handed down to the latest posterity: "Wherefore in the history, or account of the wars of the Lord, this also shall be mentioned," *jamor, dicetur*.

According to this interpretation, it would not be necessary to suppose, that Moses refers to any more ancient book, as *sepher* means also, "a narration"

by word of mouth; and Rabbi Menachem believes, that God had revealed this event to Moses, encouraging him with the assurance, that he would give him the victory over the nations bordering upon the Arnon, as he had done over the Egyptians and Amalecites at the Red Sea. See Sixt. Senens. H. --- Of Arnon, the waters of which are supposed to have given the Hebrews a passage, as the Chaldee asserts on the authority of Ps.

lxxiii. 15. Habacuc (iii. 13) also mentions that several rivers were dried up by God. The Hebrew text is almost unintelligible, "From, or against, Vahab to Supha." As there is no verb, some translate, "he (Sehon) fought against Vaheb (Grotius reads Moab) at Supha, or he came to Veb. "

But Calmet would substitute Zared instead of Vaheb: "The encamped at the torrent of Zared, and came to Supha, (Deut. i. 1, where we read the Red Sea) to the torrent of Arnon." Protestants translate, "What he did in the Red Sea, and in the brooks of Arnon, (16) and at the stream

of the brooks that goeth down to the dwelling or Ar, and lieth upon the border of Moab." H.

Ver. 15. The rocks. Some assert that the rocks fell upon the enemy: others, that they gave way and opened a passage for the Hebrews, while the rivers were also dried up. Heb. "They encamped on the stream of the torrents, which bends towards the dwelling (or city) of Ar, and rests upon the frontiers of Moab." Thus the book to which Moses alludes, confirms his account of these different encampments. C. --- The Sept. give rather a different turn of these two verses:

"Hence it is said in a book, The war of the Lord has burnt Zoob and the torrents of Arnon---and has sent the torrents to inhabit Er: and it lies upon the borders of Moab." The river, it seems, had been removed out of its bed by a subterraneous fire or earthquake, and deluged the city of Ar, belonging to Moab. The mighty hand of God terrified those nations, while all nature fought against the wicked and the unwise. Wisd. v. 21. H. --- Rocks were hurled upon the heads of the Amorrites, and the waters conveyed their dead bodies into the vale of Moab. W.

Ver. 16. Well. Heb., Beer. H. --- This station is not mentioned under the same name at least, C.

xxxiii. Probably the inhabitants had covered up this well with sand, and God having discovered it to Moses, he informed the princes, who pushed their staves down. Upon which the waters appearing, the people sung a hymn of thanksgiving and joy. Water is very scarce, and, of course, of great value in those deserts, where even still the Arabs conceal their wells, and often fight to hinder passengers from taking any of the water. C.

Ver. 17. They sung. Heb. "sing ye unto it," in chorus, men and women. Sept.

"commence a canticle unto it. This well the princes dug, the kings of nations hewed in the rock, in their kingdom, while they held dominion."

Ver. 18. Mathana. Perhaps they did not stop here, though all the encampments are not specified, C. xxxiii. Nahaliel, "God my torrent," and Bamoth, "the heights," are also situated upon the Arnon.

Ver. 20. Desert. Heb. and Chal. "Yeshimon," (Jos. xiii. 28. Ezec. xxv. 9,) a city of the Moabites.

Ver. 21. Messengers, not from the city of Cademoth, which was in the midst of Phasga, but from a desert of the same name, situated out of the dominions of Sehon. Deut. ii. 24. Euseb. --- God had already promised this country to Abraham, and though Moses did not intend to attack the king at present, being eager to fall upon the Chanaanites on the other side of the Jordan, God punishes the refusal of Sehon to let his people pass, by a swifter destruction.

C. --- The measure of his crimes was full, though the mere denial of a passage to such a vast multitude might even be justified by sound policy. H.

Ver. 22. Wells. We shall content ourselves with the torrents. They had only to travel about thirty miles. C.

Ver. 23. Jasa was not far from the Arnon, between Medaba and Dibon. Isai. xv.

4. Euseb.

Ver. 24. Garrison, either against Sehon, or against the Hebrews, whom God did not, as yet, authorize to attack the Ammonites, (C.) though the latter knew it not. H.

Ver. 26. Arnon. Hence this territory, which formerly belonged to Moab, being taken in a just war, the Moabites could not lawfully retain it, as they attempted to do under Jephthe. Jud. xi. 13.

Grot. Jur. iii. 6. --- Hesebon, or Esbus, was the capital, and lay over-against Jericho, twenty miles from the Jordan.

Ver. 27. Proverb. Heb. Moshelim: "Those who speak proverbs, or enigmas, say." Those were the ancient poets of the Amorrrhites, who composed this canticle on the victory of Sehon. C. ---

Moses inserts it in his work, as an additional proof, that the country was entirely lost to Moab, and as a denunciation of the evils which still hung over the head of that people, and would be inflicted upon them by David, &c. 2 K. x.

i. and 4 K. iii. 16. Amos i. 13. H.

Ver. 28. A fire and flame, denote the horrors of war. Jud. ix. 20. --- Ar. Sam. and Sept. read ad,

"hath consumed even the country of the Moabites and the lords (or pillars, Sept.) of Bamoth, (the heights mentioned in v. 18, 19,) on the Arnon." These lords may be the principal men, priests, or gods of the city. Jeremias (xlviii.

45,) reads this passage in a different manner, "it (the flame) shall devour part of Moab, and the crown of the head of the children of tumult." The city of Ar (which some confound with Aroer) always

continued in the hands of the Moabites, so that the efforts of Sehon against it, seem to have proved abortive.

Deut. ii. 9. 18. 29. Bonfrere. See C.

xxiv. 17.

Ver. 29. He. Chamos, the idol of Moab, is upbraided as too weak to defend his people. The pagans generally formed their judgments of the power of their gods, by the event; and, if that proved unfortunate, they were ever ready to consign the idols to the flames. Chamos was probably the sun. C. --- Some say he was Bacchus, whom the Greeks call Komas. M.

Ver. 30. Hesebon in the north, to Dibon in the southern extremity of the conquered country, near the Arnon, where Moses places the station of Dibongad. The yoke, or dominion of the Moabites, was ruined in all those parts. C. ---

Heb. "We have shot at them; or their lamp, (children or power,) from Hesebon as far as Dibon, is extinguished; and their wives (or we have destroyed them) even unto Nophe and Medaba." Sept. "Their women have still kindled a fire against Moab." Nophe is probably the Nabo of Isaias, (xv. 2,) in the environs of Medaba, where the fainting Moabites had time to breathe. The fire, which the Sept. say the women enkindled against Moab, might seem to indicate that the war was commenced on their account, like that which brought on the destruction of Troy. They entailed a still heavier destruction upon their country, when, by alluring the Hebrews to sin, they enkindled God's indignation. C. xxv.

With this verse the quotation, from the Amorrhite proverbial writers, concludes, v. 27. H.

Ver. 32. Jazer, a famous city, 15 miles from Hesebon, given afterwards to the Levites. Moses

" took the Amorrhites who were there" prisoners, according to the Heb.; or,

"drove them away,"

(Sept.) putting to death those who continued to make resistance. C.

Ver. 33. Og, the king of the most fertile country of Basan, was of gigantic stature. Deut. iii. 11.

The Rabbins relate many fables concerning him. --- Edrai was 15 miles to the north of the torrent Jeboc, (C.) which was the southern extremity of this territory. H.

NUMBERS 22

CHAPTER XXII.

Ver. 1. Plains. Sept. "to the west of Moab." These plains had formerly belonged to that people, but the Hebrews had lately taken them from Sehon, and intended now to pass over the Jordan.

The Moabites, however, being jealous of their growing power, called in the aid of the Madianites, and of the magician Balaam, and, by their wanton provocation, brought destruction upon themselves. We know not exactly the extent of the dominions of the Moabites. They seemed to have lost the greatest part of the country north of the Arnon. Their last town and capital was Ar.

C. xxi. 13. Yet they still kept possession of Mount Phasga. C.

Ver. 3. Of him: Israel. M. --- They knew not that God had forbidden the Hebrews to attack the Moabites, unless they were first assailed. Joseph. --- Heb. "Moab was much afraid of the people, because of their numbers, and was distressed (

and upon his guard) on account of the children of Israel." H.

Ver. 4. Elders of Madian, who dwelt also upon the Arnon, towards the lake of Sodom. These Madianites were a different people from those who inhabited the country to the east of the Red Sea. S. Jerom --- They were not governed by kings, but by an aristocracy, or senate of princes.

H.

Ver. 5. Beor. S. Peter (ii. 11, 15) reads Bosor. --- A soothsayer, or magician, (ariolum) as this word always indicates. Jos. xiii. 22. The Hebrews believe he was once a true prophet, a descendant of Buz, the son of Melcha, and the same as Eliu, the friend of Job. S. Jer. q. 3. Heb. in Gen.) He certainly foretold the Messias, or star of Jacob, by divine inspiration. C. xxiv. 17. H.

--- He consults and acknowledges the true God, v. 8. 18. 20. Origen (hom. 13,) believes that he left a book of his prophecies, which was known to the wise men, and discovered to them the birth of the Messias; and some Rabbins think that Moses has here inserted from that work what relates to Balaam. S.

Augustine (q. 48) shews that he was a wicked man, of whom nevertheless God made use to convey important instructions; and that he is one of those reprobates who will say, Lord, have we not prophesied in thy name? He is placed with Cain and Core. S. Jude 11. S.

Ambrose (ep. 50,) observes, that he might prophesy, like Caiphas, without knowing what he said, and that the gift of prophecy on this occasion, was no proof of his virtue. Many of the Fathers look upon him as a mere magician, who could utter no blessing, but only curses, by the rules of his infernal art.

He did not design to consult God, but the Lord puts answers into his mouth.

Theod. q. 39. 42. The method of consultation seemed to border on superstition. He wished to make God change his resolutions, as if he were an idol, and attempted to evade the impressions of his spirit. C. --- The river, Euphrates, which waters the country of the Ammonites. M. - -- Heb.

"to Pethora, which is by the land of the children of his people." S. Jerom has translated Pethora

"soothsayer," and left Ammon un declined. H. --- The Chaldee informs us, that he was a resident at Petor, a city of Syria, on the Euphrates. It is probably the same town with the Pacora of Ptolemy, near Thapsacus. Balaam is styled an Aramean; (C. xxiii. 17,) and we know that he came from Mesopotamia. Hebrew Aram Naharaim, (Deut. xxiii. 4. C.) or "Syria, between the two rivers," the Euphrates and Tigris. Salien. --- Me, ready to fall upon my dominions. It appears hence, that Balaam was in high estimation, since a distant king depends more upon his power, that upon the efforts of all his own armies, and those of his auxiliaries, and is willing to pay him for cursing his enemies at do dear a rate. Perhaps he thought that they employed magical arts to conquer their enemies, by prayer. See Ex. xvii. 11. Orig. hom. 13. H.

Ver. 6. Curse. The ancients placed great confidence in those whom they believed to be under the guidance of a superior spirit, whether good or bad.

They thought their blessing or cursing would surely have its effect. By means of charms, they also strove to evoke or draw off the tutelary god of a place, before they could expect to take possession of it. Hence, as it was requisite to mention the true name of the place, fictitious names were given to most cities of importance, while the real appellation was kept a profound secret; and Valerius Soranus was severely punished for discovering the name of Rome, Valentia. See Plin. iii. 5. Solin. ii. Plut. prob. vi. C. --- Rome, in Greek, has the same import as Valentia in Latin, and signifies strength. H. --- Macrobius has preserved the form of a solemn curse, pronounced by the Roman general against the Carthaginians. Saturn iii. 9. "Dis Pater, or Jupiter, or if you prefer any other title, I beg that you will send fright and terror, and put this city of Carthage, and this army which I intend to specify, to flight, &c. If you will perform these things, according to my intention, I promise to offer in sacrifice to you, O earth, mother of all things, and to you, great god Jupiter, three black sheep."

Thus, probably, Balac wished the Hebrews to be devoted or cursed. C.

Ver. 7. The price. Heb. lit. "the enchantments." But they took money, to engage the soothsayer to comply more readily with their iniquitous request. 2 Pet. ii.

15. Sept. &c. It was customary to offer presents to the prophets. 1 K. ix. 7.

Ver. 8. Night. He was accustomed to exercising his art by night; loving darkness, for his works were evil. Jo. iii. 19. H.

Ver. 18. Less. Not that he was resolved to comply with God's will, but because he found an insuperable impediment to oppose it at present. C.

Ver. 19. To stay. His desiring them to stay, after he had been fully informed already that it was not God's will he should go, came from the inclination he had to gratify Balac for the sake of worldly gain. And this perverse disposition God punished by permitting him to go, (though not to curse the people, as he would willingly have done) and suffering him to fall still deeper and deeper into sin, till he came at last to give that abominable counsel against the people of God, which ended in his own destruction. So sad a thing it is to indulge a passion for money. Ch. S.

Aug. q. 48. --- Philo (de vita, Mos. i) thinks that Balaam feigned this leave of God, v. 22. C.

Ver. 22. Angry. Either because he had not granted him permission to go, or he saw that Balaam was disposed to curse the Israelites, v. 32. Sept. "the angel (Michael) rose up on the road to oppose him, " diaballein. Lit. "to calumniate, accuse, resist, or to be a satan." Hence diabolus means an accuser, opponent, calumniator, &c. S. Aug. H.

Ver. 23. Ass. The angel appeared thrice to the ass, before he was perceived by Balaam. C. xxix.

3. 4. The second time, S. Augustine (q. 50) thinks he was standing in the vineyard. C.

Ver. 28. Opened the mouth, &c. The angel moved the tongue of the ass, to utter these speeches, to rebuke, by the mouth of a brute beast, the brutal fury and folly of Balaam. Ch. --- S. Thomas (ii. 2. q. 105,) says, an angel spoke by the mouth of the ass, in like manner as the devil did by that of the serpent. Gen. iii.

Infidels deride this miracle, and some have thought that it was only in the imagination of Balaam, that this dialogue was formed. Maimon. --- S. Gregory of Nyssa, seems to think that the ass only brayed as usual, and that the soothsayer, being accustomed to augur from the voice of animals, understood its meaning. But S. Peter says, the dumb beast...speaking with man's voice, forbade the folly of the prophet. 2 Pet. ii. 16. God did not endue it with understanding on this occasion, but only formed, by its mouth, such sounds as might serve to repress the cruel folly of Balaam. But he was more stupid than the ass. "Being accustomed, it seems, to such prodigies," (monstres) and intent upon lucre, he paid no further regard to such a wonderful transaction, but held conversation with his ass, without any emotion.

S. Aug. q. 48. 50. C. --- The pagan historians relate many instances of beasts and trees speaking; (Grotius) so that they object to this history, and to that of the serpent, with a very bad grace, as S.

Cyril remarks, in his third book against Julian. H. --- They relate that the ass of Bacchus spoke to him, and the horse and elephant of Achilles and Porus addressed their respective masters, while the oaks of Dodona were famous for their oracles. C. --- The river Causus said, "Hail, Pythagoras." Porphyrius, cited by S. Cyril, &c. H.

Ver. 31. Ground, with religious worship; not as God, but as an angel. See Ex.

xx. W.

Ver. 36. A town. Eusebius thinks it was Ar, the capital.

Ver. 39. City, &c. Heb. "Kiryath, chutsoth. " Calmet would read Hares, a city mentioned, Isai.

xvi. 7. 11, and stiled the walls of brick, (4 K. iii. 25,) being the same with Ar. But then the former town must be situated some where upon the frontiers of Moab, as they came from it to the capital. H.

Ver. 40. With him. Only two servants were mentioned, (v. 22,) and the princes sent by Balac, v.

15. Perhaps others from Mesopotamia might attend Balaam. H. --- The king sent parts of the victims to all. Chal.

Ver. 41. People. From the heights or temple of Baal, or the god of Chamos, where a statue or pillar (Sept.) was erected in his honour, (C.) on Mount Arabim, (M.) the soothsayer was enabled to take a distinct view of all the camp of Israel, (C. xxiii. 13,) and not of a part only, as the Sept.

and Arab. versions would insinuate. It was deemed necessary to have those present upon whom people intended to vent their imprecations. C.

NUMBERS 23

CHAPTER XXIII.

Ver. 2. Altar. They both join in sacrificing to Chamos or the devil, whom Balaam styles his lord, Yehovah: but the true God was pleased to hinder the idol from interfering at present, and answered Balaam, in order that he might see the folly of his conduct and repent; and that others, who were more willing to listen to him, than to the servants of God, might be instructed by his declaration. H. --- "God's voice is heard sounding from a profane mouth." S.

Jer. de 42. mans.

W.

Ver. 4. Speed. Heb. shephi, may signify also "on the straight road," (Sept.) "into the plain,"

(Louis de Dieu) "all alone," (Onkelos) or most probably "upon an eminence."

Kimchi. C. ---

God, in the visible form of an angel. M. --- To him. Balaam might suppose that he was addressing his idol. But Moses informs us, that the true God or his angel was present, and forced Balaam to deliver an unwelcome message to the king. H.

Ver. 7. Parable. Beginning to speak in a beautiful and poetic style, like a man inspired. C. ---

Mashal, denotes a striking and elegant prophecy. M. --- Aram, when placed alone, properly means Syria; but when Padan or Naharaim are added, Mesopotamia is meant, whence Balaam came. Deut. xxii. 5. --- East of Moab, though lying to the north, or higher part of Mesopotamia.

C.

Ver. 9. Hills. But all in vain. C. --- I am prevented from cursing him; and if I should do it, my imprecations would be turned into blessings by a superior Being. H. --- Alone, without standing in need of any auxiliaries, and devoid of fear. Deut. xiii. 28. Jer. xlix. 31. The Jews had but few connections with foreign nations, keeping at a distance from them, as being of a different religion.

C. --- Indeed, when they applied for aid to the Egyptians, &c. it generally turned out to their detriment, that they might learn to trust in God alone, who would effectually protect them, if they observed his law, as he had repeatedly promised. H. --- Nations. Israel shall not be like other people. He is under the peculiar care of God, covered with glory, full of confidence, and inspired with the love of independence; so that he will have nothing to do with the rest of the world. C.

Ver. 10. Dust. God had promised to multiply the seed of Abraham as the dust of the earth. Gen.

xiii. 16. Balaam had just beheld several thousands of them, and in rapture, exclaims, according to the Heb. "Who can count the dust of Jacob, and the number of the fourth part of Israel?" Their camp was divided into four great battalions, surrounding the ark and the Levites. Who can tell the number of one of these divisions, much less of all the multitudes there assembled, and what millions may, in a short time, proceed from them? You have reason, therefore, O Balac, to tremble, if they continue faithful to their God. But strive to make friends with them. --- Let, &c.

Heb. may also admit of the version of the Sept. "May my soul die among the souls of the just, and may my offspring be like this." We behold in this sentence, the sentiments of all worldly and interested people, who wish to obtain a reward without submitting to the necessary labour.

Impotent desires! selfish views! H. --- "All," says S. Bernard, (in Cant. serm.

21,) "wish to enjoy the felicity which Jesus Christ has promised. But how few are willing to imitate Him who invites us to do it." C. --- Thus, infidels desire sometimes to die like Catholics, though they will not live in that religion. W. ---

Even those who are in the Church, frequently give into this delusion, making fine prayers, and, in the time of temptation, forgetting all their sighs and tears, to whom God will say, as S. Gregory justly observes on those words of Job, xli. 3. I will not spare him nor his mighty words, and framed to make supplication. For, like Balaam, when the fit of devotion is over, such people are ready to give the most pernicious advice against the lives of those, whom they pretend they would be desirous to resemble in death. "That prayer is vain, which is not followed by continual perseverance in charity." S. Greg. Mor.

xxxiii. 27. The false prophet says not a word about living like the just; he only wishes, that after his soul has enjoyed all the pleasures of this world, it may depart to joys eternal, while his posterity is left behind in the midst of temporal prosperity. --- Soul die, or be separated from its body. Even Balaam establishes the immortality of the soul. H.

Ver. 13. Thence. He has a mind to try a new experiment. We have observed, that the object of malediction was to be in view. C. xxii. 41. But Balac, supposing perhaps that the multitude made too deep an impression upon the soothsayer, judged it expedient to place him in another situation, where he might see only a part of Israel. Some, however, imagine that he had only seen a fourth part, or the uttermost part of the people, who lay nearest to him before; (v. 10, and C. xxii. 41,) and hence, would have him to take now a distinct view of the whole; and, in this sense, the Samaritan and Glassius translate from whence, &c. thus, "for thou hast seen only part of Israel, and couldst not see them all." C. --- By a similar superstition, the Syrians imagined that the God of Israel was a God of the hills, and that they could more easily conquer his people on the plain country, 3 K. xx. 23. M.

**Ver. 14. Place. Hebrew sede tsohpim, or "the field of the sentinels."
Chald.**

**Such were commonly stationed on the top of high hills, to give notice,
by kindling a fire, &c. of the approach of an enemy. Is. xxi. 11. Jer. vi. 1.
C.**

**Ver. 18. Hear. Heb. "to me." Sept. read had, instead of hadai, and
translate,**

"Give ear, thou witness, (martus) son," &c. H.

**Ver. 19. Changed. Heb. "repent." Sept. "to be overawed by threats."
Origen, "to be terrified."**

**In the book of Judith, (viii. 15,) it is said, For God will not threaten like
man, nor be inflamed to anger, like the son of man. C. --- Do. Will he
suffer me to curse Israel, after he has once given me a decided
prohibition? M.**

**Ver. 20. To bless, not by my own intention, or by that of Balac, but by
God, who hath only suffered me to proceed on my journey, on
condition that I would declare his will. C. xxii. 35. H.**

**--- Heb. "Behold, I have received an order to bless;" or, with the Sept.
"I have been chosen to pronounce a blessing; I will bless, and will not
revoke, or leave off." C.**

**Ver. 21. Image-god, (simulachrum) "a statue." Chal. "falsehood." Heb.
may also signify**

**"perversity, or punishment." As long as Israel refrains from idol-
worship, and from other transgressions, as they do at present, God will
be so far from punishing them, that he will fight their battles, as their
king; (H.) and at the sound of the silver trumpets will grant them
victory. C.**

x. 9. M. --- The sound. Heb. "the shout of a king among them," encouraging his people by his presence and by his words. H. --- "I behold those who do not serve idols in the house of Jacob...the word of the Lord their God is helping them, and the majesty of their king is among them." Chaldee. M.

Ver. 22. Rhinoceros. Heb. ream, which is sometimes rendered unicorn. Bochart thinks it means the oryx, or the strong Arabian goat. The animal, of which the Scripture so often speaks, was remarkable for its strength, (C.) and could not easily be tamed. Job xxxix. 9. H. --- The Sept.

generally translate monoceros, which is a fish, with a horn proceeding from its upper jaw. This is often shewn in cabinets for the horn of the unicorn. There are various animals which have only one horn. Pliny and Aristotle instance the oryx, &c. Various authors of credit specify likewise the rhinoceros, which has

"a horn upon its nose," and is found in Ethiopia. The emperor of that country sent one to the court of Persia, which Chardin saw and describes. It is as large as an elephant, and the people have learnt the method of taming both these huge beasts. C. --- It seems the art was unknown in the days of Job, if this be the animal of which he speaks. H. --- Moses (Deut. xxxiii. 17,) seems to attribute two horns to the ream; and Pausanius allows a greater and a less one to the rhinoceros; the latter is very strong and erect. It is of a brownish colour.

C. ---

Whatever may be the precise meaning of ream, it certainly denotes an animal of superior strength, and very formidable. Balaam represents God, or the people of Israel, in this light. God had given repeated instances of his dominion over all nature, in delivering the Hebrews out of Egypt. They were also capable of striking the Moabites with terror, on account of their own prowess, and surprising numbers, v. 24. H.

Ver. 23. Soothsaying. This may be joined to what goes before, as an explanation why Israel is so much to be feared; because the people have

no dealings with the devil, in which case neither he nor all his agents can hurt them, since God is their protector, and will direct them when and how to act. ---

Hath wrought. Sept. "will bring to perfection." Orig. c. Cels. The Heb. may also signify, "undoubtedly there is no charm powerful enough against...Israel," or

"Jacob has no regard for the vain art of divination. Israel does not apply to augury. This very time will be memorable among their posterity for the wonders which God has wrought." Indeed, never was there a greater display of the Divine power in favour of the Hebrews, than in this 40th year after their exit from Egypt; and in the following, which was noted for the victories and miracles of Josue.

H.

Ver. 24. Lioness. Sept. "lion's whelp." Some explain the Heb. "a lion" of full growth and strength. But the antithesis of the Vulgate is more natural and beautiful. C. --- The lioness, being solicitous for its young ones, becomes more furious. --- A lion, ready to fall upon its prey. So Israel will not lay down the sword till he has conquered the nations of Chanaan, (M.) and those who dare to molest him. The allusion to the prediction of Jacob in favour of Juda seems very plain. Gen. xlix. 9. H.

Ver. 25. Neither, &c. When infidels cannot prevail upon people to side with them entirely, in their false worship, they endeavour to induce them at least not to bless, nor follow up the true religion. W.

Ver. 28. Phogor. Heb. "Pehor, which looketh towards Jeshimon, or the desert."

This was a part of the same chain of the mountains Abarim, with Phasga, v. 14.

Balac foolishly supposed that in a different aspect, he might still obtain what he wanted; and the soothsayer was no less infatuated in following him. But he soon felt an internal monitor, who informed him, that he need not put himself to no farther trouble, in retiring alone, to prepare himself for the operation of the spirit.

More glorious predictions in favour of Israel, presented themselves so forcibly, that he could hardly refrain, and durst no longer forbear proclaiming them aloud. C. xxiv. 1. H.

NUMBERS 24

CHAPTER XXIV.

Ver. 1. Divination. Sept. "to meet the birds." The augurs judged of future events by the flying, eating, and other appearances of birds. Heb. "enchantments." M.

--- Desert. The plains of Moab, where the Israelites were encamped. He found himself, as it were, involuntarily transported by the spirit of God, v. 2. C. --- Yet, for all that, he did not become more holy. Some work miracles, and are damned. S. Matt. vii. 22. W.

Ver. 3. Up. The same term only occurs again, (Lament. iii. 8,) where it may have the same sense, though the Sept. &c. give it here a quite opposite meaning,

"the man whose eyes are open," the prophet. But Balaam alludes to his not being able to see the angel as soon as his ass, as he does, v. 4. C. xxii. 31. C.

Ver. 4. Falleth. Out of respect to God, or in a trance. Sept. "in sleep, his eyes are uncovered."

He was accustomed to commune with the spirits in the night. C. xxii. 8. H. ---

He who is clear-sighted enough in teaching others, neglecteth his own salvation; or, being naturally incapable of diving into futurity, he derives this power solely from the operation of the spirit. M.

Ver. 6. Woody. Heb. also "extensive torrents." --- Tabernacles. Heb. ahalim, which some render lign-aloes, or stacte, as S. Jerom does, Ps. xlv. 9. Prov. vii.

17. Cant. iv. 14. The aloe-tree, however, was brought from India, and was not common in Arabia. The Syrian aloe was only a shrub; and this

tree, of which Balaam speaks, must have been tall and beautiful. ---
Pitched. Heb.

"planted." C. --- The Sept. agree however with the Vulg. H. --- Side.
Cedars grow very large on the top of Libanus, and are always green;
the fruit resembles the pine-apple; the wood is incorruptible. Sionita 6.
By humility we must rise to the summit of perfection. D.

Ver. 7. Waters. Sept. Chal. and Syr. "From his seed a man shall spring,
who shall have dominion over many nations." This must be understood
of the Messias; or, his posterity shall be very numerous; (see Prov. v. 15.
16,) or his country shall be well watered, and his crops luxuriant. ---

Agag. Saul lost his crown for sparing the king of the Amalecites, who
always took this title, 1 K.

xv. 9. Heb. may be translated, "Above Agag shall his (Israel's) king be
exalted, yet," &c. or "and his kingdom shall increase." Philo and S.
Ambrose read, "his kingdom shall be raised on high."

The Sam. and some copies of the Sept. have, "Over Gog;" while others
have Og, (C.) which may be referred to the king of Basan, who, though
lately overthrown, had been possessed of great power and wealth.
Israel was not satisfied with the extent of his dominions. H. --- Those
who read Gog, suppose that the victories of Christ over Antichrist are
foretold. Origen, hom. 17. S.

Cyp. Test. i. 10. C.

Ver. 8 - 9. Lioness. See v. 22. 24, of the preceeding chapter. H. --- This prediction was accomplished under the reigns of David and of Solomon. M.

Ver. 10. Together, to hinder him from being heard, and through indignation. Job xxxvii. 23.

Ver. 11. Honour, or reward.

Ver. 14. Counsel, out of my own head. This he was going to do, (C.) that he might not lose his reward, when again he found himself impelled by the Lord to speak what was contrary to his temporal interest. After complying reluctantly, God ceased to strive, as it were, with his rebellious will any longer, and left him to follow the bent of his corrupt heart. Upon which he proceeded to give that infernal counsel, which involved both many of the Israelites and himself in utter destruction. H. C. xxxi. 16. Apoc. ii. 4. --- Days. Heb. "Come, I will admonish thee what this people shall do to thy people," &c. Onkelos and Origen (hom. 18. and 20.) give both senses.

C. --- Indeed, the transactions of both people were so blended, when they were fighting together, that to give the history of one would be explaining the fortune of the other. H.

Ver. 16. Who knoweth. This is a new title, which he had not before assumed, v.

4.

Ver. 17. Him. The great personage whom I have in view, whose coming is deferred yet for many ages. H. --- The whole prediction refers to the Messias, whom Balaam beheld by the eyes of his posterity, the wise men, (C.) or in the prophetic vision. M. --- Some modern Rabbins pretend that he speaks of David, who was indeed a figure of Christ, (C.) and defeated the Moabites, 2 K. v. 8.

But the prophecy was perfectly fulfilled only in our Saviour's person, who is called the bright and morning star, (Apoc. xxii. 16,) to whom all nations were given for an inheritance. Ps. ii. Acts i.

8. W. --- Heb. also, "I see this thy ruin, but," &c. Sept. "I will shew to him, yet not now; I will make him happy, (C.); but (makarizo, I bless) it, or he does not approach." God executed what he ever promised in favour of all Israel, when he sent them his beloved Son. --- A star. Christ, the light of the world, the splendour of his Father's glory, whose birth was made known in the East, by a star, or meteor of unusual brightness. H. --- This material star is not the primary object of the prediction, since it did not rise out of Jacob, but it pointed out the orient from on high, and then disappeared. The ancient Jews understood this passage of the Messias. Onkelos, &c. Hence the impostor, Ben. Cusiba, took advantage of this general opinion, to draw the people after him, as the person designated; when he assumed the title of Bar-chocheba,

"the son of the star," in the second age of the church. --- Of Seth. Though David, as the figure of the Messias, conquered the Moabites, he cannot be said to have subdued all nations, the descendants of Seth, by Noe, nor all the just of whom Seth was the father, in opposition to the children of Cain. But Christ will subject all the just to his empire, and will judge all mankind. Some, nevertheless, take the children of Seth to be the Moabites, who had been already mentioned; and Junius translates the Heb. with allusion to the shameful origin of that people.

The Samar. may also signify, if we substitute d for r in korkor, as Jeremias also reads (C. xlviii. 45,) kodod. "He shall penetrate the ends of Moab, and shall overturn the walls of the children of elevation, or of pride." There were many hills in the country of the Moabites, and the people were noted for haughtiness. Jer. xlviii.

28. 29. 45. C. --- Some also assert, that Seth was the name of a king, (Grot.) and of a town of Moab. R. Nathan. --- But of this there is no proof. H.

Ver. 18. Idumea and Seir. The children of Esau shall acknowledge the dominion of Israel, from David to Josaphat, and again under Hircan. 3 K. xi. 15. 4 K. iii.

20. Josep. xiii. 17. C. --- Not only the faithful Israelites, but also the profane and headstrong sons of Esau, shall bend the knee before Christ, who will subdue them by the power of his grace, and by the preaching of his disciples. H.

Ver. 19. City of this world. Jesus will destroy their evil habits, (Orig. hom. 18,) and will select some whose lives had been hitherto scandalous, to be his intimate friends. H. --- He will save those who abandoned paganism, which had fixed its seat at the great city of Rome, (C.) and he will raise up Constantine (M.

T.) to rule over Jacob, his people. At his second coming, he will exterminate all who shall have refused to acknowledge his sovereignty, and who have remained out of the city of the Church. H. --- Those who have fled out of the cities for safety, shall be sought out by David, and destroyed. He slew all the male children of Edom, 3 K. xv. 15. C. ---

In this prophecy, some particulars relate to him, as that he shall subject Moab and Idumea by the valour of his troops, while other things can belong only to Christ, the star, who shall destroy the remains of the city. M. --- By changing one letter, Calmet would translate, "Princes shall spring from Jacob: but Seir shall perish from his cities." A long train of princes in Jacob prefigured the Messias, while the Idumeans have been unknown for many ages. C.

Ver. 20. Nations, which rose up to attack the Hebrews. Onkelos. --- Saul will punish them, 1 K.

xv. The Amalecites were a very ancient people, known in the days of Abraham.

Gen. xiv. 7. But now they are no more. H.

Ver. 21. Cinite. From the top of the hill, he cast his eyes across the Dead Sea, and beholding the strong holds of the Cinite, whose country had been promised to the Hebrews, he is inspired to foretel what would happen to this people. He alludes to their name, which signifies a nest; (C.) and to the manner in which those nations of Arabia lived, in caverns cut out of a rock. Bellon, ii.

61.

Ver. 22. Captive. The Sam. insinuates that they should return, 1 Par. ii. 55.

"Though thy nest should be entirely consumed, thy inhabitants shall return out of Assyria." C. --- Sept. "If to Beor (the capital) there should be nests of iniquity, the Assyrians will reduce thee to captivity." Heb.

"Yet the Cinite should be wasted, till," &c. H. --- The family of Jethro was now among the Hebrews, and their posterity were suffered to dwell with the tribe of Juda. Abor afterwards removed into the tribe of Nephthali, and was led away by Salmanasar, 4 K. xvii. M. --- Some of the Cinites were mixed with the Amalecites, 1 K. xv. 6. The Assyrians infested the neighbouring nations, as well as the Hebrews, under Sennacherib and Nabuchodonosor, as the prophets inform us. C.

Ver. 23. Things, of which he is about to speak. The time is remote, but very dreadful, when the Assyrians shall be chastised, in their turn, as well as the Greeks and Romans, who shall have destroyed Assur, and even the most favourite nation of God. Balaam began by announcing the prosperity of the Hebrews, but he at last gives some comfort to Balac, by letting him know that they shall also be laid waste, as well as his kingdom, and the powerful nations around him. This is the condition of all human things! H.

Ver. 24. Italy. Heb. "Chittim," which Bochart endeavours to prove with great erudition to mean Italy; while Grotius contends it means Macedon, and Calmet doubts not but this is the import of the present text. The Macedonians under Alexander and his successors, conquered the countries of Assyria, Palestine,

&c. Antiochus Epiphanes raised a cruel persecution against the Jews. But may suppose that the Hebrews here mentioned, are the nations beyond the Euphrates. C. --- Heb.

"ships...shall afflict Heber and he also shall perish for ever," which seems to refer to Heber alone, and not to those who shall oppress them, as the Vulg.

Sept. &c. express it. H. --- Indeed, we do not find that the Scripture mentions the end of the Roman empire, of which many explain this passage. C. ---

Grotius (Jur. ii. 9) maintained that it still subsisted in the German empire.

Others think it will be destroyed only in the days of Antichrist. T. Dan. ii. 40. ---

But many have asserted that it was overturned by the Goths, and that the Romans are the people who would reduce the Hebrews to the greatest misery, under Titus. M. --- The kings of Macedon are, however, styled kings of Cethim, (1 Mac. i. 1. viii. 5,) and they were the immediate subverters of the Persian empire, as theirs fell a prey to the Romans. Theod. q. 44. C.

Ver. 25. Place, in Aram. He returned soon after to the country of the Madianites, and was deservedly involved in their ruin. H. C. xxxi. 8. --- Perhaps he only began his journey homeward, and stopped on the road. C. --- As for Balac, he fought against Israel, (Jos. xxiv. 9,) at least by endeavouring to get them cursed. Severus says, "he was overcome." But we know not the particulars of the battle. H.

NUMBERS 25

CHAPTER XXV.

Ver. 1. Settim, which had Abel, "mourning," prefixed to it, (C. xxxiii. 49,) on account of the slaughter of 24,000 of the Israelites, v. 6. 9. It was situated in the plains of Moab, near the Jordan, and was the last station of the Hebrews. C. ---

In this neighbourhood all the following transactions occurred, which are recorded, till the end of the Pentateuch. M. --- Balaam, being convinced that the Hebrews would be invincible, as long as they continued faithful to God, advised the nations, who had sent to consult him, to let their daughters converse freely with the Israelites, but not to yield to their impure desires, unless they consented to offer sacrifice to their idols. C. --- Thus they first captivated their hearts, and then subverted their understanding: For some rejecting a good conscience, have made shipwreck concerning the faith. 1

Tim. i. 19. H. ---

By the same method many have been drawn into heresy. W. --- The counsels of an able but wicked man, are often followed by the most dreadful effects. That these women were sent by the Moabites, and also by the Madianites, (v. 6. 17,) instigated by the perverse counsels of Balaam, (C.) appears not only from the event being recorded in this place, but also by the express declaration of Moses, C. xxxi. 7. 8, and of the Apocalypse, C. ii. 14. Salien, Mic. vi. 5. H.

Ver. 3. Initiated to Beelphegor. That is, they took to the worship of Beelphegor, an obscene idol of the Moabites, and were consecrated as it were to him. Ch.

--- Heb. "Israel was attached, or married to Beelphegor," the sun, Adonis or Osiris, whom the psalmist (cv. 28,) styles, the dead, because the people were accustomed to bewail the death of Adonis every year, with great solemnity. C.

--- S. Jerom supposes this god "of opening, or nakedness," Beelphegor, to be the obscene Priapus. M. --- The people fell by degrees into the depth of abomination. They first defiled their bodies with women, then their souls were contaminated by the sacrifices of their idols, till they began really to adore them, and even to consecrate themselves to their service, meaning to ratify their base apostacy from the true God. H. --- Yet it is probable all those who were cut off by pestilence, were not thus initiated: but only those who were the princes or ringleaders, and who are sentenced to be gibbeted. Salien. --- The mother of Asa, king of Juda, was not ashamed to preside over the mysteries of this obscene idol, (3 K. xv. 13,) which people worshipped by prostitution.

Villalpand. S. Jer. in Osee iv. 9. T.

Ver. 4. People. Assemble the judges, and by their sentence, hang them who have been most guilty. Onkelos. --- If any of the judges, or princes themselves, have gone astray, let them not be spared. H. --- The Jews assert, that the malefactor was always killed before his body was hung on a gibbet; and that crucifixion was not known among them. But the contrary is asserted by many.

It is not clear whether these criminals were hung by the neck, or crucified, after they had been first stoned, as guilty of idolatry, or whether they were fastened to the gibbet alive, for greater torment and disgrace. C. --- Sun; publicly. See 2 K. xii. 11. M.

Ver. 5. Judges, who had not been guilty. Sept. "to the tribes." The judges, and even private individuals, were thus authorized to exterminate the guilty, as the Levites had been before, Ex.

xxxii. 27. While punishment was inflicted but slowly, and some perhaps of the more noble were spared, so that Zambri, even became more insolent. God began to supply the defect of his ministers, by sending the plague among the people, as Onkelos insinuates. H.

Ver. 6. One, Zambri, v. 14. M. --- Went in. Heb. "brought unto his brethren, or came...with a woman of Madian." Sept. "introduced one of his brethren to a Madianite woman." But the Sam.

copy agrees with the Vulg.; and the ancient edition of the Sept. must have done so too, since the Fathers explain it in the same sense. Philo de vita Mos.

Origen, &c. Josephus (iv. 6,) pretends that Zambri had married the most noble Cozbi, and that Moses finding fault with such infractions of this laws, this prince of the house of Simeon, arraigned him publicly of cruel tyranny and imposture in thus imposing his own laws upon a free people, and that for his part, he would retain his wife and ingratiate himself with many gods, that he might discover the truth. Phinees heard this with just indignation, and following him to his tent, transfixed him with Cozbi, his wife, while those young men who were desirous of imitating his zeal, treated similar offenders in like manner. "God destroyed the rest by the plague, so that not less than 14,000 perished," as Epiphanius translates, omitting dis, or ten thousand, though many copies have only 23,000, which agrees with the number specified by S. Paul, if indeed he allude to this transaction. 1 Cor. x. 7.

Philo observes, that Phinees slew the Israelite who had sacrificed to the idols, and was in the company of the harlot; and , "that 24,000 perished in one day."

H. --- Perhaps 1000 of the heads might be gibbeted, and 23,000 of the common people slain. D.

Ver. 7. Dagger. Josephus translates romach, by romphaia, "a sword." Sept. by seiromasten, a long and sharp iron rod, like a spit, such as people used to try if any smuggled goods be concealed. H. --- It denotes any sort of offensive weapon. C. --- The Vulg. sometimes translates, a lance or spear. M.

Ver. 8. Parts. Ovid says, Lethifer ille locus, "That place where wounds so often deadly prove."

Heb. kubbak, means brothel-house just before, a bead, vault, cistern, belly, &c.

Sept. translate,

"through her womb." The plague, inflicted by God, instantly ceased, to shew the divine approbation of this exemplary punishment, and all were so much filled with terror and repentance, that it was no longer necessary for the judges to sentence any more to death. An effectual stop was also put to the spreading disorder of both carnal and spiritual fornication. H.

Ver. 9. Slain. Heb. adds, "in the plague," or pestilence sent by God, (Ps. cv. 29,) and in the punishments inflicted by the judges, "twenty and four thousand." H.

--- The tribe of Simeon, lying to the south, had given way to greater disorders with the Madianites; (C.) so that they were found to have 37,100 fewer than when they were numbered before. C. ii. 13. See C. xxvi. 14. H.

Ver. 12. Peace. He has the honour of restoring the people to peace and to my favour, so that my covenant shall still subsist with them. He shall surely be his father's successor in the high priesthood, and shall not be prevented by death.

Ver. 13. Seed. A short interruption of 150 years (from Heli to Abiathar, of the race of Ithamar) may be accounted trifling in a duration of so many ages, during which the posterity of Phinees enjoyed this dignity. Phinees succeeded Eleazar and had for his successors, Abiezer Bocci, and Elsi. C. --- Some add Zararias, Meraioth, and Amarias, upon whose death, 1157 years before Christ, Heli got possession, by some means, and was followed by Achitob, Achielech, and Abiathar, of the same family, till David joined Sadoc with the latter, and he was acknowledged sole pontiff on the rebellion of Abiathar. B.C. 1014. See Lenglet's tables. H. --- We have no proof that the succeeding high priests were of a different family, (C.) till our Saviour's time, who re-united in his person the right both to his priesthood and to the kingdom of Israel for ever. See S. Aug.

C. D. xvii. 6. H. --- God did not promise that no interruption should take place.

He only granted a perpetual right to the family of Phinees, (Cajetan) which they might forfeit by their misconduct. T. --- He was certainly always disposed to comply with his promise, and really granted the effects of it to the posterity of Phinees, at least for almost 1000 years, even if we grant that the Machabees were not his lineal descendants, of which there is no positive proof either way.

Thus, for ever, often denotes a long duration. Though Phinees was entitled already to the high priesthood, in quality of the eldest son of Eleazar, he had before no assurance of surviving him, nor of having a succession of children who might be capable of the high office, and free from every blemish; (C.) so that the promise made to him was not only a ratification of his title, but a new and real benefit. H. --- Zealous. The Jews allow any person to kill one who publicly, or in the presence of ten people, commits idolatry, sacrilege, fornication with a strange woman, and also a priest who, being unclean, approaches to the altar. This they call the judgment of zeal.

Seld. Jur. iv. 4. Grotius ii. 20. This practice they authorize by the example of Phinees, Mathathias, &c. 1 Mac. ii. 24. Such liberty was carried to a great excess, by the Zealots, in the last siege of Jerusalem; and it would be very criminal, where such a law is not in force. C. ---

Phinees was, however, either one of the judges, and thus gave an example of just severity to his fellow magistrates, or he was inspired by God to resent the public injury done to his name. It is never lawful to kill by private authority.

Catec. Rom. p. 3. C. vi. 5. S. Thomas ii. 2. q. lx. 6. W.

--- Those who act under the influence of inspiration must be very careful not to give in to any delusion; and the examples of holy persons who are mentioned, with applause, in Scripture, for having been the instruments of God's vengeance, will not authorize us to do the like, unless we can produce the like testimony. H. --- Atonement, by averting the scourge of God, (v. 8. 11,) and by putting a stop to the corruption of the people, which might otherwise have greatly increased, if Zambri had escaped with impunity. C.

Ver. 14. Kindred. Heb. "of a chief house among the Simeonites," as Sur was of equal nobility,

"head over a people, and of a chief house in Madian," v. 15. H. --- He is styled king, and one of the five princes of the nation. C. xxxi. 8.

Ver. 17. Madianites. God spared the Moabites for the sake of Lot (Deut. ii. 19,) and of Ruth, of whom David and Christ should be born. They were perhaps less guilty, but they did not escape due chastisement under David, 2 K. viii. 2.

M. --- The war against Madian was the last which the Hebrews waged in the lifetime of Moses. C. xxxi. H.

NUMBERS 26

CHAPTER XXVI.

Ver. 1. Shed. Heb. and Sept. "after the plague," which destroyed so many. Chal.

After all who had murmured were cut off, the new progeny is numbered. S.

Jerom. W.

Ver. 2. Number. This was done that the general might know what forces he could muster to attack the nations of Chanaan on the west side of the Jordan, and also in order that the lands might be properly distributed. The war lasted seven years, and the distribution of lands was not completed till some time afterwards. It is not clear that those who were not enrolled at this time, as being 20 years of age, would have any portion, except that of their fathers, allotted to them; but it seems, however, rational that those who were arrived at that age when the distribution was made, would have their share like the rest.

There were 1820 people fewer than in the register which was taken before, (C.

i.,) thirteen months after the departure from Egypt. The Levites seem not to have been numbered with the utmost exactitude, as only five families are mentioned, (v. 58, Jans.) though there were many more, 1 Par. xxiii. 6, &c. Their numbers amount to only 23,000. C. --- They had rather increased in the desert during 38 years; (see C. iii. 39,) as had also the tribes of Juda, Issachar, and Zabulon, which lay to the east; of Manasses (who perhaps on that account precedes Ephraim) and Benjamin to the west; Dan and Aser to the north.

Nephtali proved deficient; so did likewise the tribes of Ruben, Simeon, and Gad, who were stationed to the south of the tabernacle. When they were numbered the first and the second time, (Ex. xxxviii. 25, and Num. i. 46,) they amounted to 603,550, exclusively of the Levites. Now they could only count 601,730 men fit for war. Considering their frequent disasters, it is even a matter of surprise that their ranks were not thinned still more, particularly as we are assured that all who had been numbered before, except Josue and Caleb, the Levites, and such as had kept themselves free from murmuring, had perished, v. 64. H. --- In the particular accounts of the tribes, and in the names of persons,

the Sept. frequently differ from the Hebrew. But the total amount agrees.

Ver. 4. Them. Heb. "commanded Moses and the children of Israel, who came forth out of the land of Egypt." The same plan was now to be pursued as formerly.

Ver. 7. Thirty. They had lost therefore 2870 men. C. i. 21.

Ver. 9. Princes. Heb. "men of name in the congregation," senators. Vatab. C.

xvi. 2.

Ver. 10. Miracle. Heb. "they became a sign," of reproach, and a memorial of God's just judgments, who caused the earth to swallow up Core and his companions alive, by a most disgraceful kind of death, to which the faithless vestal virgins were condemned at Rome, being buried alive; while those who had offered incense were consumed by fire. Many of the ancients assert that Core was also burnt, meaning perhaps by the fire of hell; to which he descended.

Josep. iv. 3. --- Others have thought that the children of Core were swallowed up with their father. But this is not true, with respect to some of them at least, (H.) who by a miracle of divine grace and goodness, were preserved from joining in his sedition; (C.) while Core, his wife and servants, all concurred to shew them such a pernicious example. H. --- Lyran. and the Rabbins tell us, that the children stopped to intreat their father to repent; and while the earth opened under them, God supported them in the air, and gave them the spirit of prophecy; so that they sung, (Ps.

xl.) God is our refuge, &c., or, according to others, the Ps. xli. which has their name in the title.

But these accounts are to be received with caution. The Samaritan text, fuerunt in fugam, (C.) may be translated, "out of this world they fled away, (11) and the sons of Core did not perish."

Ver. 12. Namuel. N has been substituted for i, in the name of Iamuel, as it is read elsewhere, and in the Syriac, both here and 1 Par. iv. 24, where Ahod is by mistake written with r, instead of d.

See also the Arab. Ken. H.

Ver. 14. Families. Ahod is not mentioned, as he, probably, died without children. See Gen. xlvi.

10. M. --- Hundred. Their numbers were the most reduced. See C. xxv. 9. H.

Ver. 18. Hundred. Sept. add, "4000." This tribe had formerly 45,650. It had lost 5100.

Ver. 22. Hundred. Juda had increased 1900.

Ver. 25. Issachar had also 9900 more.

Ver. 27. Zabulon was more numerous by 3100; so that this division had an additional strength of 13,100, while the former was diminished by 45,070 men.

H.

Ver. 29. Machir: 1 Par. vii. 20, we find Ezriel also mentioned. See C. xxxi. 39.

Ver. 30. Jezer, who is called Abihezer. Jos. xvii. 2. and Paral.

Ver. 34. Hundred. Manasses had increased his numbers by 20,500, while Ver.

37. Ephraim had lost 8000. H.

Ver. 38. Bela was the father of two families, v. 40. The other five children of Benjamin probably left no issue. Gen. xlv. 21. D.

Ver. 41. Benjamin had 10,200 added to his former number. Hence this division of the army, though hurt by Ephraim, (v. 37,) had an increase of 22,700.

Ver. 43. Suhamites. Their father is called Huthim in Genesis, and also by the Sept. This branch of Dan was more numerous than formerly by 1700 soldiers.

Ver. 47. Aser had an addition of 11,900; and, both together, 13,600. But they were let down by Ver. 50. Nephtali, who had lost 8000; so that this division had only 5600 more. H.

Ver. 54. A less. God introduced among his people that equality, which was so much desired by Lycurgus, Solon, &c. The fertility of the land assigned to Benjamin, compensated for the smallness of its quantity.

Ver. 55. Lot. Josue appointed commissioners, who measured the land, and divided it according to its fertility; and the portions assigned to each of the tribes by lot, corresponded with the predications of Jacob and of Moses; God so regulating the lots by his allwise Providence, in order that the people might be more convinced of the truth of the

prophecies, and that no undue favour was shewn to any one by Josue, Eleazar, or by the other men in authority. He took the whole upon himself, that none might complain of their rulers. C. ---

Masius supposes that the different divisions of the land were written down, and placed in an urn, and that the heads of the tribes drew according to their birth. Jos. xv. 1. --- The heads of families, such as Henoch, &c., (v. 5.) probably also drew lots, to know what part of territory allotted to the tribe, should fall to their share; (H.) and they parcelled out their land among their children. M.

Ver. 58. Core. Three other families are mentioned. Ex. vi. 17, &c. They were not going out to war. D.

Ver. 59. Levi. Sept. "who bore these (Lobni, &c.) to Levi, in Egypt; and she bore to Amram, Aaron," &c. as if Jochabed had been wife both of Levi and of Amram, which is very improbable.

It is more likely that the wives of these two bore the same name. The Heb. may agree very well with the Vulg. See Ex. ii. 1. C. --- It was afterwards forbidden for a person to marry his aunt.

Lev. xviii. W.

Ver. 64. Sinai, if we except the Levites. M. See C. xiv. 23. --- Origen (hom. 21.) makes a very good remark on this subject. This circumcised, but rebellious people, conducted by Moses into the desert, clearly points out the Hebrews, who come to the frontiers of the promised land, but are not suffered to cross the Jordan. The uncircumcised are introduced into the land flowing with milk and honey, not by Moses, but by Josue, the figure of our Saviour, who opens heaven to true believers. "The first people is rejected, which had received circumcision, and the second is introduced, which is gathered from the Gentiles; and it is the people which obtains its father's inheritance...If Moses give any inheritance, it is not within the Jordan...it is a land fit for cattle...he does not distribute it by lot...nor can he know the merits of each. This is done by Jesus only, to whom his Father has given all judgment." H.

NUMBERS 27

CHAPTER XXVII.

Ver. 1. Salphaad, a descendant of Joseph, had departed this life in the desert, being one of those who sinned, by murmuring, at Cades-barne. See C. xiv. and xv. 32. C. --- He only left these five daughters behind him; and, as many others might be under the same predicament, their case deserved the attention of the legislator, who referred it to God. H.

Ver. 3. Father, the portion which would have been assigned him; that so those whom we may marry, may take the inheritance, under the name of Salphaad, which some of the children may also bear. M.

Ver. 4-6. Their. The first of these pronouns is written larger than usual, the second is improperly masculine in Heb.; both, it is pretended, to honour the young women. Kennicott.

Ver. 9. Him. The Jews observe, that if the father of the deceased were still alive, he would take the inheritance. Seld. Success. xii. and xiii. But if his wife were inclined to marry again, she might insist on his next relation taking her, before she could be required to give up his goods.

Deut. xxv. 5. Hence the Gemarra of Babylon says, "If we are the daughters of Salphaad, let them give us his estate; but if we are not his daughters, let them make the brother of Salphaad marry our mother."

Ver. 11. Uncles. His nephews are at a greater distance from the original stock.

The Phœnicians carried the same regulations into Africa. Grot. Jur. ii. 7. The relations by the mother's side, could claim no part. The husband was heir to all his wife's goods, except her dowry, which went to her children. People born of a slave, or of a harlot or strange woman, were not lawful heirs. "These regulations have been adopted by all civilized nations." Orig. hom. 22. C.

Ver. 13. People, in limbo. M. --- He was not buried in the grave of his ancestors, but on some part of Mount Abarim, called Nebo. Deut. xxxiv. 1. 6. H. --- Moses, hoping that this sentence of exclusion from the promised land might be only a threat, had earnestly besought God to let him enter. But being forbidden to speak of the matter any more, he understood that it was as irrevocable as an oath. Deut. iii. 26. iv. 21. He turned, therefore, his whole solicitude to obtain of God some one, who might enjoy the honour and happiness of conducting the people, and putting them in possession of God's promises. He regards not flesh and blood on this occasion, (Philo, de caritate. Salien,) but sets a noble pattern for all ecclesiastical superiors to imitate. D.

Ver. 16. Flesh, who gives life, and penetrates the secrets of hearts. C. xvi. 22.

Ver. 17. Shepherd. Christ makes use of the same comparison. Jo. x. 1. Kings are often styled shepherds in Homer. Moses begs that his successor may be enabled to conduct the multitude in both peace and war. --- To go in and out, means to govern, (3 K. iii. 7,) and includes all the occurrences of life. Act. i. 21.

Ps. cxx. 8. C. --- Thus, temporal princes are the shepherds of the people. But they are not, on that account, supreme in spiritual causes. For here Josue only receives part of the glory of Moses, while Eleazar is appointed to consult the Lord for him, and to direct him in all matters of importance, v. 20. 21. W.

Ver. 18. Spirit of God, which was given to him, when he was appointed a judge; (C. xi. 17,) the spirit of prophesy, (Onkelos,) and of wisdom, (Deut. xxxiv. 9,) of which he received a fresh increase, by the imposition of the hands of Moses.

By the like ceremony people are confirmed, and ministers of religion are still ordained. Act. vi. 6. 1 Tim. iv. 14. C. --- God endues Josue with all the necessary qualifications for his high office. He makes choice of him, and not of any of the relations of Moses, that the people might not be offended at the supreme power being in a manner engrossed by one family; and he appoints one 93 year old, that the success of war might

not be attributed to Josue, though he had been long at the head of the armies, and a man of greatest authority, even the vice-gerent of Moses. He declares his election before all the multitude, with the high priest at their head, that there might be no dispute about the matter; and, on this account, he requires various external ceremonies to be observed. Salien.

Ver. 20. Precepts, to accept of this office, (C.) and to discharge it with integrity.

H. --- Glory, not that which shone on the face of Moses, as Onkelos would have it, but all the marks of distinction due to a chief magistrate, (C.) the insignia of his office. See Ex. xviii. 21. Salien. --- Treat him with respect, as your successor. M. --- Let him henceforward commence to exercise his authority before you, that all the people may hear and obey him. Sararius. T.

Ver. 21. For him. Hebrew adds, "according to the judgment of Urim." See Ex.

xxviii. 30.

Nothing better shews the theocracy of the Hebrews, as Josephus styles it, (c.

Apion. ii.) than this order for the chief magistrate in civil affairs, to consult and be guided by God's minister, and by the sentence which he should pronounce in his name. Till the reign of David, at least, we find few wars undertaken, without consulting God: (C.) and the Rabbins assert, that the kings could not declare any war of their own accord, without the consent of the high priest and Sanhedrim.

Seld. Syned. iii. 12. Saul lost his crown and life for not complying with the injunctions of God, which were communicated to him by the prophet Samuel.

H.

Ver. 23. Commanded. This Moses executed on his birth-day, when he was 120

years old, (Deut.

xxxi. 2. 7,) having frequently before given proper instructions to Josue. Deut. i.

38. and xxxii. 44.

H.

NUMBERS 28

CHAPTER XXVIII.

Ver. 2. Seasons. These precepts had often been repeated already: but perhaps they had not been exactly observed in the desert, so that Moses indicates them once more, as if to remind the people that they will now have no excuse, if they neglect these sacrifices in the promised land. C. -

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These frequent repetitions may also remind us, with what attention we ought to worship God. D.

Ver. 3. Lambs. Kids would not suffice. See Ex. xxix. 38. The lambs must not be above a year old. But it is not clear whether they could be offered eight days after their birth, as on other occasions. Ex. xxiii. 19. C.

Ver. 6. Sinai. Hence it seems to have been discontinued for 38 years. C. Lev. ix.

17. M.

Ver. 7. In the. Heb. "in the holy thou shalt cause the shecar to be poured out unto the Lord, a drink-offering." See C. iv. 8, on the meaning of shecar. H. ---

Some believe, that artificial wine of palm-trees, &c., might serve for libations.

In this sacrifice, the priests furnished the liquor; so that all was to be poured out on the altar of holocausts, which stood in the court. C.

Ver. 10. Which, &c. Heb. "the burnt-offering of every sabbath, besides the perpetual holocaust and its libations," which were due for every day. H. --- On the sabbath, two more were to be offered of the same age. Jansenius observes, that three belonged to the morning service, and one to that of the evening. M. C.

Ver. 11. Month. This is not reckoned among the festivals. Lev. xxiii. The Rabbins look upon it as a day of devotion, particularly for women. Buxtorf.

Syn. xvii. Spencer (Rit. iii. 1,) maintains, that the Hebrews began their month when the moon first appeared, and that they imitated the pagans in keeping that day holy. But his proofs on both heads are very unsatisfactory. The Hebrews followed the solar year for many ages after Moses, though they might have adopted the lunar towards the close of the republic; and the pagans themselves ridiculed those as vile imitators of the Jews, who kept the new moons as a festival. Hor. Sat. i. 9. Sabbata Vin tu Curtis Judæis oppedere. ---

The Greeks, Romans, Egyptians, Arabs, and Turks, have given in to various superstitious practices in honour of the moon. See Macrob. Sat. i. 15, &c. C. ---

The devil is commonly the ape of God, and teaches his votaries to adopt the ceremonies of the true religion, either to delude them more easily, or to bring those practices into discredit. Thus Middleton has endeavoured to shew the conformity of Pagan and Papal Rome, as if the ceremonies of the Catholic religion were to be rejected because some of them have been in use among the heathens.

By the same argument he may ridicule the revelation of God himself, on this subject, and represent vestments, holy water, &c. as superstitious. He may pull down altars, condemn all forms of prayer, abolish all worship, both of soul and body. For such things have all been prostituted to idols! But those who are not totally infatuated by prejudice, will deplore the abuse of these things, and will not refrain from adoring the true God according to his will, with all the faculties both of their soul and body, on account of the devil and his false prophets having extorted similar acts of worship from their followers. It is no wonder that Protestants should ridicule our holy ceremonies, since they scruple not to assign so base an origin to those which God expressly prescribed. H. --- The sacrifices which were ordered to be offered up on the first day of the month, were probably designed to renew the memory of the world's creation, or rather of the Divine providence, which regulates the seasons. Nothing was sold on this day. Amos viii.

5. But people went to hear the prophets, (4 K. iv. 23,) and feasted among themselves, 1 K. xx. 18.

It is thought that many rested also from servile work, though this is nowhere commanded. C. ---

Tirin agrees with Tostat and Sanctius, in supposing that servile work was prohibited, for which he refers to 1 K. xx. 19. He also asserts that the Jews observed the lunar system, and that their months consisted of 29 and 30 days alternately, as 29 days and a half elapse from one moon to another. The sound of trumpets probably announced this solemnity. C. x. 10. Lev. xxiii. H.

Ver. 13. Tenth. An assaron, gomer, or chomer, which is the tenth part of an epha, as that is the tenth of a core or chomer, which is the largest Hebrew dry measure, containing 32 pecks and one pint English; so that the gomer would be equivalent to five pints. H. --- This quantity of flour accompanied each holocaust at the beginning of every month. C.

Ver. 15. Above. This is the import of the Heb. &c.: for no libations accompanied the sin-offerings, nor incense. See C. xv. 3. Lev. v. 12. M.

Ver. 16. Phase, or Passover, the most solemn of all the festivals, when the lamb was to be eaten on the 15th of Nisan, and during the eight days no leavened bread was allowed. The Jews searched all the corners of their houses, lest some might be concealed by mice, and they would not so much as name it. S.

Paul exhorts us to do the like, in a spiritual sense, by purifying ourselves from every defilement of sin when we receive the blessed sacrament, and by not even mentioning sins of impurity. 1 Cor. v. 7. Ephes. v. 3. H.

Ver. 23. Offer, as well as that in the evening, which was in less danger of being forgotten.

Ver. 24. Fire. Heb. "food of the sacrifice made by fire." --- Rise. Heb. "it shall be offered besides the perpetual holocaust, and its libations," morning and evening. All the aforesaid sacrifices and libations were to be repeated on each of the seven days, v. 19. 22.

Ver. 26. The day of Pentecost, seven weeks after the Passover, was the next in solemnity, to thank God for the wheat harvest, of which the first-fruits were now presented. H. --- Two loaves, made with leaven, were given to the priests.

Lamy. See Lev. xxiii. 17.

Ver. 27. Two calves. Only one is specified in Leviticus, being that designed for the morning; another was immolated at night. C. --- The same victims are prescribed as v. 19. M.

NUMBERS 29

CHAPTER XXIX.

Ver. 1. The first. This day was doubly solemn, as being the first day of the month, consequently entitled to all the sacrifices enjoined for it; and also a holiday, for which other victims are requisite, besides the perpetual holocausts, v. 2. 6. C. xxviii. 11. H.

Ver. 7. Tenth. The feast of expiation, on which see Lev. xvi. 29. xxiii. 27, where we have also explained what relates to the feast of tabernacles, v. 34.

Ver. 12. Seven days, not refraining indeed all that time from servile work, but remaining under tents, and daily performing what is required, v. 13. &c.

Ver. 35. Eighth day, which was more solemn than the preceding ones, but less so than the first.

The victims are every day diminished. C. --- This day, in the Hebrew calendar, is called the feast of retention, (atsroth) as they staid near the tabernacle. D.

Ver. 39. Vows. The general regulations did not hinder any private ones from being fulfilled. C.

--- Sacrifice. Mincha, or offering of flour, &c. H.

NUMBERS 30

CHAPTER XXX.

Ver. 3. Oath, to do something commendable, shall observe his promise, whether any body has heard him or not. The Rabbins pretend, that if the vow be not expressed in words, it is not obligatory. But this is only true before men, who cannot subject their fellow creatures to punishment for internal faults. H. --- The obligation of a vow or oath is founded upon common honesty, which requires that we should comply with our lawful promises; and, though all properly belong to God, yet, as he does not strictly require us to do every good work which may be in our power, we may, by vow, testify our desire to please and honour him the more. Some of the Rabbins have very loose sentiments with respect to vows, which they look upon as no better than building an altar, or immolating a victim upon the high places. It is sufficient, they say, to observe the law, apud Fagium. C. --- Luther was desirous of introducing the same loose morality among Christians. But we need not ask, what the Rabbins said, or Luther, &c. But what does God and his Church assert? The Scripture repeatedly commends prudent vows; and those who can persuade themselves that they can infringe such solemn promises without offence, will be little solicitous about keeping their word to a fellow creature, unless when interest, or fear of shame, force them to do it. H. --- He who makes a vow to abstain from any thing lawful, would be guilty of sin if he should observe it afterwards. S. Aug. q. 56. W.

Ver. 4. Girl in age, not 12; or, if more, at least not married, nor out of her father's house, v. 17.

For either of these conditions rendered a girl incapable of binding herself irrevocably. The father, or all who had the care of her, might rescind her vow, provided they did it as soon as it came to their knowledge, or on the same day, v. 15. Boys under 13, were under similar restrictions.

Grotius. --- Wives, and, in general, all who are under subjection, could not dispose of themselves without the consent of their superiors, as their want of prudence, &c. might have otherwise injured what belonged, in some measure, to another. H. --- The law, therefore, submits their case to the decision of their immediate judges. C. --- But if the thing, which a person vowed, was already of strict obligation, as to fast on the day of expiation, (Lev. xxiii. 29,) no one could presume to hinder his wife from complying with this double duty. W.

Ver. 7. Husband, whether she live with him, or with her father; whether she be only espoused, or the marriage be consummated. Women often staid for some time at their father's house after they were married; and, in this case, some people say that either her father or her husband might disannul her vow. But others allow this right only to her husband. Bonfrere. See v. 11. C.

Ver. 14. It. The Rabbins restrain this law to fasting and abstinence. But the Hebrew seems more general, (v. 13,) "every vow, and every binding oath to afflict the soul, her husband may ratify or annul." The vows of abstinence are most common, and generally more disagreeable to husbands.

C. --- S. Augustine (q. 59,) thinks it unreasonable that the husband should have a control over the vows of continency in his wife, any more than she could have over him, in this particular, as their rights are equal: he seems inclined to allow him to annul the vows of abstinence only. Indeed this seems to be the meaning of afflicting the soul, which is done by submitting to various restraints, required on days of fasting. See Lev. xxiii. 27. H. --- In things which could nowise hurt the parent or husband, many believe, that the person who had made a vow, was bound to perform it secretly, even though the superior had declared his dissent. But with respect to fasting, pilgrimages, &c. which could not be performed without his knowledge, it does not seem that they were under any farther obligation, even though the superior should retract what he had connived at for a whole day. In doubtful cases inferiors must not refuse to obey. The sin lies at the door of him who exercises his authority in an improper manner. Lyran. T. v. 16.

Ver. 15. Day. Heb. "from day to day." If he has not given his decision on the first day when the vow came to his knowledge, unless he asked for a delay, as some allow, the person was bound to perform what she had promised. C. ---

Immediately. Heb. "in the day," which seems to restrict the power of annulling the vow to a single day, v. 4. It would be unreasonable for the person to be kept long in suspense; and the law of God requires that we should not defer to perform our vows. Eccles. v. 3. 4. H.

Ver. 16. That. Sept. "the day." If he retract his consent, he shall incur all the guilt. S. Aug. q. 59.

The woman need not be under any disquietude, as the fault is not in her. C. ---

If a person had made a rash vow, he might obtain a dispensation from the tribunal of three judges, or from a doctor of the law, who would enjoin him to offer the sacrifice for ignorance, to punish his levity.

See Seld. Jur. vii. 2. Those who break their vow are to be scourged among the Jews, which shews that they do not, in general, approve the sentiments of those Rabbins whom Fagius, a Protestant, alleges, v. 3. They make a distinction between vows and promises confirmed by an oath, v. 11.

The former change the nature of a thing, according to them; so that, if a person should vow not to wear the phylacteries ordained by Moses, he must comply, though not if he had only promised on oath to refrain. But this distinction is absurd. No vow or oath can bind any person to transgress the law of God. H.

NUMBERS 31

CHAPTER XXXI.

Ver. 2. Madianites. The five princes, (v. 8) had joined Sehon, in his attack upon the Hebrews.

Jos. xiii. 21. They had united with the Moabites against them, and had been most active in perverting the people of God. They had even the wicked Balaam still among them, who was bent upon destruction; so that God saw the measure of their crimes was full, their provocations unsufferable, and he was pleased to let Moses be witness of their just punishment. This he would effect with a very small force, v. 5. H. --- This war of religion was terminated about a month before the death of Moses.

Ver. 6. Trumpets. These are the holy vessels just specified, though some believe that he carried the ark, which was done in some wars. Jos. vi. 1. 1 K. iv.

5. Priests always sounded the trumpet.

Deut. xx. 2. Phinees was appointed general of this expedition to reward him for his zeal against the fornicators. C. --- Or Josue headed the army, as he did on other occasions, though his name be not here specified. The tribe of Levi was not obliged to go to battle, and therefore only twelve tribes send each 1000.

Josue had been elected general by God, so that it was not necessary to mention his name. Salien.

Ver. 8. Recem; by which name Petra, the capital of Arabia Petrea, is known.

This petty king probably took his title from this city, over which he presided. C.

--- All the five had been, perhaps, tributary to Sehon. Jos. xiii. 21. H. ---
Sur, the wretched parent of Cozbi. C. xxv. 15. C.

--- Balaam. Some think he was a native of Madian, though he had resided in Mesopotamia. He had either stopped in this country, or hearing of the calamities of the Hebrews, had returned to receive the reward of his pernicious counsel. Thus he was overtaken by God's just judgment, and he fell into the pit which his avarice had dug for him. C. xxiv. 25. H. --- Probably he was busy with his incantations; for this sort of men is generally cowardly. He had no sword.

C. xxii. 29.

Salien.

Ver. 9. Possessions. Lit. "all that they could, they plundered." It seems they did not advance very far into the country; or many saved themselves by flight; for we find the Madianites soon powerful enough to enslave the Hebrews. Judg.

vi. 1.

Ver. 10. Castles. Heb. tiroth, means also, "palaces, or shepherds' huts." C.

Ver. 13. Camp. They had sent news of their victory, and of the plunder which they were bringing to the camp, (H.) to be divided equally among their fellow soldiers, when they were met by Moses, &c. who came to congratulate with them, and to examine how they executed their commission, as well as to admonish them to be purified before they entered the camp, v. 19. C.

Ver. 15. Women. They had received no positive orders respecting them, and it was customary to spare their lives. But these dissolute women had rendered themselves unworthy of such indulgence, (C.) and the sight of them raised the just indignation of Moses, who was afraid lest their manners should corrupt the victors. H.

Ver. 16. The sin of Phogor. The sin committed in the worship of Beelphegor.

Ch. --- Many of the prostitutes had returned home, being terrified at the slaughter of their queen, Cozbi. H.

Ver. 17. Of children. Women and children, ordinarily speaking, were not to be killed in war.

Deut. xx. 14. But the great lord of life and death was pleased to order it otherwise in the present case, in detestation of the wickedness of this people, who by the counsel of Balaam, had sent their women amongst the Israelites on purpose to draw them from God. Ch. --- Only those who were under twelve would be thus reserved; and as their tender minds might yet receive the impressions of virtue, by a proper education, they might, one day, be married by some of the Hebrews. The boys were all slain, either because they might be inclined to resent the injury done to their relations, or because they were all consecrated

to Beelphegor; the first-born to be his priests, the rest to be victims, if necessary, to avert any evil. For "the heathens in cold blood," says Paine,

"offered their children in sacrifice to Baalpeor." It was on this account, that the killing of all the first-born in Egypt, was felt so terribly, as the people could not lawfully approach their gods.

Forbes. --- Moses did not reserve the girls for the purpose of debauchery, as Paine ignorantly pretends; for that was contrary to his own laws, nor did he wantonly kill the innocent, which he also strictly forbade, and which he would have been still more afraid to do, if he had been an impostor. But he preserved the lives of those girls who might be presumed innocent, and who might live to do good, while he took the revenge of the Lord (v. 3,) upon the rest. H.

Ver. 19. Shall be. Heb. "purify yourselves and your captives on the," &c. The girls, and all the booty, might probably be rendered unclean by the presence of a corpse, &c. C. xix. 14.

Ver. 23. Expiation, with which even the vessels which had been through the fire, were to be purified, or washed, as the Heb. Sept. &c. observe. C. --- Moses perhaps gave this ordinance by word of mouth, on this occasion, (M.) though something similar be prescribed before. Lev. vi.

28. xi. 33. xv. 12.

Ver. 27. Equally. Those who had been in battle, had about a 50th part more than the rest. They gave the first-fruits to the priests, while those in the camp presented theirs to the Levites. Other rules were afterwards observed. See 1 K.

xxx. 24. 2 Mac. viii. 28. The Rabbins assign the greatest share to the king, (Seld. Jur. vi. 16,) and Homer gives the largest portion to the general; after which the rest was equally divided, and even the absent partook. The gods were not forgotten. So also among the Hebrews, Syrians, &c. the general make an equal division. David assigns a part of the booty for sacred uses, 1 Par.

xxvi. 26. See Ex. xv. 9. C.

Ver. 32. Spoil. Heb. "the remains of the spoil," which had not been consumed by the 12,000. C.

Ver. 41. Fruits. Heb. "a heave-offering to," &c. v. 29.

Ver. 49. Wanting. Sept. "all were unanimous," (Origen,) and "all answered to their names."

Thus God was pleased to shew, that his Providence had directed the battle. H.

Ver. 50. Garters. Sept. "bracelets," put on the arm, 2 K. i. 10. Sometimes the Eastern nations wore large precious rings on their legs. - -- Tablets. Heb.

tsamid, an ornament of the hand. Gen.

xxiv. 22. The armillæ, or viriliæ, were worn by men near the shoulder. - --

Bracelets, (dextralia) for the right hand. Eccli. xxi. 14. Heb. hagil, means an ear-ring, Ezech. xvi. 12. --- Chains of gold and silver interlaced, worn round the neck. S. Jerom, ep. ad Marcel. The Madianites went to battle in their richest attire, (Judg. vi. 21,) as did also the Persians; (Bellon. 2,) and the Turks do so still, (C.) being descended from Ismael, the half brother of Madian, who both settled in Arabia.

H.

Ver. 50. His own. Gold, and such ornaments as might easily be concealed by the soldiers, where not required to be brought to the common stock to be equally divided. C. --- There were 840,000

head of living creatures, including the 32,000 virgins, which were distributed.

The gold, which was voluntarily presented to the Lord, amounted to above five talents. Salien. B.C. 1470. --- The princes made a voluntary offering of their gold, but the common soldiers retained what each man had gotten. D.

NUMBERS 32

CHAPTER XXXII.

Ver. 3. Saban, and Nebo. These towns were afterwards retaken by the Moabites. Isai. xv. 2. 8.

--- Beon. Perhaps the same with Mehon, or Beth Baal Mehon. Jos. xiii. 17. C.

Ver. 5. Jordan. They are a figure of those who would possess heaven without labour. But none is crowned, except he strive lawfully. 2 Tim. ii. 5. W.

Ver. 7. Overturn. Heb. nua, "to discourage," (H.) break, dissolve, &c. v. 9. M. ---

The same history is mentioned, (Deut. iii. 12. 18,) but without these reproaches. C.

Ver. 11. If, &c. They shall not see Chanaan. M. --- In Scripture, odious things are not fully expressed, particularly in oaths. Ps. lxxxviii. 36. and cxxxi. 2. C. ---

Heb. "surely none...shall see...because they have not perfectly followed me."

Grot. H.

Ver. 12. Cenezite. His father was either called Cenez, or a part of the country of the Cenezites, being promised to Caleb at Cades-barne, he assumed his title.

Jos. xiv. 6.

Ver. 13. Led, &c. Sept. "he rolled them over," to denote their afflictions. H.

Ver. 15. Of all. Heb. "if, or because you will not follow after him. He will stop them in the desert, and you will destroy all the people." Sept. "because you will turn away from him, to abandon him again in the desert, and you will sin against all this congregation." God had decreed that all should go together to the conquest of the promised land; so that, if these children of Ruben and of Gad should refuse to comply, Moses was afraid that all might be ruined.

Perceiving that his discourse turned on this subject, they approached with greater confidence, and shewed their readiness to fight for their brethren.

Upon which Moses was satisfied. H.

Ver. 17. Cities, which in the space of two months they would repair sufficiently, so that their children might be protected against the Amorrites, &c. They left strong garrisons, very prudently, to keep possession of the conquered country: 70,580 remained in the cities; while 40,000 went before their brethren.

See C. xxvi. 7. 18. and Jos. iv. 13.

Ver. 19. Jordan. Heb. adds, "or forward," any where, in case fresh conquests be made. C.

Ver. 20. Lord, or the ark, under the guidance and protection of God.

Ver. 21. Man, that may be required: Josue only took 40,000 for the vanguard. H.

Ver. 25. Ruben. No mention is made of those of the half tribe of Manasses.

Perhaps they only joined the rest afterwards. C. v. 33. They occupied the northern parts. H. --- The Heb. has here a solecism, "the sons of Gad he said;"

to avoid which, Onkelos adds, the tribe, &c. Houbig.

Ver. 26. Galaad. Only a small part of the territory properly went by that name, v.

39. C.

Ver. 30. With you. Sept. "armed for war before the Lord; take by force their baggage, wives and cattle, before you, into Chanaan, and let them have shares with you in Chanaan." H.

Ver. 34. Built, or repaired; for they had been cities of the Amorrhites before. ---

Aroer was occupied by the Moabites after the Israelites were led into captivity.

Jerem. xlviii. 1. 19.

Ver. 35. Sophan. Some believe that this is the same city with Etroth, and that it took its name from Saphon, the son of Gad. C. xxvi. 15. --- Jegbaa perhaps the Beon, v. 3. See Judg. viii. 11.

Ver. 36. Betharan, which Herod enlarged, and called Livias, south of Hesebon.

C.

Ver. 38. Nabo. Probably the same as Nebo and Nobe. --- Baalmeon. This city had a variety of names, v. 3. 35. Those who rebuilt these cities gave them their own names, v. 42. Heb. Targum of Jerus. Yet they were often known by their former appellations. C. --- The rebuilders chiefly objected to the names of idols, Baal, &c. which were joined with these cities. M.

Ver. 40. In it, by means of his descendants. For Machir must have been above 250 years old, if he were still alive. Many children are attributed to Machir and his father, Manasses, who were not their immediate offspring. The latter had only Machir, who survived him; Ezriel was probably a grandson of Machir, as he is styled the son of Galaad. C. xxvi. 31. Jos. xvii. 2. See 1

Par. vii. Adoptive and legal children are often confounded with those who are really born of a person, as also those places which are inhabited by his posterity. C.

Ver. 41. Jair was born of Segub, the son of Esron, by a daughter of Machir, 1

Par. i. 21. He did not remain in the tribe of Juda, but dwelt in that of his mother, (C.) or perhaps he married a descendant of Machir, and obtained these villages. Seld. Suc. c. xviii. --- Havoth, means "a circle of cabins or shepherds'

huts," in Arabic. Bochart.

Ver. 42. Canath. This town is reckoned among those of Jair, (1 Par. ii. 23,) either because Nobe conquered it under his banners, or because it fell to the share of Jair, after the death of Nobe. C.

NUMBERS 33

CHAPTER XXXIII.

Ver. 1. The mansions. These mansions, or journeys of the children of Israel from Egypt to the land of promise, were figures, according to the Fathers, of the steps and degrees by which Christians, leaving sin, are to advance from virtue to virtue, till they come to the heavenly mansions, after this life, to see and enjoy God. Ch. --- Conduct. Lit. "hand." Aaron died before they came to the last of these 42 stations, or encampments. H. --- The observance of the law, and the true worship of God, can alone insure us eternal happiness, and enable us to sing Holy, &c. S.

Jer. ep. ad Fab. W.

Ver. 2. Which. Heb. "and Moses wrote down their departure and their marches, by the commandment of the Lord; and these are their journeys, according to their going out." These are the places of any note in that wide and dreary desert, near which the Israelites passed. All the encampments are not intended to be specified. The people marched on slowly, and sought for pasturage, with all diligence. The names of these more remarkable places, have been so differently pronounced, that many of them have been greatly confounded; (C.) and interpreters vary so much in their situation, that nothing can be decided with certainty. H.

Ver. 3. Ramesses, a city of great note, about 60 miles from the Red Sea. Ex. i.

11. C.

Ver. 4. Gods. Their idols were thrown down. S. Jer. ep. 127. See Ex. xii. 12. M.

Ver. 6. Soccoth, the second station. H. --- Etham. Sept. "Butham," the Butum of Herodotus, (ii.

75,) situated in a plain.

Ver. 7. Beelsephon; perhaps the city of Clysma, or Colzan, where the Hebrews crossed the sea.

Ver. 8. Etham, or Sur. Ex. xv. 22. --- Mara, 60 miles to the south of the Red Sea.

C.

Ver. 9. Elim. "The wood of palm-trees, five days' journey from Jericho." Strabo.

See Ex. xv.

Ver. 10. Red Sea. This encampment is not specified before. C. --- It was the seventh in order.

H.

Ver. 11. Sin. Farther from the promised land than that of Tsin, (C. xx. 1,) or Cades-barne.

Ver. 12. Daphca. Sept. and Eusebius read, Raphca; (C.) D and R, in Hebrew, are easily confounded. H. --- This encampment is passed over in Exodus, as well as the following at Alus.

Ver. 14. Raphidim and Sinai. See Ex. xvii. and xix. 1.

Ver. 16. Lust. After three days' journey, passing by the station of burning. C. x.

33. xi. 3.

Ver. 17. Haseroth, near Cades-barne, the same as Aserim, ("the unwall'd towns" of the Heveans, extending as far as Gaza,) or Asor, called afterwards Esron, on the south of Chanaan. Jos. xi. 10.

Moses does not specify here the memorable encampment at Cades-barne, where the Israelites arrived, after 11 days' march from Horeb. Deut. i. 2. 19. It was not far from Asor, on the frontiers of Idumea, (C.) in the desert of Pharan.

C. xiii. 1.

Ver. 19. Rethma. The situation of this and the following station, cannot be fixed.

Ver. 21. Lebna. A strong place besieged by Sennacherib, (4 K. xix. 8,) between Cades and Gaza.

Jos. x. 29. The Hebrews encamped a long while about Mount Seir. Deut. ii. 1.

Ver. 22. Ressa was in the same neighbourhood. S. Hirarion converted its inhabitants.

Ver. 24. Arada. Herad, Adar, or Barad, are probably the same place, on the southern limits of Chanaan, four miles from Maceloth, the Malatis of Eusebius.

Ver. 30. Hesmona, or Asemona, a city of the tribe of Juda, towards Egypt. C.

xxxiv. 4.

Ver. 32. Gadgad. These three stations are placed in a different order, Deut. x. 6.

But some word has been transposed, as Aaron died on Mount Hor, when the Hebrews encamped at Mosera, or Moseroth, a second time. C.

Ver. 34. Jetebatha. It may be rendered also "Hills of concupiscence," famous for torrents of water. Deut. x. 7.

Ver. 35. Asiongaber. Some place this station on the Mediterranean, where Strabo fixes the city of Gassion Gaber, the Beto Gabria of Ptolemy. But the Scripture informs us it lay on the Red Sea. 3 K. ix. 16. Cellarius thinks most probably upon the Elanitic gulph, to the east of that of Suez, or Heroopolis, where Josephus maintains Asiongaber or Bernice stood. The Hebrews came to this station from that of Elat. Deut. ii. 8. C.

Ver. 36. Sin, or Tsin. Cades is another name of the same desert. Near the city of Cades-barne, the Hebrews encamped a long while, and had plenty of water; but here they murmured for want of it, and Mary departed this life. C. xx. C.

Ver. 37. Hor, at a place called Mosera. Deut. x. 6. This was the road from Arabia to Chanaan, and the Hebrews attempted to enter by it, but were repulsed by the king of Arad, though they afterwards defeated him at Horma. C. xxi. 3.

Ver. 41. Salmona, where it is thought by some that God sent the fiery serpents.

C. xxi. 6. The Israelites being refused a passage by the Idumeans and Moabites, God orders them to measure back their steps towards Asiongaber, and to go round their territories. C.

Ver. 45. Dibongad, is often called Dibon. Moses observes, (C. xxi.) that the Hebrews passed by or encamped at various places, before they came to this town. It is sometimes attributed to Ruben, and at other times to Gad, being on the confines of both tribes. C.

Ver. 49. Moabites. Here they were deluded by wicked women. C. xxv. H.

From these 42

stations, the Fathers take occasion to shew, how we must advance in a spiritual life. D.

Ver. 52. Pillars. Heb. stones placed on high "to be seen." Sept. "towers of the sentinels." Chal.

"temples, where they adore their idols."

Ver. 53. Land of its old inhabitants, and of the places dedicated to superstitious purposes. H. ---

Heb. "occupy the land." Sept. "drive out the inhabitants, and dwell there."

Ver. 55. Nails. Sept. "goads," &c. by which they will force you in a manner to gratify your curiosity, by an imitation of their idol worship; and thus will prove to you more dangerous, than if you had nails piercing your eyes. See Jos. xxiii.

13. Ezec. xxviii. 24. These abandoned nations must not be spared through a false pity. Deut. xx. 16. C. --- The Israelites, however, proved negligent, and God made use of the remains of these nations to scourge his people, and to train them for war. D.

NUMBERS 34

CHAPTER XXXIV.

Ver. 3. The most salt sea. The lake of Sodom, otherwise called the Dead Sea.

Ch. --- Limits.

These are very properly defined in this place, that the Hebrews may know what nations they ought to destroy. M. --- A line may be drawn from the southern point of the Dead Sea, through Adar, as far as the Nile and the Mediterranean Sea, comprising a part of the desert of Sin, or Zin.

Ver. 4. The Scorpion. A mountain so called, from having a great number of scorpions. Ch. ---

Heb. Hakrabbim. There was a city of the same name, the capital of Acrabathene, (1 Mac. iii. 3,) not far from Petra. --- Senna, a town of the desert of Zin, (C.) or a mountain specified Judg. i. 36.

S. Jerom. --- Adar. Heb. "Hasor Adar." But they seem to be two distinct towns.

Jos. xv. 3. ---

Asemona. See C. xxxiii. 30.

Ver. 5. Egypt. Many suppose the rivulet of Rinocorura is meant. M. --- But it seems more probable that the Nile, the only river of Egypt, or the eastern branch of it, where Pelusium stands, is designated. There is no proof that the former rivulet belonged to Egypt; and though some assert that the Hebrews never dwelt to the west of it, the territory was so barren, that nothing may be said respecting that affair. We find, however, that under Solomon they inhabited as far as the river of Egypt; (1 Par. xiii. 5. 3 K. viii. 65,) and if they had not, God's promise entitled them to that part of the country; as well as to that which extends to the great river Euphrates, though they perhaps never took possession of it. See Gen. xv. 18. Jos. xiii. 3. Pelusium is commonly reckoned the frontier town of Egypt. Ezec. xxx. 15. Stabo xvi. In another place, the promised land extends from Emath to the torrent of Egypt, (1 K. viii. 55,) or of the desert, Amos vi. ult. C.

Ver. 6. Great sea, compared with those of Palestine, which were only like pools or lakes. The Hebrews call every great collection of water, a sea. The Mediterranean bounded the promised land entirely, on the west.

Ver. 7. The most high mountain. Libanus. Ch. --- Heb. "the mountain of the mountain, or of Hor." Some understand Mount Casius, Hermon, Taurus, or Amanus; which last lies on the confines of Cilicia, and hence the Rabbins draw a line by the straits of Gibraltar to Pelusium, so as to comprise all the islands and the waters of the Mediterranean. Selden. Marc. Claus. i. 6. But Grotius denies that the sea can be claimed by any one, nor was it, even for fishing, says he, before the days of Justinian. Jur. ii. 2, 3. C. --- At any rate, Moses here seems to mean the northern limits from the point of the Mediterranean, where Libanus is situated, across the country eastward to Emath, and as far as the village of Enan, v. 9. H.

Ver. 8. Emath. It is of great importance to fix the situation of this city. Some take it to be Antioch, the capital of Syria, on the Orontes. But that was a modern city, founded by Nicanor, and called after his father, Antiochus, and embellished by Callinicus and Epiphanes. Strabo xvi.

--- Others believe it is Epiphania, at the foot of Libanus, on the same river, and a distinct city from Emath Rabba, or "the great," of Amos vi. 2. Josephus i. 7.

(C.) and S. Jerom (in Isai. x.) seem to be of this opinion. M. --- But the city in question was most probably Emesa, of which Amos speaks above. It was also upon the river Orontes, at a small distance to the east of Libanus, on the road to Damascus. This road was the northern boundary. Emesa was perhaps formerly the capital of the country of Soba, (2 Par. viii. 3,) and was taken by Solomon. Reblatha, or Rebla, (v.

11,) was a part of its territory. Theod. in Jer. xxxix. 5. C.

Ver. 9. Enan. Heb. "Hazer Henan." In Ezechiel, (xlvii. 17,) it is called the court of Enon. It may be Gaana, north of Damascus, or rather Inna, placed to the south of that city by Ptolemy.

Ver. 11. Sephama, or Apamea. Targum. --- Rebla. Sept. "Bela, or Asbela." H. ---

S. Jerom understands Antioch, near which was the fountain of Daphnis, or Daphne, a word which is inserted in the Targum, though it be not found in Hebrew. But Antioch did not lie on the eastern borders, and this fountain may be the same place as Enan, v. 9. --- Against. Heb. "on the east side of Ain, or the fountain." C. --- Cenereth. This is the sea of Galilee, illustrated by the miracles of our Lord. Ch. --- The line was not drawn to this lake of Genesareth, or of Tiberias, as it was likewise called, but comprised a large territory lying to the east of it, (C.) and given to the tribes of Manasses, Gad, and Ruben, which inhabited the country east of the Jordan and of the Salt Sea.

H. --- Eastward: the Sept. insinuate, "to the south, leaving the sea of Cenereth on the east." ---

The fountain of Daphnis may probably be that near the Semechonite lake, through which the Jordan runs. Josep. Bel. iv. 1. It may have received the title of Daphnis, from the laurels with which it is adorned, like the suburbs of Antioch. Bonfrere. M. --- It appears that Moses has only in view, the nine tribes for which a provision was not yet made; and their eastern limits extend from Emath, down the Jordan to the Dead Sea, so as to comprise no part to the east of that river, which was already given to their brethren; (see v. 13, 15, 29,) and thus the observation of Calmet, respecting the countries east of Cenereth, will be rather inaccurate, as the line must run through that sea, following the course of the Jordan. These were properly the eastern limits of Chanaan, which country comprised all between Egypt and Idumea, as far as Sidon and Mount Libanus, being bounded by the Jordan on the east. The other three tribes were hemmed in on the north and east by the mountains of Hermon, Basan, Galaad, and Arnon; beyond which, the nations about Damascus, and the descendants of Ammon, Ismael, and Moab dwelt, in Syria and the desert of Arabia, so that the latter country was the eastern boundary of the promised land, taken in its utmost extent. H. --- The respective limits must naturally vary, when we speak of the whole or a part only. D. T.

NUMBERS 35

CHAPTER XXXV.

Ver. 3. Cities, in all forty-eight, with a thousand paces round them. This land belonged to the community: but some built upon it, Jos. xxi. 18. 1 Par. vi. 60.

The burial place for the Levites lay behind it. Drusius. --- In these cities alone, the Levites had houses and gardens of their own; other might live with them, and indeed the cities acknowledged other lords, as Hebron belonged to Caleb, Jos. xiv. 14. The Levites were dispersed throughout the land, that they might instruct the people both by word and by example. Deut. xxxiii. 10. They had a clear revenue without labour of husbandry, equivalent to any two of the other tribes. Abulensis. --- Six of their cities were assigned for places of refuge, as they were the proper judges of the cases, in which murder may be excused, and to remind them that they ought to be very merciful. Hence arose the privileges, granted to some churches, of protecting those who fled to them for an asylum. That none might be hindered from enjoying this benefit, three of these cities were situated on each side of the Jordan, and at equal distances.

Salien.

Ver. 4. Paces. This is equivalent to 2000 cubits, (v. 5,) or a sabbath day's journey. Selden, Jur.

iii. 9. S. Jerom. q. 9. ad algas. Heb. retains the same word, amma, "cubit," in both verses: but some copies of the Sept. Philo, and Josephus, have "2000

cubits," (C.) which Dr. Wall and Kennicott deem to be the original reading. H. ---

Bonfrere would also correct the Hebrew by the Vulgate as a pace among the Greeks consisted of three feet, and a cubit of half that quantity. The geometric pace of the Romans contained five feet, and the sacred cubit of Villalpand half as much; so that 2000 sacred cubits make 1000 geometric paces. Thus the Vulgate is perfectly consistent with itself. M. --- Some imagine that Moses speaks of the common cubit here and of the sacred one, which was doubly as large, v 5. But this is not probable; and the distinction of cubits, (C.) at least in his days, (H.) is very uncertain. Perhaps Moses may first specify the depth of this space of ground from the wall, and afterwards its length, which would be doubly greater.

C. See Sevius on Jos. xxi. q. 8, &c. --- The semidiameter was probably 1000

cubits. D.

Ver. 5. Sea. Heb. simply, "on the west side 2000 cubits, and on the north side 2000 cubits, and the city in the midst. This shall be to them the suburbs of the city."

Ver. 6. Cities. Maimonides pretends, that all forty-eight cities of the Levites were asylums; though only six were bound to receive the fugitive gratis.

Moses had promised a place of refuge, which he now grants. Ex. xxi. 13. The altar and temple enjoyed the like privilege: the latter even till its destruction.

Philo. --- Josephus mentions only six cities of refuge. Those who could not be supposed to have killed a person designedly were not obliged to flee to them; as, on the other hand, the murderer was not permitted to enter, if his malice were notorious, or his negligence extreme. Rabbins ep. Seld. Jur. iv. 2. To be secured at the altar of holocausts, it was necessary to touch the grate. If the judges declared that the person's case was such as the law admitted, he was conducted away, under a strong guard, to one of the cities; or, if he were deemed unworthy, he was put to death, out of the holy place. The altar was commonly the refuge only of priests.

Those who were not of Hebrew extraction, could not claim the rights of an asylum, according to the Rabbins. But the contrary seems to be asserted, v.

15. The roads to the cities of refuge were to be kept in good repair, and in case more than six should be found necessary, three others might be appointed.

Deut. xix. 3. 8. This privilege is founded on the law of nature, which decrees that the life of the innocent man, who has had the misfortune to kill another, should not be taken away.

Other nations extended this right to almost every crime, that the weak might have an opportunity of defending themselves. The sons of Hercules erected for this purpose the altar of mercy, at Athens. Some of the pagan temples could protect even the greatest criminals, as well as the innocent, who might fear oppression. Those of Apollo, at Delphos, of Bacchus, at Ephesus, &c.

were very famous. See Marsham, Chron. sæc. 13. Tiberius found it necessary to recall these privileges among the Greeks, as they were greatly abused.

Tacit. An. iii. 6. But his decree was not much regarded. The Romans had their asylums also, at Naples, &c. where those who had been condemned to die, might be secure. Rome itself was an asylum for all strangers, as S. Aug.

remarks, de C. D. i. The Christian emperors afforded the like privileges to our churches. But some who were guilty of the crimes of adultery, murder, heresy,

&c. were deprived of the benefit.

C. --- Those who fled to the altar among the Jews were first to be purified; (Philo) and if they had committed murder publicly, like Joab, they were dragged away, 3 K. ii. T.

Ver. 12. Kinsman, the nearest relation, who was called the revenger of blood, (v. 25. 27, H.) or the redeemer, because it was his duty to see that justice was done to the deceased. When the person, who had involuntarily committed murder, arrived at the city, he was to make his appearance before the judges of it, and, if they thought his account satisfactory, they admitted him, but upon condition that he should take his trial before the judges and the people of that country where the murder had taken place, (v. 25. Jos. xx. 4. 9, T.) though some think that the judges of the city of refuge, passed sentence. Masius, &c. --- If it proved favourable, he was bound to remain in the city till the death of the high priest, otherwise the relations might kill him as an outlaw; as they might also if he was declared guilty. In case the murder were

voluntary, the judges of the place where it was committed set to demand the criminal. Deut. xix. 11.

Ver. 18. If, &c. Heb. "or he smite him with a wooden weapon, (wherewith he may die,) and he die, he is a murderer: the murderer shall surely be put to death." The two former verses are expressed in the same awful manner, intimating that the weapon must be of such a nature that it might easily give a mortal wound, and also that the effect really followed. In these cases, if the person could not clear himself, no refuge or reprieve was allowed. H. --- But the deceased must have been killed upon the spot, otherwise the person who struck him could only be required to pay a fine. Ex. xxi. 19. M.

Ver. 19. Him, with impunity. If the judges have passed sentence, he shall be obliged to put it in execution, v. 21. 31. S. Aug. q. 65. E. --- The laws of Athens required also that a relation should put the murderer to death, though the deceased were even of servile condition. Demost. --- Those of Rome condemned the involuntary manslayer to retire for a year, and afterwards to appease some one of the relations, and to offer the sacrifices, and submit to the usual purifications. Even at the present day, the Persians and Arabs deliver the murderer to be slain by the kinsmen of the deceased, after sentence has been passed by the judges.

Ver. 21. Kill him. It seems, when the case was evident, he was not only permitted, but commanded to punish the criminal. Bonfrere. Deut. xix. 12. M.

Ver. 25. Delivered. Heb. "the multitude shall deliver the slayer." It seems the judges pronounced sentence, according to the votes of the people assembled; (C.) or the plurality of voices among the 21 judges decided the matter. Grot. H.

--- High priest. This mystically signified that our deliverance was to be effected by the death of Christ, the high priest and the anointed of God.

Ch. --- He rescued us from the hand of the revenger, the devil. Theod. q. 50. 51.

--- Before his death, the way of our true country was not open, nor secure. S.

Greg. hom 6. in Ezech. W. --- By this law, Moses shewed a horror for murder, and the respect due to the person of the high priest, during whose life even the involuntary murderer was obliged to keep himself retired in a city of refuge.

Masius. --- At the death of the pontiff, all Israel put on mourning, so that private injuries were to be forgotten, when the public had such cause for sorrow; and in the mean time the vengeance of kinsmen would relent. Maimon. More. iii. 40.

--- Murder was punished by the Greeks, in the days of Homer, with banishment, though sometimes this was remitted by the relations, for a sum of money. Iliad ix. C.

Ver. 27. Him. Custom explained this law, as giving leave to any person to inflict the punishment upon the wandering murderer, though the relation seem only to be specified. Grot. --- Some think, that to kill such a person was still criminal in the sight of God. But others believe that, as he had forfeited the privilege of an asylum, by absenting himself from it, (C.) the law subjected him to the same rigour with which he might have been treated before he came thither; (v. 19. H.) and provided proper moderation were observed, and malicious revenge avoided, no guilt would attach to him who executed the implied sentence of death. The Jews observe, that God allows us to revenge another sooner than ourselves, as there is less danger of excess or of delusion. C.

Ver. 30. Man. A person might be tried on such evidence. Deut. xix. 15.

Ver. 32. Cities. Heb. "you shall take no money to retire to a city of refuge, to return into his own country, till the death of the priest." The Sept. supply, "you shall take no redemption money, to permit (a voluntary murderer) to flee into a city of refuge, (nor of an involuntary one,) to return,"

&c. Grotius. --- The banished, may refer to people of the former description, who had gone away to screen themselves from persecution. But they could never be allowed to inhabit the country any more. Their presence would seem to defile it. H. --- "You shall not take money of him who has fled to a city of refuge, to suffer him to return home." Chaldee.

Ver. 33. Defile not. To inspire a greater horror for murder the earth was represented as defiled by blood, and only to be purified by the death of the criminal. Without shedding of blood, there is no remission. Heb. ix. 22. H. ---

On the same principle, our churches, &c. are deemed profane when murder, or some great indecencies, have been committed in them, so that they require a fresh consecration. C.

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CHAPTER XXXVI.

Ver. 1. Galaad. The descendants of Machir, who were settled in Galaad, were particularly interested, in knowing how their female relations of the house of Salphaad, were to dispose of their fortunes, which God had allowed them.

They knew that, by the law, their husbands would obtain possession; and if those husbands should be of another tribe, part of the land allotted to Manasses might be lost. See C. xxvii. and Jos. xvii. 1. 3.

Ver. 4. That is, an explanation of the jubilee, added by S. Jerom, who gives the sense of the Heb.

though not the very words. --- Lots. Heb. "when the jubilee of the children of Israel is come, then shall their inheritance be added to that of the tribe in which they are received; so shall their inheritance be taken away from the inheritance of the tribe of our fathers." H.

Ver. 6. Tribe. Heb. adds family also: for heiresses were obliged to marry in their own family, to prevent the confusion of the inheritances. If they had a mind to renounce their right, they were at liberty to marry where they pleased. C. ---

The nearest relations, who chose to receive their land, were under an obligation of marrying them. Ruth iv. 6. H. --- A similar law prevailed at Athens.

Ver. 7. Wives. Heb. "shall keep to the inheritance of the tribe of his fathers."

Those who marry heiresses must be of the same family: but others may take wives from any of the tribes of Israel, as the most holy did without scruple. S.

Jerom in Jer. xxxii. T. E. --- The Rabbins extend this law to all, with the Vulgate: but only during the time that the land of Chanaan remained undivided. Seld.

Succ. c. xviii.

Ver. 8. Women. Heb. "every daughter that possesseth an inheritance...shall be wife to one of the family of the tribe of her father." Commonly the females were debarred from inheriting land, when they had any brothers. The Levites were not concerned in these regulations, as they had no inheritance; and hence, we need not be surprised to find that S. Elizabeth, of the daughters of Aaron, (Luc.

i. 26,) was related to the blessed Virgin, who was of the family of David. The mother of S. Elizabeth might be of the tribe of Juda; or a maternal ancestor of the blessed Virgin might spring from the tribe of Levi. C. --- Tradition determined the lawfulness of such marriages, and in this case, S. Augustine (Consens. Ev. ii. 23) admires the providence of God, in causing his beloved Son, the great anointed, to be born both of the regal and priestly tribes, in which an unction was required, before the priests and kings were put in possession of their respective offices. Thus Christ was both priest and king, and such were anointed in the law of Moses. W.

Ver. 11. Father. They married their cousin-germans. The original is rather undecisive, as Dod may signify, "an uncle, great uncle, or cousin;" and a son, in Scripture, is often put for any descendant. The marriages of cousins were not expressly forbidden by the law, and if they had, they might have been dispensed with on this occasion, as well as when a brother died without issue.

C. --- Claudius was the first of the Romans who obtained leave of the senate to marry his brother's daughter. Sueton. D.